SOVEREIGN CALL ORIGINS

Campaign Screenplay

Based on the novel by
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PROLOGUE

1 EXT. UNIDENTIFIED BATTLEFIELD - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-PRO-CS01

Black. A breath arrives too close to the ear. A pinpoint of ethereal light strikes a consuming void.

UNIDENTIFIED VOICE (V.O.)
The Reach is groaning...

Teeth close on a breastplate. The soldier's face remains out of view.

UNIDENTIFIED VOICE (V.O.)
Your armies... they fall...

Radiant steel passes through black flesh and white bone.

UNIDENTIFIED VOICE (V.O.)
The echo weeps...

Crimson and purple blood meet on barren stone. Several armored bodies collapse at different distances.

UNIDENTIFIED VOICE (V.O.)
The carnage you wreak... Will not stop...

The star swells. Talons take another soldier as charging light overtakes the horizon.

UNIDENTIFIED VOICE (V.O.)
The Eclipse of life... They will call you King...

An unidentified figure raises a blade. The frame whites out before any face becomes legible.

UNIDENTIFIED VOICE (V.O.)
But you shall die a beggar...

The sun cracks and splinters. The pulse strikes every silhouette equally.

UNIDENTIFIED VOICE (V.O.)
The end is nigh... My King...

A beat of white silence. Cut to the endless amber evening above Ianis.

SCOR 01 THE MANTLE

2 INT./EXT. TELEMY / CROWNWATCH APPROACH - ETERNAL EVENING
SCOR-01-CS01

The scorched Telemy shudders through Ianis's amber evening. Tarrik rises, secures Cinderline, and leaves the cracked helm on the bench.

PILOT
High Centurion, we are beginning our final approach to Crownwatch.

LYESSA
Try not to look so eager.

TARRIK
We have survived most of our voyages together.

LYESSA
Most. A comforting record.

She folds the radiant dagger and places a hand on his shoulder plate.

LYESSA
This summons is unprecedented. Whatever happens inside Crownwatch, we will leave differently than we entered.

TARRIK
My soldiers are still on Proper, Men who held the line because I told them it would matter. Some of them are lying in Reformation plasma, and I am here to receive a wreath.

LYESSA
You did not order the ceremony.

TARRIK
I accepted it.

LYESSA
Then let them have the ceremony. Let them place the wreath and tell themselves they made you. You know better.

The ramp lowers. Tarrik kneels to touch the ancient platform stone, then rises. The construct waits across the path.

CONSTRUCT
I am assigned to escort you to the Ceremonial Annex, where you shall receive commendation for valor in the Dominion Crusades. Do you accept your escort?

TARRIK
Glory.

Tarrik walks through merchants, veterans, devotional wares and frightened onlookers. A beggar collides with the construct, falls, and palms a calf plate.

BEGGAR
I am sorry, Your Glory. I did not mean to interrupt your important excursion. Please forgive me.

Lyessa clears him from the path. Tarrik sees bronze vanish beneath grasscloth and deliberately says nothing to the escort.

LYESSA
You saw that.

TARRIK
It was not mine.

LYESSA
Nor was it his.

TARRIK
He may need it more.

The modest Good King statue extends a hand toward people; surrounding conquerors tower above it. Inside, a mural divides a star. Five unfinished circles mark a sealed lower stair.

CONSTRUCT
Restricted reliquary access.

TARRIK
I did not ask.

CONSTRUCT
Your pace deviated.

LYESSA
Try not to offend the floor plan.

Lyessa gives him a private smile. The construct guides Tarrik toward the Ceremonial Annex doors.

3 INT. CROWNWATCH - CEREMONIAL ANNEX - ETERNAL EVENING
SCOR-01-CS02

CONSTRUCT
High Centurion Tarrik Walcur and Special Agent Lyessa Caedryn, you have arrived at the Ceremonial Annex. Emperor Caelus Virel will conduct the proceedings.

TARRIK
The Emperor is officiating?

CONSTRUCT
Correct.

Lyessa brushes a loose auburn strand from Tarrik's forehead.

LYESSA
Whatever happens in there, stand straight.

The doors open. The fanfare stops. Thousands watch the elevated walk. Lyessa moves to the dais side; Tarrik kneels before the gold-armored Emperor.

CAELUS
High Centurion Tarrik Walcur. This honor is no token, and your deeds are not forgotten. Long have I watched and waited for the day you would kneel before me in this chamber. Long have I trusted that you would carry the mantle of our Dominion across campaign and conquest. Today, that faith is rewarded.

Fists strike breastplates. Proper burns above the dais.

CAELUS
The quelling of the insurrection on Proper.

Resiil's mines replace it. Tarrik sees civilians in tunnels behind the glorious rendering.

CAELUS
The reclamation of Resiil's sacred mines.

The projection becomes Tarrik's small family house. His breath catches; Lyessa's hand tightens around Egdredil.

CAELUS
The sacrifice of blood and kin in our long war against the Reformation.

Contempt roars from the galleries. Caelus raises a hand and the room obeys.

CAELUS
Son of steel, the mantle that follows is not light. Today, you become...

Tarrik lifts his face. Hold the space between their eyes.

CAELUS
My heir.

No cheer has time to begin. A blue line strikes Caelus's shoulder. Blood scatters over gold. He falls; the crown spins once across marble. Praetorians ignite shields.

TARRIK
My Emperor!

He rises with Velkorran. Lyessa has Egdredil raised toward the upper columns.

LYESSA
There.

An icy-blue distortion slips between the columns. Freeze on the final blue edge. Cut to Selene.

4 INT./EXT. CROWNWATCH - UPPER CORRIDOR AND BALCONY - ETERNAL EVENING
SCOR-01-CS03

ON SCREEN:
MOMENTS EARLIER

Selene lowers her viewmaker in the empty upper corridor.

SELENE
The passage is clear.

NEURAL HANDLER
You're close, Do not give yourself away. And Selene... order is eternal.

SELENE
Order is eternal.

Selene cloaks, disrupts the watchers, intercepts the service lift, and fires two entryway shots. At the balcony rail her cloak fails; she drops prone.

ON SCREEN:
TARGET: EMPEROR CAELUS VIREL
STATUS: ACTIVE
ASSIGNMENT: TERMINATION

Footsteps. Selene rolls and draws Axiom. Lyric raises both hands, wearing silver armor, crowned-flame shoulder insignia and an authorization disk.

LYRIC
Relax, It's me.

SELENE
You are supposed to be securing the Telemy.

LYRIC
The ship is ready and impatient. I refused to let you witness history alone.

SELENE
This is not a spectacle.

LYRIC
History usually is from the balcony.

SELENE
Return to the ship.

LYRIC
In a moment.

SELENE
That was not a suggestion.

LYRIC
And yet I continue to interpret it creatively.

Selene rematerializes Staccato. Lyric watches the army below; purple veins show in her eyes and pale braid. A glimpse of hatred displaces the joke.

The young soldier and dark-haired woman enter the central walkway. Selene's viewmaker resolves him before her scope returns to Caelus.

ON SCREEN:
TARRIK WALCUR
DOMINION HIGH CENTURION
CRUSADE COMMAND

LYRIC
Caelus's favorite pet.

SELENE
Our distraction.

PALACE GUARD
Downed guard on level eight!

SECOND PALACE GUARD
Seal the western corridor.

SELENE
Fix it, Return to the ship when it is done.

LYRIC
Of course.

Lyric disappears. Selene steadies Staccato on Caelus's heart.

CAELUS
Today, you become... My heir.

Selene's breathing catches. Tarrik's kneeling figure gains terrible strategic meaning. Her thought sounds privately, unheard by the room.

SELENE (V.O.)
Promotion. Not succession. Did Voss know?

The trigger breaks while doubt is still forming; reticle shifts one degree. Blue Echo strikes the shoulder. Shields close around Caelus.

SELENE
This was not a coronation.

She compresses Staccato, cloaks and runs. At the produce-crate junction Lyric crouches under fire with a new compressed cylinder at her lower back. Its contents remain concealed.

LYRIC
A little help, Keeper?

SELENE
King damn you, Lyric.

Selene and Lyric bring down three enforcers with Verity and covering fire. Their escape radio resumes.

SELENE
Move. Eastern platform.

LYRIC
I know where the ship is.

SELENE
You were supposed to be with it.

LYRIC
And yet here we both are.

Doors seal behind them; broken window and exposed terrace funnel the escape toward the active Telemy. Selene's cloak fails. A heavy gunner erupts into the doorway.

5 INT./EXT. CROWNWATCH - EASTERN SERVICE ROUTE - ETERNAL EVENING
SCOR-01-CS04

The heavy gunner falls; smoke lifts from Verity. Lyric's firing position is empty.

SELENE
Lyric?

Shielded enforcers flood the far passage. Selene backs toward the platform, still searching instead of celebrating victory.

SELENE
Lyric!

Her cloak folds around her. She runs up the Telemy ramp and watches the narrowing gap.

SELENE
Lyric!

The ramp seals without silver armor aboard. Cut back to Tarrik forcing through panicked friendly personnel. At the balcony approach he and Lyessa find throat-cut and visor-shot enforcers beneath dead watchers.

LYESSA
Reformation.

TARRIK
Why wound him?

LYESSA
Perhaps she missed.

TARRIK
After crossing every defense in Ianis?

LYESSA
We can question her after we catch her.

They continue through blue cuts and amber craters. A wounded enforcer lies beside the shattered corridor.

WOUNDED ENFORCER
Platform, They went toward the eastern platform.

TARRIK
They?

WOUNDED ENFORCER
Blue armor. Another one in Dominion silver.

At the final crater Lyessa fires Egdredil into the Telemy's left engine. Tarrik jumps the crater, rolls and sights the exposed coolant core. Beyond the engine, market families come into focus.

LYESSA
Tarrik, fire!

Hold his trigger finger against the engine and a child pointing up from the terrace.

LYESSA
Tarrik!

He lowers Cinderline. The Telemy escapes between bronze towers. Friendly bolts fade behind it.

LYESSA
Why the loehs did you not shoot?

TARRIK
I could not bring it down without hitting the market.

LYESSA
You had the engine.

TARRIK
And everyone behind it.

A thin ringing displaces the alarms. Ianis's turning rings stretch; ceremonial echoes become indistinct fragments. No named entity is shown.

UNIDENTIFIED VOICE (V.O.)
The Reach is groaning.

TARRIK
The Reach is groaning?

Lyessa's hand on cheek and shoulder snaps reality back.

LYESSA
You were gone. Did the blast hit you?

TARRIK
No.

LYESSA
Then what happened?

TARRIK
I heard something.

LYESSA
What?

TARRIK
Nothing.

She does not believe him. A command light interrupts the moment.

LYESSA
The War Council has summoned us. Come on.

Camera settles behind Tarrik. The route now leads through treatment crews toward the Atrium elevator.

6 INT. CROWNWATCH - ATRIUM OF COMMAND - ETERNAL EVENING
SCOR-01-CS05

Ranking officers make room in the elevator without speaking. Tarrik keeps his eyes on the sealed doors.

TARRIK
Did you know?

LYESSA
About the succession? No.

TARRIK
Why would Caelus announce it without telling the Council?

LYESSA
Because he is the Emperor.

Doors reveal a war table crowded with retaliation demands. Caelus stands crowned, shoulder bandaged gold.

CAELUS
I want answers.

TARRIK
The assassin escaped in a stolen Telemy. Lyessa damaged its engine before it cleared Crownwatch. If the vessel attempts another slipjump--

CAELUS
Not the assassin. Where is the Crownmark?

DAYNA
The attack concealed a second breach. During the evacuation of the annex, a lone operative entered the lower reliquary and removed the Crownmark of Ianis.

TARRIK
The reliquary was sealed.

DAYNA
The intruder carried Dominion authorization.

MINISTER
The theft can be contained, The attempt on Your Glory's life cannot. If the Reach learns Reformation agents penetrated the heart of the capital, our governors will question our strength. We must establish the public account before--

A solar spear appears in Caelus's hand. He buries it in the minister's console, spraying molten bronze but killing no one.

CAELUS
Leave us.

The Council departs. Lyessa gives Tarrik a small nod before following. Caelus sinks into the throne and touches the bandage.

CAELUS
Do you know the Crownmark, Tarrik?

TARRIK
A relic of the Disappeared King, inherited from the Sundering. Dominion tradition calls it a map of his final path.

CAELUS
And its significance?

TARRIK
Divine right to rule.

Caelus descends and rests a hand where Tarrik's father once touched his shoulder.

CAELUS
I am glad you survived, dear boy.

TARRIK
Why me? You have ruled for centuries. There are generals with greater victories, ministers born to noble houses, warlords who have served you longer than I have lived.

CAELUS
The Dominion is strong enough to conquer, That is not the same as being strong enough to endure. Order is never inherited, Tarrik. It is imposed. Every generation must win it again. The men who stood around this table know how to inherit power. You know how to make soldiers trust it. I watched you become an instrument capable of carrying my purpose beyond my life.

The word instrument lands. Caelus lifts Tarrik's chin and ignites five unfinished circles across the Reach map.

CAELUS
The Crownmark of Ianis is one of five, Read together, they are believed to reveal the King's Road, the course he traveled before he forsook the Reach. The oldest covenant promises that whoever reaches the road's end will receive his final inheritance.

TARRIK
What inheritance?

CAELUS
No surviving record names it. Some believed the King left a weapon capable of ending all war. Others imagined a throne from which every current of Echo could be commanded. This is your inheritance. Complete the road, and your claim will rest upon more than my declaration. It will rest upon the King's own judgment.

Gold pulses over Neon Veil.

CAELUS
Our next Crownmark is held by a criminal called Dead Hand. Recover the five Crownmarks, my heir. Begin on Neon Veil. And bring me the assassin.

TARRIK
If it becomes a choice?

CAELUS
Bring the assassin alive if you can. But do not return to Crownwatch without the relic.

TARRIK
Glory to the Emperor.

Transition to the ground-floor hall with repairs and casualties continuing behind it. Lyessa crosses from the pillar and embraces him; he slowly holds her back.

LYESSA
What did he say?

TARRIK
He wants all five Crownmarks.
Beginning with one held by Dead
Hand on Neon Veil.

LYESSA
Then we are in a race.

TARRIK
For the Crownmarks?

LYESSA
For your throne.

Hold on Tarrik's unresolved reaction. Cut to black.

SCOR 02 THE REAL TARGET

7 INT./EXT. TELEMY / MESTRIA LANDING PLATFORM - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-02-CS01

Amber warnings crowd the controls. Selene forces the shuddering Telemy level.

CONSOLE
Coolant line compromised, Engine temperature exceeds operational threshold. Estimated slipjump capacity: one.

SELENE
One is enough.

She enters Mestria coordinates and inserts the Reformation signatory beacon beneath the transponder. Blue clearance overrides Dominion identity. Navigation confirms. Six hours pass.

On the commons bench she studies the empty ramp. No flashback reveals Lyric's extraction. Her fist strikes the armrest.

SELENE
Why couldn't she stay with the loehsing ship?

Command strip, gauntlets and plates enter the vaporizer in order. Water runs red, then clear. Selene touches the bruise beside her temple, wipes her wet lashes, and sleeps curled on the hard bench in her undersuit.

CONSOLE
Automatic course to Mestria complete.

She wakes reaching for a weapon, remembers, and rebuilds her armor. The city below is white circles, gardens, controlled lanes and cool illumination. Maintenance drones surround the stained gunship before its ramp has fully lowered.

SELENE
Home.

Selene walks the civic route. Citizens do not kneel. Tharne's neural call interrupts beside the Senate Hall.

THARNE
Keeper Veyne?

SELENE
Go ahead.

THARNE
Glad to have you back, ma'am. Truly. Chancellor Voss summoned me when she received your clearance signature. We're waiting in her office. Are you close?

SELENE
Almost there. Sit tight.

A drone erases a fleck of Dominion ash beneath her boot. She enters the transport column.

SELENE
Chancellor's level.

TRANSPORT SYSTEM
Authorization accepted.

The column rises with the city's ordered terraces below, arriving at the office corridor.

8 INT. MESTRIA - CHANCELLOR'S OFFICE - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-02-CS02

Voss turns from the capital window. Selene remains standing before the desk; Tharne is eager beside the door.

VOSS
Your efficiency will be remembered.

SELENE
The mission failed, Your Grace. Emperor Caelus remains alive. I failed.

VOSS
The operation was a qualified success. Caelus's death would have improved the outcome, but we designed the operation to succeed even if he survived.

SELENE
Caelus was the objective.

VOSS
He was one objective. This was the other.

Lyric pushes away from the far wall in silver armor.

LYRIC
Hey there, Sel.

Selene cannot move. Let the relief hurt before she names it.

SELENE
I left you.

LYRIC
You extracted when you were supposed to.

SELENE
I believed you were dead.

LYRIC
I know.

VOSS
Lyric's route required a separate extraction. Your pursuit drew Crownwatch's security east while she entered the lower reliquary. A cleared courier skiff was staged beneath the western service shelf.

Lyric sets the cylinder on the desk. Gold casing unfolds around five black-gold points and a white core.

SELENE
You knew.

LYRIC
Yes.

SELENE
You used my ignorance as cover.

VOSS
We protected the separation of objectives, Had you known, your attention would have divided. You would have attempted to preserve both the assassination and Lyric's extraction.

LYRIC
I did not enjoy lying to you.

SELENE
You did it anyway.

LYRIC
I followed the plan.

SELENE
That should have been my decision. They believe it reveals the road taken by the King before the Sundering.

VOSS
And that whoever unifies all five will inherit his authority over the Reach.

LYRIC
A bedtime story with a body count.

SELENE
If it is only a story, why did we kill for it?

VOSS
Because belief has operational consequences. The Dominion would use the Crownmarks to sanctify another age of conquest. And because the relic may contain knowledge neither civilization has recovered. We will complete the King's Road first. Whatever waits at its end will not belong to bloodline, spectacle, or the obedience of frightened worlds. We will study it. Understand it. Eternal order, Selene. A renewed Age of Radiance constructed from what is true.

Selene looks from the core's reflection in Voss's eyes to the frozen survey globe Lyric activates.

LYRIC
I extracted the Dominion's survey with the relic, Most of it is historical speculation. One lead appears in every surviving analysis.

VOSS
Caerion II, Beneath the northern ice. The three of you will leave as soon as a ship is prepared. Selene will command. Lyric will provide access. Tharne will authenticate the survey and isolate the probable site.

SELENE
The Emperor named an heir during the ceremony. Tarrik Walcur. Caelus altered the event without public notice to make the declaration. Walcur will be dispatched when they understand what was taken.

VOSS
Then do not allow him to change the next one, If Walcur enters your path, resolve him.

SELENE
Yes, Your Grace.

Selene turns without answering Lyric's farewell. Tharne follows into the transport column; the system continues quietly beyond the glass.

THARNE
Congratulations, Keeper, An impossible operation, and you completed it.

SELENE
Yes, Successful.

Her reflection descends in perfect order. The word does not reassure her.

SCOR 03 ASK CAELUS / SCARS

9 INT. GY SUPREMACY - PRIVATE DORM - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-03-CS01

Four days after Crownwatch.

Verelion turns beneath the viewport. Lyessa pulls Tarrik into the dorm and kisses him as the door seals. Armor settles beside the bunk; camera stays on their faces and hands.

TARRIK
I thought I had lost you.

LYESSA
You will have to try harder than that.

TARRIK
I am serious.

LYESSA
So am I.

She rests her forehead against his. Her fingers tighten behind his neck.

LYESSA
I love you.

He becomes still. Four days of imposed identity loosen in a breath.

TARRIK
I love you too.

Dissolve forward within the same private respite. Lyessa traces the lance scar under his collarbone.

LYESSA
My Emperor.

TARRIK
Do not call me that.

LYESSA
There must be an empress somewhere in this grand destiny of yours.

Her teasing smile fades as she realizes he has heard a real question.

TARRIK
Is that what you want?

LYESSA
I want what you were always meant to become.

TARRIK
Do you want me, Lyessa, or the throne?

LYESSA
I wanted you when you were a blood-soaked cadet who thought polishing armor was beneath him, I wanted you before you had a command. Before Caelus ever spoke the word heir.

She places her palm over his heart instead of moving away.

LYESSA
But I also know what you are capable of. I will not apologize for believing the Reach would be stronger beneath your hand.

TARRIK
And if I do not want it?

LYESSA
You will.

They both hear the certainty. Her next line softens.

LYESSA
You are afraid.

TARRIK
The assassin fired when Caelus named me.

LYESSA
Then she feared what the name would make you.

TARRIK
Or she knew something I do not.

For once Lyessa has no answer. Ship machinery returns to the foreground.

SHIP ANNOUNCEMENT
Attention. Final approach to Verelion begins in thirty minutes. Mission personnel report to deployment stations.

She rises and rebuilds the soldier: webbing, plates, controlled braid.

TARRIK
When this is over...

LYESSA
When this is over, you can ask me properly.

She fastens the Dominion insignia; camera settles behind Tarrik with a route toward the hangar.

10 INT. GY SUPREMACY - CENTRAL HANGAR - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-03-CS02

Echo charges cross the hangar beneath old crimson banners. The gray civilian freighter looks forgettable beside the gunships. Cross approaches from behind.

CROSS
That would be yours. Hayden Cross, Intelligence handler. His Glory assigned me to the Crownmark campaign as your liaison.

Lyessa stiffens, one hand near compressed Egdredil.

CROSS
Agent Caedryn.

LYESSA
Cross.

TARRIK
You know each other.

CROSS
We served in adjacent operations.

LYESSA
That is one interpretation.

Cross raises his command strip. Caelus's personal signet glows with unrestricted authority.

CROSS
The Emperor anticipated your caution, My presence reflects the importance of the mission, not a lack of confidence.

TARRIK
A reassurance that usually means the opposite.

The hangar doors split. Rain lashes the grav barrier; Neon Veil burns magenta below.

CROSS
Its registry is accepted by the major syndicates. Your briefing is loaded into navigation. Dominion armor stays aboard.

TARRIK
No enforcers?

CROSS
The Veil tolerates our presence because it believes this is routine intelligence. If its syndicates learn you are pursuing a Crownmark, every mercenary, government, and cult within four systems will join the search.

TARRIK
And Dominion authority?

CROSS
Exists wherever our enforcers are standing. The Reformation uses a similar definition. In Neon Veil, they often stand across the same street.

TARRIK
What happened between you and Lyessa?

CROSS
Ask me after you recover the Crownmark.

Cross leaves them beside the freighter.

TARRIK
He is not coming?

LYESSA
Cross prefers other people to bleed through his intelligence.

TARRIK
That sounded personal.

LYESSA
It was meant to.

She boards before he can press. Transition to Tarrik on Neon Veil street in poncho and concealed tactical kit, Lyessa already taking overwatch.

11 INT./EXT. NEON VEIL - AVENUE AND DUPLEX - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-03-CS03

A hooded courier waits beneath a failing pharmacy sign. A broken red hand flickers through encryption on his bag.

LYESSA
There.

TARRIK
Dead Hand.

LYESSA
Or bait.

The courier looks directly at Tarrik and runs.

TARRIK
Bait.

Tarrik chases the courier through crowd and alley. Lyessa tracks from rooftops, using a suit-assisted jump and tractor spike.

LYESSA
Lost sight, Moving. Immediate left. Courtyard.

The black-and-red duplex encloses a rocking chair under rain. The courier vanishes inside.

TARRIK
Can you see through the walls?

LYESSA
Something is scattering the scan.

Tarrik searches past ammunition, sorted currencies and spent Dominion rounds. At the kitchen island he inspects a perfectly white paper, scanning it without detecting poison or transmitter.

ON SCREEN:
ASK CAELUS ABOUT THE CAULDRON, BOY.

TARRIK
Lyessa.

LYESSA
What is it?

He sends the image. Her breathing stops. Silence.

TARRIK
Do you know what it means? Lyessa.

LYESSA
No.

TARRIK
Dominion records place Dead Hand at Righteous IV. Not Cauldron. The official account says the Reformation destroyed a Dominion industrial colony. Why would Dead Hand tell me to ask the Emperor?

LYESSA
I don't know.

TARRIK
Cross does.

LYESSA
Tarrik, leave the house.

Red timers awaken beneath kitchen counters, wall panel and door.

TARRIK
Charges.

LYESSA
Move!

Tarrik turns, but ringing bends amber light. His legs stop obeying; the Wasp drops in his hand without firing.

TARRIK
Loehs. Not now.

LYESSA
Tarrik!

She drops toward courtyard. Familiar memories echo as indistinct sound, then an ancient woman's voice comes from nearer than thought.

UNIDENTIFIED VOICE (V.O.)
The Echo weeps.

White consumes the kitchen; paper slips from his fingers. Timers hit zero. The duplex detonates in fire and amber plasma. Lyessa reaches porch and is hurled backward.

LYESSA
Tarrik!

Cut to rain hissing against burning wreckage. Tarrik's point of view sinks into mud.

12 EXT. NEON VEIL - BURNING DUPLEX RUINS - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-03-CS04

Tarrik rises on forearms in mud. Orange fractures fade from his failing shield. A rod pins the muscle below his left knee. Lyessa drops beside him through smoke.

LYESSA
Look at me. I'm here, I'm getting you out.

Her first pull sends pain through him.

TARRIK
Stop!

She sees the rod. Red suit channels ignite as she lifts both beams clear. Tarrik crawls; she drags him beyond the foundation.

CROSS
Walcur, respond.

LYESSA
Safehouse was rigged. Walcur has a penetrating wound below the left knee. Severe blood loss. Shield critical.

CROSS
Extraction inbound. Stabilize him and hold position.

Metal scrapes beneath the ruined floor. A dull red glow rises from below.

LYESSA
Something survived the blast.

CROSS
Withdraw immediately.

LYESSA
You know what's here.

CROSS
Do not investigate the structure. Get Walcur out of the courtyard.

She seals an ameliorating patch around the entry wound.

CROSS
Leave the object in place.

LYESSA
Bring me a surgeon in ten seconds. No? Then be quiet. Tarrik. Stay awake.

TARRIK
I am awake.

LYESSA
You are performing a poor imitation.

She folds cloth into his hand and prepares the second patch beneath his calf.

LYESSA
Bite.

Eyes meet. She pulls the rod; his scream dies in cloth. The second patch clamps torn tissue. Green rings align vessels; blood loss slows, but the ruined muscle remains visibly wounded.

LYESSA
Where are you?

TARRIK
Verelion.

LYESSA
With whom?

TARRIK
You.

Her breath breaks. She kisses him once, hard with fear, and rests her forehead against his.

LYESSA
Stay that way.

An impact shakes the ruins. He catches her wrist before she turns.

TARRIK
You knew what Cauldron meant.

LYESSA
Not here.

TARRIK
You lied to me.

LYESSA
I am keeping you alive.

TARRIK
Those are not the same answer.

The glow beneath the house surges. Both turn toward the cellar.

13 EXT. NEON VEIL - DUPLEX COURTYARD - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-03-CS05

A mechanical voice enters both neural laces before the wide hat clears the cellar.

DEAD HAND
No, They are not.

Brown trench coat opens over black steel and scar tissue. Both mechanical gauntlets carry red-plasma revolvers; his human mouth stays closed.

DEAD HAND
Unlike those who raised you, I refused the order.

CROSS
Walcur, withdraw.

DEAD HAND
Still listening, Hayden?

Cross's channel falls silent.

TARRIK
What order?

DEAD HAND
Ask your companion why Cauldron still follows her into sleep.

Lyessa fires before he can answer more. Red plasma tears steaming furrows through mud; she dives beside Tarrik.

LYESSA
Can you stand?

TARRIK
Once.

LYESSA
Make it useful.

Tarrik rises using the wall; medical patches strain and leak. Dead Hand closes on him.

TARRIK
Who gave the order?

DEAD HAND
Ask Cross.

Lyessa reaches with crimson daggers. He grips wrist and jaw; her boot-contact Echo breaks the hold, but she lands with her shield dying. Tarrik intercepts a revolver; the arm blade locks Velkorran.

DEAD HAND
You stand like a man already kneeling.

Dead Hand's chain gun forces Tarrik's raised barrier; Lyessa's bolt knocks it aside.

LYESSA
Now!

He sees the too-clean opening and takes it. Velkorran rises through one elbow and falls through the other. Both mechanical forearms hit grass. Dead Hand kneels, satisfied rather than hurt.

DEAD HAND
There, Now you can see.

TARRIK
Where is the Crownmark?

DEAD HAND
Not an inheritance.

TARRIK
Answer me.

DEAD HAND
A scar.

Violet fills his eyes. Rain shears away. Black vapor rises from elbow machinery; Velkorran softens and bows in Tarrik's grip.

LYESSA
Back.

Dead Hand opens his mouth for the first time. Its layered voice now comes from flesh.

DEAD HAND
Your King crossed the Reach as Sovereign and mistook obedience for love.

Wet black muscle folds into replacement arms; violet veins ignite.

DEAD HAND
Then he vanished and left five monuments so the faithful would continue crawling after him. The Crownmarks are scars, boy. Your Emperor would tear them open and call what bleeds out a throne.

The new limb carves a trench and catches his wounded ankle. Tarrik loses bent Velkorran to mud, raises Cinderline from the ground, and fires into flesh that closes again.

14 INT./EXT. NEON VEIL - RUINED COURTYARD AND CELLAR - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-03-CS06

Dead Hand drives Tarrik into the chimney. Brick collapses. Tendrils pass beneath torn collar webbing and cold reaches skin. Torn armor obscures the point of contact.

DEAD HAND
The Echo weeps.

Tarrik's horror changes to recognition.

TARRIK
How do you know that?

DEAD HAND
How do you?

Egdredil cracks through the rain. The mass around Dead Hand's skull erupts; tendrils release Tarrik. Lyessa stands beyond it with rifle smoking, mouth bloodied and one arm weak.

LYESSA
Tarrik?

TARRIK
Alive.

She drops to him and checks face, throat and chest.

LYESSA
Did it touch your skin?

TARRIK
I don't know.

LYESSA
Tarrik.

TARRIK
I don't know.

Black residue evaporates from the collar as smoke. She trains Egdredil on the corpse while black flesh collapses to ruined metal.

CROSS
Walcur. Caedryn. Respond.

Neither answers immediately. Cross's next question is not about their wounds.

CROSS
Did he speak?

TARRIK
Yes.

CROSS
What did he tell you?

TARRIK
He told me to ask you about Cauldron.

Let the silence last long enough to become a response.

CROSS
Return to the ship.

TARRIK
No. The Crownmark is still here.

CROSS
You do not know that.

Dead Hand's overturned hat begins blinking. Red numbers project into the rain; beneath them, a final sentence.

ON SCREEN:
WRONG HOUSE, HEIR.

Red light intensifies under the cellar. Something older than the city begins to wake. Cut away with the timer still falling.

SCOR 04 THE APPROVED VERSION

15 INT. THETA INFORMATION COLUMN - DECODING SUITE FIFTY-SIX - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-04-CS01

Oran's gravitic mobility frame brings him level with the scanner. Selene places her identity implant into its reader; Lyric lowers the sealed relic into the scanning ring.

ORAN
Senior Steward Oran Pell, I oversee extraction integrity and archival classification. Please summon me if the relic produces an interpretation conflict.

ON SCREEN:
PHYSICAL SOURCE SECURED
EXTRACTION WILL NOT ALTER RELIC

Selene reads the assurance twice. Blue scanning light passes through the Crownmark; its white core answers once. Tharne begins drawing Oran into an explanation at the central thermal shaft.

CREUS
Keeper Veyne. Creus Thri, Office of Civic Information Integrity. We require your certification of the Crownwatch operational record before public release.

SELENE
Send it.

ON SCREEN:
OPERATIONAL RECORD: WARNING SHOT
MISSION ASSESSMENT: OPERATIONAL SUCCESS

SELENE
Limited? Caelus named him heir before the Dominion military.

CREUS
An heir possesses limited authority before assuming the throne.

LYRIC
They erased me.

SELENE
You remain undercover.

LYRIC
Undercover means hidden during the operation. This means inconvenient afterward.

ON SCREEN:
CIVILIAN LOSSES RESULTED FROM UNDISCIPLINED DOMINION RESPONSE
NO REFORMATION ACTION OUTSIDE ESTABLISHED OPERATIONAL TOLERANCES

SELENE
What are the established tolerances?

CREUS
Classified.

ON SCREEN:
CALCULATED PROBABILITY OF IMMEDIATE RETALIATION: 17.8%
APPROVED CIVIC THREAT INDEX: 81%

THARNE
The Crownmark is classified. The operation was complicated. This tells the public what matters.

SELENE
Yes, They will understand what they were given.

Tharne takes this for agreement. Lyric studies the distinction in Selene's face.

SELENE
Why is the approved threat index four times the calculated danger?

CREUS
The figures answer different questions. One predicts military action. The other establishes the compliance required to preserve public continuity.

SELENE
You are telling people to behave as though seventeen-point-eight is eighty-one.

CREUS
We are providing the behavioral framework most likely to reduce casualties.

Travel controls, monitoring and expanded surveillance populate the report. Hold on Caerion II among the affected worlds.

LYRIC
That helps us.

Selene understands the advantage. The extraction completes. Approved clusters turn green; other clusters turn red.

ON SCREEN:
THEOLOGICAL CONTAMINATION DETECTED

SELENE
What does that mean?

ORAN
The extraction contains unverifiable religious language. Dominion and Remnant origin, primarily.

SELENE
Does it contain navigational information?

ORAN
It may.

SELENE
Then why classify it as contamination?

ORAN
The Republic cannot base military action upon scripture.

The red clusters enter an automatic purge queue. Selene's hands hover beside the first file awaiting deletion.

16 INT. THETA INFORMATION COLUMN - DECODING SUITE FIFTY-SIX - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-04-CS02

SELENE
Executive override. Keeper 118.

ON SCREEN:
OVERRIDE INSUFFICIENT

A pale-gold path opens beneath Caerion II's northern ice. The next condemned file exposes its navigation text.

ON SCREEN:
WHERE THE TWO LIGHTS DIE BENEATH THE ICE
THE WITNESS WAITS BELOW THE SILENT CROWN

SELENE
That is the location.

LYRIC
Copy it.

SELENE
Every extraction is monitored.

LYRIC
You infiltrated Crownwatch.

SELENE
Crownwatch was less secure.

LYRIC
You are joking.

SELENE
No.

Across the suite, Tharne points to the exhaust column's manual-inspection controls. Selene listens without turning toward him.

ORAN
The level enters a local maintenance partition.

THARNE
Could I see it?

Oran, delighted to explain, activates the partition.

ON SCREEN:
LOCAL MAINTENANCE PARTITION ACTIVE
CENTRAL AUDIT DELAY: NINETY SECONDS

Selene selects the whole extraction for her combat-memory cache. When the destination is rejected, she relabels it as a local integrity diagnostic. The transfer begins.

LYRIC
You planned that?

SELENE
No.

LYRIC
Convincing.

A watcher rotates toward the command strip. Lyric moves between its lens and Selene, holding the insignia toward it and matching its sidestep.

LYRIC
Does the archive classify objects by manufacture or current ownership?

SELENE
Sergeant Vale.

LYRIC
Legitimate question.

ON SCREEN:
CACHE VOLUME EXCEEDS MAINTENANCE PARAMETERS
IDENTITY SIGNATURE REQUIRED

The purge reaches eighty-five percent. Selene's palm hovers over the identity field: the record will name her if she saves it.

LYRIC
Selene.

Selene presses her palm flat. Hold on the accepted signature before the copied route appears.

ON SCREEN:
KEEPER 118 AUTHORIZATION ACCEPTED
NONOPERATIONAL CONTENT REMOVED
TEMPORARY MEMORY DECAY: 03:47:00

The originals vanish from the approved archive. Selene opens the saved golden route privately; the Crownmark itself remains untouched inside the ring.

LYRIC
You stole classified information from your own government.

SELENE
I preserved mission-critical data.

LYRIC
That sounds healthier.

SELENE
You saw nothing.

LYRIC
That does seem to be policy.

The maintenance partition closes. Selene seals the physical Crownmark and returns it to Lyric.

SELENE
Do not let it leave your possession.

LYRIC
Now you trust me?

SELENE
No.

CREUS
The Crownwatch record requires authorization. Public continuity measures begin in nine minutes.

The false report replaces the private route. Tharne waits for accuracy; Lyric recognizes the compromise. Give Selene a long breath with both the report and the temporary-cache indicator visible.

CREUS
Keeper?

Selene places two fingers against the identity field deliberately.

SELENE
Keeper 118, Selene Veyne. I authorize the controlled public release.

ON SCREEN:
CERTIFICATION ACCEPTED
PUBLIC RECORD APPROVED

CREUS
Order is eternal.

The transmission ends. Selene removes her command strip, keeping the hidden truth close.

SELENE
Let us leave.

17 INT./EXT. THETA INFORMATION COLUMN - ELEVATOR AND LOBBY - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-04-CS03

Oran intercepts the departing group near the suite exit.

ORAN
Was the suite satisfactory?

SELENE
It performed exactly as designed.

ORAN
The highest praise a system can receive.

The group walks along the glass-elevator route; its doors close around all three.

THARNE
I thought we were in a hurry.

SELENE
The displacement network records passenger identity, destination, and transfer contents.

THARNE
Of course.

LYRIC
Did he just become more enthusiastic about surveillance?

SELENE
Understanding it.

LYRIC
That is usually how it starts.

Public displays awaken across the tower. The fabricated balcony Selene aims without hesitation; Lyric is absent and Tarrik kneels before Caelus.

CIVIC NARRATOR
Through disciplined action, the Reformation has demonstrated that no tyranny lies beyond accountability.

THARNE
They completed it quickly.

LYRIC
They made you perfect.

RECONSTRUCTED SELENE
Order is eternal.

The actual Selene leaves the elevator before the reconstruction can repeat. At the lobby pond, Lyric removes the crowned flame from her silver armor.

SELENE
What are you doing?

LYRIC
I wore this because it opened doors.

SELENE
That is not what I asked.

LYRIC
No.

Lyric drops the insignia. Bronze settles among the pale stones as koi scatter. At the shuttle ramp Oran catches the departing group, holding Selene's identity implant.

ORAN
You left this in the console.

Selene accepts it. Fear crosses her face without disguise.

ORAN
The central audit identified an unusually large maintenance cache.

Lyric's hand moves toward her weapon; she does not draw or attack.

SELENE
The Crownmark produced unstable diagnostic fragments, I isolated them to prevent contamination of the approved extraction.

ORAN
Prudent. I classified the cache as a Keeper-level operational action. Its contents cannot be reviewed without executive authorization.

Lyric's hand lowers. Oran's trusting warmth wounds Selene more than suspicion would.

ORAN
Your service protects us all, Order is eternal.

SELENE
Order is eternal.

Oran returns to his tower. The crew boards; Selene removes the command strip at the engineering station.

LYRIC
You are getting good at this.

SELENE
At what?

LYRIC
Saying things that remain technically true.

ON SCREEN:
TEMPORARY MEMORY DECAY: 03:34:00

SELENE
Tharne, initialize an isolated storage core. No network connection.

THARNE
Why isolate it?

SELENE
Because the Republic's systems cannot be trusted to preserve it.

Tharne's admiration gives way to a moment of uncertainty. He begins the isolated transfer; the gold path descends beneath Caerion II.

THARNE
That was marked for deletion?

SELENE
Yes.

THARNE
But the location may be real.

SELENE
We will find out.

The copy completes before decay. Tharne takes the pilot's station.

THARNE
Destination?

SELENE
Caerion II.

The Resolver rises toward the stars. Below, the projected Selene raises her rifle across Mestria's public screens.

SCOR 05 WHERE TWO LIGHTS DIE

18 INT./EXT. RESOLVER / NORTHGLASS CHECKPOINT - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-05-CS01

In the seamless Resolver cabin, Tharne studies the golden route while Lyric scrapes adhesive from her now bare breastplate. Selene watches the vast Reach beyond her familiar Republic.

THARNE
The two lights are probably the planet's moons, The Witness is more difficult. There is no exact correlation between the older glyph and modern Insignia.

LYRIC
So the greatest informational civilization in the Reach cannot translate two sentences?

THARNE
We can translate them. Context is uncertain.

LYRIC
Then you do not know what they mean.

THARNE
I know what they probably mean.

LYRIC
The lights could be lamps.

THARNE
Why would an ancient navigational record mention lamps?

LYRIC
Ancient people had lamps.

Tharne abandons his answer. Selene lets herself smile. The stars return to points as transit concludes.

ON SCREEN:
CAERION II CIVIC THREAT INDEX: 81%
TEMPORARY MOVEMENT RESTRICTIONS ACTIVE

Voss's face appears alone above the console; the lack of ceremony makes the assurance feel personal.

VOSS
Selene. Caerion II's restrictions are operating within projected parameters. Your presence has been integrated into the local response framework. Proceed with confidence. Trust the process that brought you there.

The transmission ends. Cut to landing vapor freezing around the Resolver. Tharne unfolds a snow-bending refractor and offers it to shivering Lyric.

THARNE
You can borrow my refractor.

LYRIC
No.

THARNE
You are shivering.

LYRIC
I am maintaining character.

They walk toward Northglass. Broken heating conduits and insulated civic junctions establish failure beneath orderly geometry. At the checkpoint, authorization opens the barrier for Selene, then reforms behind her, leaving families exposed.

CHECKPOINT OFFICER
Only personnel holding executive authorization may proceed, All refused entry must report for sedition screening.

NORTHGLASS FATHER
My children are freezing.

SELENE
Sedition?

ON SCREEN:
NORTHGLASS SUBVERSIVE ACTIVITY PROBABILITY: 91.8%

THARNE
The model may have identified a network rather than individual actors.

SELENE
Based on what?

THARNE
The variables are restricted.

SELENE
I am not.

Selene turns back from the heated street, giving the officer her implant. The officer opens the evidence packet for her inquiry.

SELENE
Show me the sedition model.

CHECKPOINT OFFICER
Its classifications are generated automatically.

SELENE
I did not ask who generated them.

ON SCREEN:
UNAUTHORIZED POWER CONSUMPTION: 312% ABOVE BASELINE
REPEATED NIGHTLY GATHERINGS

Selene removes her helmet and kneels into the cold with a household sharing a grouk-hide blanket. She listens to the witnesses.

SELENE
Why has your household power use tripled?

NORTHGLASS FATHER
Our heat sink failed.

SELENE
Then why increase consumption?

NORTHGLASS FATHER
Three other families moved into our lower room when theirs failed. We connected their heaters to our generator.

ON SCREEN:
ENCRYPTED PEER-TO-PEER COMMUNICATION

NORTHGLASS WOMAN
The civic relay froze last month, We built a mesh from old mining transmitters. It is the only way to reach the northern blocks.

The next alert identifies the boy holding an old Wasp. Selene crouches before him; the weapon scan shows an empty chamber and no active cell.

SELENE
Put it down. Whose weapon?

NORTHGLASS BOY
My father's.

SELENE
Where is he?

NORTHGLASS BOY
Died in the Crusades.

SELENE
Why bring it here?

NORTHGLASS BOY
I was going to sell it. My sister hasn't eaten since yesterday.

ON SCREEN:
KING-ERA PHRASEOLOGY DETECTED

The final evidence is an old work-song recording from Quincy's, its King references worn into local dialect. Each flagged fact remains visible beside the human explanation.

SELENE
I am overriding the result.

THARNE
The model incorporated environmental conditions.

SELENE
Not correctly.

THARNE
Then a variable was weighted improperly. We correct it.

Officers load detainees into screening transports. A mother presses against a closed window while her child screams outside.

SELENE
And until then?

THARNE
We investigate.

SELENE
Apparently.

Selene marks the classification as an environmental false positive.

CHECKPOINT OFFICER
Keeper, that will release every detainee.

SELENE
I have screened them. They are cleared.

Transports unlock; the barrier falls. The mother rejoins her child. Citizens cross toward the heated district, some suspicious, some grateful. Selene approves Quincy's civic account.

SELENE
Emergency supply requisition. Food, heat cells, blankets, and temporary lodging for every citizen released through this checkpoint. Authorization Keeper 118.

NORTHGLASS BOY
What about this?

He looks at the old pistol in the snow. Selene retrieves it and places it back in his hands.

SELENE
Keep it at home. Do not sell your father for dinner.

They walk toward the glacier; the Rest House doors admit the families behind them.

THARNE
The review process worked. The Republic identified a probable threat. A Keeper investigated and corrected a false result. That is what oversight is for.

SELENE
I corrected it.

LYRIC
Careful, People might start thinking government agents are supposed to help them.

Twenty meters later, Lyric holds a shivering hand toward Tharne.

LYRIC
Give me the refractor.

Tharne grins and passes it over. The three continue together beneath the glacier.

19 INT./EXT. CAERION II - WESTERN GLACIER AND SILENT CROWN - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-05-CS02

At the fork, smooth bright ice extends east. Broken ice and deep scratches guard the west. Selene's entire display disappears for one second.

ON SCREEN:
WESTERN ROUTE
SUCCESS PROBABILITY: 100.000%

An unrequested message hangs over the western passage without a window or source. Selene runs a diagnostic; it vanishes and the ordinary route estimates return.

ON SCREEN:
EASTERN ROUTE: MISSION SUCCESS 81.7%
WESTERN ROUTE: SURVIVAL 8.6%

THARNE
We go east.

SELENE
West.

THARNE
Eight-point-six percent survival.

SELENE
I know.

THARNE
Then based on what?

Selene cannot supply a calculation. Lyric studies her instead of the display.

LYRIC
You sure?

SELENE
Yes.

LYRIC
Good enough.

Lyric draws her Stinger and enters the west. Tharne waits one breath.

THARNE
There has to be a variable the model cannot account for.

SELENE
Obviously.

They follow the western route. Rangefinder distances change even when nobody moves. In the low chamber, a glaivehound trembles at the deeper darkness. Lyric aims, but it retreats and sprints past the group toward the fork.

THARNE
They have no documented avoidance response to humans.

SELENE
It was not avoiding us.

Ahead, three sets of their own tracks cross untouched snow. Their real prints still end at their heels. Tharne fits his boot to the identical heel mark. Selene briefly sees Lyric beside a wall, Tharne over a symbol and herself before solid ice.

LYRIC
Did you see something?

SELENE
Yes.

LYRIC
What?

SELENE
I do not know yet.

The three continue through the passage. At its end, the three occupy the positions just seen. Selene faces a scanner-confirmed forty-two-meter mass of solid ice.

ON SCREEN:
DESCEND

She places her palm against the warm wall; white-gold light traces a doorway. Ice withdraws without melting, opening stairs that Tharne's scan still denies.

LYRIC
That is not ice temperature.
Missing variable.

Tharne cannot answer. Selene descends through stone into pale metal. Frame an ancient eye beside a crown at the sealed doorway; both predate their modern factional descendants. The door separates into the vast cavern.

THARNE
Nothing agrees, Depth contradicts gravity. Temperature does not correspond to our position. My compass is pointing north and south.

LYRIC
Maybe it is open-minded.

Hundreds of meters above them, an enormous golden crown holds within ancient ice. Two moonbeams cross through it onto the golden sphere. Pale fire burns in silence.

SELENE
Where the two lights die beneath the ice.

THARNE
The Witness waits below the Silent Crown.

LYRIC
What happens when they die?

Selene steps onto the gold path. The structure pulses white. Tharne's datapad blacks out, Lyric's ammunition counter disappears and every element vanishes from Selene's visor. Hold her transparent, unannotated view of the Crown and her companions.

LYRIC
Sel?

SELENE
We found it.

20 INT./EXT. SILENT CROWN - SPHERE CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-05-CS03

Selene's recovered viewmaker offers unsuccessful seams and resonance locks. A projected image of her hand lifts a finger toward the vertical channel; her real hand hangs motionless.

ON SCREEN:
PASSAGE

THARNE
Something wrong?

SELENE
I am testing a possibility.

THARNE
What probability?

Selene does not answer. Her finger follows the projection. White Echo races through the shell's engravings; concentric golden layers unlock.

LYRIC
What did you do?

SELENE
I do not know.

LYRIC
That continues to be reassuring.

The opening is black. The last moonbeam leaves the sphere and every pale flame dies for one heartbeat. White Echo erupts from the opening. Selene staggers; Tharne falls across the gold path and loses his blade into the snow. Lyric screams, collapses and convulses.

SELENE
Lyric!

Selene kneels and tears away Lyric's helmet. Purple blood marks the eyes; black veins climb her throat. Tharne scrambles beside them.

SELENE
Get the chestplate off.

Tharne releases the clasps. Selene's diagnostic cannot identify the response. She catches Lyric's head before it strikes the ice again.

ON SCREEN:
UNKNOWN SYSTEMIC RESPONSE

SELENE
Stay with me.

A second white pulse strikes. Violet light recoils; black veins retreat down Lyric's throat. The mental voice is intimate and peaceful, audible to Selene alone.

CROWNMARK MENTAL VOICE (V.O.)
Bearer recognized.

SELENE
What was that?

THARNE
What was what?

As the light fades, convulsions resume. Selene rises toward the threshold. Another answering pulse stills Lyric; her breath remains ragged.

THARNE
Do that again.

Selene takes another step. A new pulse drives the black veins farther back.

THARNE
We should take her to Northglass.

SELENE
Their medics will not know what this is.

THARNE
Neither do we.

SELENE
But something in there does.

Lyric draws a shallow breath with her eyes still closed.

LYRIC
Go. Before I change my mind.

Selene crosses the threshold. Tharne gathers Lyric into his arms and follows; the opening seals behind them. Warmth replaces glacier cold. Banners, pale flowers and flowing white Echo surround a raised platform and its hovering five-point Crownmark.

Tharne lowers Lyric against the wall. Her breathing steadies, but a trace of violet remains under her skin. Selene approaches the platform, her companions behind her.

21 INT. CAERION II - SPHERE / RADIANCE COUNCIL RECORDING - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-05-CS04

Selene reaches toward the Crownmark. The chamber dissolves into a council chamber. The tired King rests his chin on a fist while officials argue. Lyric remains seated where the sphere wall had been; Tharne stands within the projection.

SELENE
You see this?

THARNE
All of it.

A white-and-gold-robed figure appears beside Selene, face an unbroken plane of light. Its voice enters her thoughts; the others never acknowledge it.

PRIVATE GUIDE (V.O.)
Have you found what you seek?

SELENE
You cannot see him.

THARNE
See who?

PRIVATE GUIDE (V.O.)
You seek the Crownmark.

SELENE
Yes.

PRIVATE GUIDE (V.O.)
You seek possession.

SELENE
I seek its purpose.

PRIVATE GUIDE (V.O.)
Better.

The guide turns Selene's attention toward the table. A pale Forbearance projection fills with red indicators.

FIRST COUNCIL OFFICIAL
My King, corrective action against the citizens of Forbearance cannot be delayed. Communication traffic has risen four hundred percent. Unauthorized assemblies occur nightly. Resource stockpiles are being redirected, and references to your removal have appeared in private correspondence. The predictive ministry assigns a ninety-three-point-one percent probability of organized revolt within sixty days, If we isolate the cities, remove the agitators, and install military governors now, projected casualties remain below eight thousand.

SECOND COUNCIL ADVISOR
Delay raises expected loss beyond forty thousand.

The King looks at the people interpreting the projection rather than the projection itself. He stands.

GOOD KING
The data is indicative, Your conclusion is not.

FIRST COUNCIL OFFICIAL
Majesty?

GOOD KING
Forbearance has endured infection for six years. Its heating grids failed last winter. Three agricultural districts were destroyed before harvest.

He approaches the map and marks a city. Selene remembers the shared generator under the Northglass blanket.

GOOD KING
You see increased communication and call it conspiracy. I see frightened neighbors asking who still has medicine.

Another city replaces the first.

GOOD KING
You see unauthorized assemblies. I see families sharing the few homes that can still hold heat.

Food routes cross the final city.

GOOD KING
You see supplies changing hands and call it preparation for revolt. I see people feeding one another because our own fleets arrived late.

SECOND COUNCIL ADVISOR
The probability of insurrection exceeds ninety percent.

GOOD KING
Then your certainty has exceeded your understanding.

The King deactivates red indicators one by one.

GOOD KING
The system has shown you patterns. That is what it was made to do. It cannot tell you what a person means.

MILITARY OFFICER
Ignoring the model creates unacceptable risk.

GOOD KING
I am not ignoring it.

Routes for food, medicine, heat infrastructure and engineers replace the threat map.

GOOD KING
I am refusing to mistake prediction for judgment. If Forbearance rises against us, we will answer what they do. We will not punish them today for what we fear they may become tomorrow.

SECOND COUNCIL ADVISOR
And your command?

GOOD KING
We will not cleanse them. We will not subjugate them. We will help them.

The council fades. Selene stands again inside the sphere; the private guide remains beside her.

PRIVATE GUIDE (V.O.)
What do you see, Keeper Veyne?

SELENE
A ruler.

PRIVATE GUIDE (V.O.)
Those are titles.

Give Selene a breath to remember the tired eyes rather than a monument.

SELENE
A man who listened.

PRIVATE GUIDE (V.O.)
And?

SELENE
A man who knew order was not the same as obedience.

The guide inclines its head and vanishes. The crew sits within several breaths of unfilled silence.

THARNE
The model was incomplete.

LYRIC
Your King just showed you that a machine cannot understand people.

THARNE
That is not what he said. The system identified patterns. Executive judgment supplied context.

LYRIC
So the system is perfect as long as someone ignores it when it is wrong.

THARNE
That is dishonest.

SELENE
He did not reject the system, He rejected certainty. He understood the risk and refused to let probability make the decision.

THARNE
That is consistent with Republic doctrine.

LYRIC
Then why did it bother you?

Tharne looks away. A platform tone ends the conversation. The Crownmark lights toward Selene and tracks her as she shifts. Tharne's outstretched hand produces nothing.

THARNE
It recognizes you.

LYRIC
Let me try.

Lyric forces herself upright and steps once toward it. The core dims; violet veins darken under her throat. She retreats.

LYRIC
Fine.

The core brightens for Selene. She extends her hand; the Crownmark descends and folds into a black-gold medallion with a living white center.

CROWNMARK MENTAL VOICE (V.O.)
Record preserved.

Selene closes her fingers. White light retreats from the walls, flowers close, banners settle and ivy withdraws. This is a system sleeping, without fracture, violence or falling rubble.

SELENE
We leave.

The doorway opens. Cold enters; the three cross onto the gold path. The sphere closes seamlessly. Above them the moonbeams are gone and the Silent Crown is dark.

22 EXT. CAERION II - GLACIER FORK AND NORTHGLASS - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-05-CS05

They begin the ascent. Lyric gradually walks without Tharne's support, but never lets him move far away. At the fork, collapsed ice has sealed the eastern passage.

ON SCREEN:
ESTIMATED MISSION SUCCESS: 81.7%

Tharne looks between his unchanged prediction and the wall, then closes the window.

LYRIC
Missing variable?

THARNE
Loehs off.

LYRIC
There he is.

They emerge under a pale sky. Warm light fills Quincy's Rest House; the boy with his father's Wasp is inside eating. Let Selene see him without interrupting the family's meal. The Resolver waits ahead.

Several meters before the ramp, Selene's viewmaker flickers.

SELENE
Not now.

Northglass vanishes for Selene alone. Beneath an unfamiliar sky with red-burning clouds, Tarrik kneels before her. His broken bronze armor is scorched; blood covers both hands. He is exhausted and alone rather than the perfect extremist of public models.

A dark-haired woman stands behind him holding a weapon. The image distorts. Tarrik looks up and meets Selene's eyes for one impossible instant.

ON SCREEN:
DO NOT LET HIM KNEEL.

SELENE
Tarrik?

Selene steps toward him. The vision collapses; snow returns beneath her boots and the viewmaker reboots.

ON SCREEN:
SYSTEMS NOMINAL

LYRIC
Sel?

SELENE
What?

LYRIC
You said something.

Selene's hand rises to the Crownmark compartment.

SELENE
No.

LYRIC
You sure?

Selene looks back toward the glacier. Leave room for the memory of footprints, failed models and the wounded man.

SELENE
I am not sure of anything.

LYRIC
Finally.

Lyric disappears into the shuttle. Selene remains beneath the moons for another breath, then boards. Caerion's sky continues moving as if nothing has changed.

SCOR 06 THE ECHO WEEPS / WHAT VICTORY PROVES

23 INT./EXT. NEON VEIL - RUINED SAFEHOUSE AND BURIED ARCHIVE - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-06-CS01

Zero replaces the countdown above the overturned hat. Tarrik shields his face; Lyessa turns her last emitter toward the cellar. Nothing explodes. Rain hangs for a breath, then the ground moves and red light opens along old seams.

LYESSA
What the Loehs is that?

CROSS
Walcur. Respond.

TARRIK
We're alive.

CROSS
Leave.

Lyessa presses a loosened patch to Tarrik's calf; blood spreads beneath her thumb.

TARRIK
You're reopening it.

LYESSA
You reopened it when you fought an Eclipse nightmare on one leg.

TARRIK
I was adapting.

LYESSA
You were becoming furniture.

CROSS
Agent Caedryn. Medical status?

LYESSA
He can move badly.

CROSS
Then move badly toward extraction.

Tarrik retrieves bent Velkorran from the mud. A private warning cuts beneath his ringing ears.

PRIVATE WARNING VOICE (V.O.)
Do not open what was closed.

He stops at the old stairwell. The false floor has exposed worn stone steps.

TARRIK
He wasn't living here.

LYESSA
No.

TARRIK
He was sitting on top of it.

CROSS
Dead Hand maintained safehouses throughout the Veil.

TARRIK
This isn't a safehouse. We find the Crownmark, Then we leave.

CROSS
Negative, The Emperor ordered recovery where operationally feasible. This structure is unknown, compromised, and outside our intelligence. Recovery is no longer feasible.

TARRIK
Then tell Caelus I made a command decision.

CROSS
His Glory will not appreciate that phrasing.

TARRIK
He can promote someone else.

CROSS
I'm dispatching a recovery team.

TARRIK
No soldiers. If Dead Hand spent years hiding this, a Dominion platoon will announce it to every syndicate and Reformation listener in the Veil.

Cross offers no answer. Tarrik and Lyessa descend through the industrial levels. Tarrik tries to pull away from Lyessa; his knee folds and she catches him.

TARRIK
Do not enjoy this.

LYESSA
I've dreamed of the day Tarrik Walcur admitted I was stronger than him.

TARRIK
I'm injured.

LYESSA
Excuses.

At an abandoned transit station, a recent broken red hand points toward a service tunnel. Carved beneath it: NOT FOR HIM.

ON SCREEN:
NOT FOR HIM

LYESSA
For who?

TARRIK
Caelus.

LYESSA
You don't know that.

TARRIK
He called me heir. He said the Emperor would tear the Crownmarks open.

CROSS
Dead Hand was a bounty killer. Do not turn cryptic warnings into revelation.

TARRIK
I'm wondering why Dominion intelligence calls him a butcher but never mentions that he spent years over a Crownmark.

Cross is silent. In the older tunnel, the heat increases and signal weakens. The trail reaches a circular black-stone door.

ON SCREEN:
THE ROAD DOES NOT END AT A THRONE

TARRIK
What if Caelus is wrong?

LYESSA
About what?

TARRIK
The Crownmarks. The inheritance. Whatever waits at the end. Not lying. Wrong.

LYESSA
He isn't.

TARRIK
So you know?

LYESSA
I trust him.

TARRIK
That isn't the same thing.

LYESSA
It was enough for you until tonight.

Tarrik touches the circular door. It opens of its own accord before Lyessa can use her compact charge. White light spills out. Velkorran pulls away from the threshold; when Tarrik enters, the blade shrieks. White power throws him backward into Lyessa and extinguishes the sword.

LYESSA
King-era?

TARRIK
Has to be. We found something. White-gold architecture beneath the city.

CROSS
Do not enter the lower archive.

TARRIK
I never said there was an archive.

The neural link carries silence.

TARRIK
How do you know this place?

CROSS
King-era sites frequently incorporated archival chambers.

TARRIK
You guessed.

CROSS
Yes.

TARRIK
Have you been here?

CROSS
No. Recover the Crownmark. Do not interact with anything else.

The connection drops abruptly. Neither Tarrik nor Lyessa can prove whether Cross or the structure ended it. They enter; Tarrik's pain disappears without the bloody wound healing.

LYESSA
No treatment signature.

Tarrik slowly inspects Dead Hand's living chamber. Eight years of ration seals, modern intrusion and maps surround five Crownmark points. The maps' center is a black circle.

ON SCREEN:
DO NOT COMPLETE
DO NOT OPEN
LET THE ROAD DIE
HE CALLS IT INHERITANCE BECAUSE HE CANNOT BEAR TO CALL IT WARNING

Lyessa tears a map from the wall in anger. Tarrik catches her wrist before the paper falls; the old argument has arrived beneath a new warning.

TARRIK
He knew Cauldron. He knew you and Cross.

LYESSA
Stop.

TARRIK
He knew Cross gave orders.

LYESSA
I said stop.

Tarrik releases the wrist he caught when she tore down a map.

TARRIK
When will you tell me?

LYESSA
Later.

TARRIK
When does later happen?

LYESSA
When I can tell you without changing everything.

Neither speaks as the passage deepens. Near the translated WITNESS / REMEMBER / RETURN inscription, the private warning returns. Lyessa moves closer.

LYESSA
You heard it again.

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
What did it say?

TARRIK
I don't want to tell you.

LYESSA
Why?

TARRIK
Because I don't know what's mine anymore. My memories. The words. Dead Hand. Caelus. Cross. You.

LYESSA
I am yours.

TARRIK
Then tell me about Cauldron.

LYESSA
Not here.

The promise remains love, not possession. Tarrik continues toward the lower chamber with Lyessa less than two meters behind; the emotional distance remains unclosed.

24 INT. NEON VEIL - LOWER WITNESS-SEAL CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-06-CS02

The lower chamber opens around white-gold flooring repaired across a jagged black fracture. Dark overlapping bands hold a five-point Crownmark in place. Its white core pulses; violet answers from below.

LYESSA
Found it.

Tarrik watches power pass through the relic into the bands rather than merely power the relic. Lyessa circles the repair.

LYESSA
It may release if we interrupt the conduits.

TARRIK
What does this look like to you?

LYESSA
A power junction.

TARRIK
It's closing something.

His leg buckles as he rises. His hand catches the housing; the chamber wakes in white light. Lyessa pulls him back.

ON SCREEN:
WITNESS SEAL
ROAD NODE
BOUNDARY PRESERVED

LYESSA
Forty-three percent.

TARRIK
It says seal.

LYESSA
That could mean anything.

TARRIK
Dead Hand called the Crownmarks scars. The wall calls this one a seal. It's physically holding something closed.

LYESSA
We recover it.

TARRIK
And if removing it opens the fracture?

LYESSA
Then we deal with it.

TARRIK
How?

She has no answer. The violet line keeps moving below the white-gold repair.

LYESSA
The Reformation is searching for these, We cannot let them assemble the King's Road first.

TARRIK
Why?

LYESSA
Because they'll use it against us.

TARRIK
Selene could have killed Caelus after the first shot. She didn't.

LYESSA
She tried to kill him.

TARRIK
And then chose not to.

LYESSA
You've been shot, impaled, poisoned by Eclipse contact, and manipulated by Dead Hand in the last several hours. You are spiraling.

TARRIK
Which part of that makes Caelus right?

LYESSA
Stop.

TARRIK
Which part makes this an inheritance?

Certainty leaves Lyessa's face. Private voices swell beneath Tarrik's neural audio.

PRIVATE WARNING VOICE (V.O.)
Do not open what was closed.

PRIVATE WOMAN'S VOICE (V.O.)
The Reach is groaning.

For less than a heartbeat, Tarrik stands among stars. Violet splits a black horizon above something enormous. The chamber returns with Lyessa holding his arm.

LYESSA
What did you see?

TARRIK
Nothing.

LYESSA
You're doing it now.

TARRIK
What?

LYESSA
What you accuse me of.

Leave a breath between the people who love one another and conceal their respective doors.

LYESSA
Are you taking it?

TARRIK
I don't know.

LYESSA
Then perhaps that's the first honest answer either of us has given in an hour.

Static returns to Tarrik's lace. Cross's next statement is not a question.

CROSS
You have reached the lower chamber. The Crownmark should be mounted within the central seal.

TARRIK
You said you had never been here. You said Dominion intelligence didn't know this site.

CROSS
Recover the Crownmark.

TARRIK
How do you know where it is?

CROSS
The Emperor's orders are clear.

TARRIK
That isn't an answer.

CROSS
It is the only one you need. Remove it.

TARRIK
What happens if I don't?

CROSS
The Reformation eventually finds it.

TARRIK
And if I do?

CROSS
You complete the mission.

TARRIK
Mission. Inheritance. Throne. No one knows what this is.

CROSS
Caelus does.

Lyessa's expression offers the same belief. Tarrik looks from her to the relic, wanting the Emperor's certainty and unwilling to return empty-handed. His fingers close around the edge; cold burns through the glove.

LYESSA
Tarrik.

He pulls. The Crownmark does not move.

CROSS
Continue.

He braces a boot on the dark repair and pulls again. The relic shifts; his calf screams. Bands tighten and violet brightens beneath them.

LYESSA
Tarrik.

He stops. Hold his hand on the edge without moving. He can still let go.

PRIVATE WARNING VOICES (V.O.)
The Reach is groaning. The Echo weeps. Do not open what was closed.

Tarrik deliberately pulls once more. The Crownmark tears free and folds into a portable black-gold medallion. White-gold light erupts. The seal parts a fraction, exposing a thin violet line.

Cross vanishes from the comm. A single enormous pulse travels through the structure. Tarrik closes his fist around the relic while Lyessa stares into the opening.

LYESSA
Tarrik.

PRIVATE WARNING VOICE (V.O.)
The Echo weeps.

The final warning is grief. Golden light consumes the chamber. Lyessa reaches for Tarrik, but her hand passes through his arm.

LYESSA
Tarrik!

Another room and another age replace the damaged seal. Before a distant throne stands a bloodied general.

25 INT. NEON VEIL - SEAL CHAMBER / RADIANCE COURT RECORDING - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-06-CS03

Sunlight reveals a circular court and living city beyond tall windows. The general's gold armor is bloodied; the King wears a simple white robe and narrow wreath.

GOOD KING
Tell me what you believe you have earned.

LYESSA
Tarrik?

TARRIK
You see this?

LYESSA
Yes.

Neither participant in the record notices the modern pair. The general lowers his head.

ILYRAN GENERAL
My King, I ask only what your law has always promised.

GOOD KING
And what has my law promised you?

ILYRAN GENERAL
Stewardship proportional to sacrifice. The Ilyran campaign lasted fourteen years. I led the first landing at Cyr and held the southern line after General Morren fell. I buried two sons on that world, along with half the soldiers who followed me there. I did not ask to return. I did not ask to be spared. I asked for enough soldiers to finish what we began.

GOOD KING
And you did. You broke the Ilyran armies, forced the planetary courts to surrender, and restored Crown transit through the southern systems.

ILYRAN GENERAL
Then you understand why I am here.

GOOD KING
I understand why you believe you are here.

The King descends from the throne without ceremony and embraces the general. Let several seconds pass: rigid arms, then falling shoulders, closed eyes and grief escaping discipline. Lyessa becomes still.

GOOD KING
I know what you gave me, I know what was taken from you. You have served me beyond anything I had the right to ask.

The King releases the embrace but keeps his hands on the general's shoulders.

ILYRAN GENERAL
Then grant me stewardship of Ilyra.

GOOD KING
No. You will not govern Ilyra.

ILYRAN GENERAL
I do not understand.

The King approaches the occupation projection; the general follows.

ILYRAN GENERAL
My armies pacified those worlds. My soldiers died there. I gave fourteen years of my life to bring them beneath your law.

GOOD KING
And somewhere along the way, you began believing the cost made them yours.

ILYRAN GENERAL
I said no such thing.

GOOD KING
You asked me to give you what survived your victory.

ILYRAN GENERAL
I earned the authority to govern them.

The King lets the claim remain before answering. The general fills the silence.

ILYRAN GENERAL
I proved loyalty, competence, and endurance. What more could stewardship require?

GOOD KING
Consent.

ILYRAN GENERAL
They rebelled against you. They killed Crown soldiers and burned cities loyal to your rule. Now you would trust them to govern themselves?

GOOD KING
I would trust them to become something other than the worst thing they have done.

The King circles the projection. Red occupation regions shift to white and gold.

GOOD KING
You broke the armies threatening the southern routes. You ended the siege of Cyr and prevented another decade of war. For those things, the Reach owes you gratitude. But victory proves only that you were strong enough to take a thing. It does not prove that you are fit to keep it.

Tarrik forgets to breathe. Lyessa sees the change in him but cannot intervene in the record.

GOOD KING
Power is necessary, Sometimes terribly so. There are evils that cannot be reasoned into submission, tyrants who must be removed, and doors that must be held when everyone behind you is dead. But power creates responsibility before it creates privilege. If your strength gives you anything, it gives you an obligation to repair what was broken by its use.

ILYRAN GENERAL
What would you have me do?

GOOD KING
Return. Not as governor. As a builder.

The projection exposes broken roads, powerless districts and shattered hospitals.

GOOD KING
You know where the roads were destroyed, You know which cities have no hospitals because your artillery reached them first, which districts lost power during the blockade, and which farms burned when the southern front collapsed. You know the damage better than any administrator I could send after you. You wanted stewardship proportional to sacrifice. Then steward the consequences. You will command reconstruction until Ilyra can stand without you. You will answer to its civilian councils and restore what your army destroyed, whether its people thank you or spit at your feet.

ILYRAN GENERAL
And when the work is finished?

GOOD KING
You will come home.

ILYRAN GENERAL
No governorship? No title?

GOOD KING
You already have too many.

A few officials laugh. The general stares at the conquered worlds without joining them.

ILYRAN GENERAL
Then what was the point of winning?

Every court sound stops. The King's face softens.

GOOD KING
That they survived losing.

Let the sentence settle before he leaves the projection.

GOOD KING
My authority does not make the Reach mine. Your victories do not make its people yours. We hold power because someone must bear its weight. The day we treat that weight as a reward, we are no longer fit to carry it.

The general kneels.

ILYRAN GENERAL
Forgive me.

The King takes him under one arm and raises him immediately.

GOOD KING
Do not kneel for being wrong. Learn.

A flash of five-point machinery interrupts the hall. It stabilizes; the general leaves with officials already discussing reconstruction. An elderly woman waits beside a larger five-point recording instrument threaded with circuitry.

GOOD KING
Did it hold?

RECORDER
The whole exchange.

GOOD KING
Good.

His eyes close; the years show at once. The recorder joins him beside the apparatus.

RECORDER
Why preserve these moments?

The King turns toward the instrument. His eyeline seems to pass through Tarrik's position, impossible in a centuries-old record.

GOOD KING
Because memory becomes obedient, when those who inherit it are powerful enough.

RECORDER
Obedient to whom?

GOOD KING
Whoever survives us. The Reach will tell stories about this age, and it will tell worse ones when we are gone.

He rests one hand on the black-gold recording frame.

GOOD KING
They will make us simpler because simplicity is useful. Some will remember only the battles. Others will remember only the laws. Both will believe the fragment they kept was the whole.

RECORDER
You expect division.

GOOD KING
I expect people. Set the Witness.

RECORDER
For whom?

GOOD KING
For those who come looking for what I left behind.

White-gold light passes through the modern pair without heat. Tarrik reaches for Lyessa as the hall, King and impossible sunlight collapse. His own wounded body returns; he falls to one knee and pain detonates through his calf.

26 INT./EXT. NEON VEIL - LOWER SEAL AND TRANSIT STATION - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-06-CS04

Tarrik catches himself on the white-gold floor. Lyessa steadies against the black repair. The violet cut remains alive beneath them.

LYESSA
You saw all of that?

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
Then it was real.

TARRIK
It was an Echo reconstruction.

LYESSA
That is technology.

TARRIK
You're trying to make it smaller.

LYESSA
I am trying to understand it. One recorded decision does not define an entire reign.

TARRIK
No. But it tells us the King did not believe victory made that general fit to rule.

LYESSA
That general.

TARRIK
Caelus named my campaigns, my victories, and the soldiers who follow me. He used what I have done to explain why I should inherit everything.

LYESSA
He named your character.

TARRIK
Are those the same thing to him?

She does not answer. The relic projects five points, three illuminated.

ON SCREEN:
IANIS
CAERION II
NEON VEIL

LYESSA
Three.

TARRIK
The Ianis Crownmark was active when Lyric stole it. The Reformation must have reached Caerion.

LYESSA
Then they have two.

TARRIK
Or they accessed two. We do not know whether they kept them.

All five paths converge on a dark unlocated point. Partial translations change without certainty.

ON SCREEN:
THRONE
CONFIDENCE: 18%
WOUND
CONFIDENCE: 17%

LYESSA
It cannot mean both.

TARRIK
Apparently it can.

A tremor kills the projection. System glyphs ignite around the disrupted repair.

ON SCREEN:
BOUNDARY DEGRADED
PRIMARY WITNESS REMOVED
SECONDARY CONTAINMENT ACTIVE

Black-violet filaments enter translucent stone. White fire burns them away, but more appear.

TARRIK
We opened it.

LYESSA
We weakened it. We still do not know what is beneath us.

TARRIK
That distinction is doing a great deal of work.

Pressure rises through their bones. Something vast shifts below; a sound of thousands or millions breathing together passes through the fracture. No enemy emerges. A white-gold barrier steadies and dims the violet line.

LYESSA
What the Loehs was that?

TARRIK
Dead Hand knew.

LYESSA
He suspected.

TARRIK
He lived above this for eight years. He was right about this.

LYESSA
For now.

TARRIK
We leave.

Lyessa takes Tarrik's weight at the first hard climb; this time he allows it. At Dead Hand's chamber she begins taking every intact map.

LYESSA
Take the maps.

TARRIK
That sounds like concealment.

LYESSA
It sounds like intelligence discipline. Cross knew where the Crownmark was. I do not want him deciding which parts of this matter.

TARRIK
Do you think Caelus knew?

LYESSA
I think Caelus knows more than Cross told us.

TARRIK
That was not my question.

LYESSA
I don't know.

They cross the King-era doorway. Velkorran's warped edge abruptly relights amber; Lyessa catches Tarrik's wrist as he nearly drops it.

LYESSA
You still hate old technology?

TARRIK
I hate technology with opinions.

LYESSA
You would hate Tharne.

TARRIK
Who?

LYESSA
Nothing.

Tarrik files the unfamiliar name away. Old transit layers restore their carrier network; Cross calls immediately.

CROSS
Walcur. Report.

TARRIK
We recovered the Crownmark.

CROSS
Condition?

TARRIK
Intact.

CROSS
Did it activate?

Tarrik looks at Lyessa and closes his fingers around the warm relic.

TARRIK
No.

CROSS
No activation?

TARRIK
Nothing useful.

CROSS
The installation?

TARRIK
Destabilized during extraction.

CROSS
Any Echo event?

TARRIK
No significant event.

Cross requests Dead Hand's records. Lyessa casually disconnects the archive buffer; its indicator goes dark.

TARRIK
Mostly damaged, A few local diagrams. Nothing actionable.

CROSS
Transmit everything when you regain full connection.

TARRIK
Our systems took an Echo surge underground. I will not push potentially corrupted data into a Dominion intelligence network.

CROSS
Understood. His Glory will want a direct briefing.

The connection closes. They walk several meters before Lyessa speaks.

LYESSA
You lied.

TARRIK
More than twice.

LYESSA
That does not improve it. Why?

TARRIK
Because Cross knew the site he denied knowing. Because I removed part of a functioning seal, and I do not know what happens if the Dominion decides the correct response is to remove the other four. And because the King showed us something Caelus never prepared me to see.

Lyessa holds his gaze. The agreement comes after her uncertainty rather than instead of it.

LYESSA
So we keep this between us.

TARRIK
We?

LYESSA
I saw the same Witness. I am not telling Cross.

TARRIK
And Caelus?

LYESSA
Not yet. When we understand what we saw, we tell him together.

TARRIK
That is your answer for Cauldron.

LYESSA
This is different.

TARRIK
You keep deciding when I am ready for truth.

His anger softens from exhaustion, not resolution.

TARRIK
When you tell me about Cauldron, do not give me the version you think I can survive. Tell me what happened.

LYESSA
I will.

They finish the ascent. At the misty surface, advertisements and food-stall commerce continue over the wound. Six intelligence operatives have secured the property; Dead Hand's body and hat are gone.

TARRIK
Where is he?

INTELLIGENCE OPERATIVE
Transferred to sealed containment, High Centurion.

TARRIK
Under whose authority?

INTELLIGENCE OPERATIVE
Intelligence.

TARRIK
No one enters below. Seal the site.

INTELLIGENCE OPERATIVE
Our directive carries imperial authorization.

Tarrik steps closer, knowingly using the title whose certainty he has just challenged.

TARRIK
Then tell intelligence the Emperor's heir personally ordered the structure untouched until he reviews it.

INTELLIGENCE OPERATIVE
Yes, High Centurion.

LYESSA
That was manipulative.

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
I liked it.

The black-bronze shuttle descends through mist. The pair boards; Tarrik's hand remains protectively over the Crownmark compartment as the hatch seals.

27 INT. GY SUPREMACY - MEDICAL BAY - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-06-CS05

In the Supremacy medical bay, a medic removes Tarrik's ruined calf patch and scans the damaged tissue twice. Lyessa waits against the wall, blood dried in her hair.

MEDIC
Your body appears to have begun healing, stopped, then resumed.

TARRIK
Is that a problem?

MEDIC
It is unusual. No full armor deployment for forty-eight hours.

TARRIK
I wasn't wearing full armor.

MEDIC
And yet you still found a way to damage yourself.

LYESSA
That is his primary skill.

MEDIC
You are next.

LYESSA
I am healthy.

MEDIC
You have blood in your hair.

LYESSA
Decoration.

MEDIC
Sit.

Tarrik walks the short corridor. Crew salutes accumulate conclusions of triumph he cannot share. His quarters close into silence. He places the Crownmark on his desk; five nodes project with three lit.

ON SCREEN:
LAST THRONE
CONFIDENCE: 18%
LAST WOUND
CONFIDENCE: 17%
MERIDIAN INCOMPLETE
WITNESSES PRESERVED: 3

A knock sounds. Tarrik closes his hand to extinguish the projection.

TARRIK
Enter.

Lyessa enters in a clean black undersuit with damp hair. She sits across the desk. Leave a quiet beat with the relic between them.

LYESSA
He loved that general.

TARRIK
The King?

LYESSA
He refused him because he loved him. He did not think the man was evil. He thought he was wrong. That matters.

Tarrik waits instead of pressing for the admission. Lyessa folds her hands.

LYESSA
It means Caelus can be wrong.

The admission costs Lyessa. Tarrik lets it stand.

LYESSA
It does not mean he is wrong, Or that the Dominion is.

TARRIK
No.

LYESSA
But he can be.

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
I hate this.

TARRIK
I know.

LYESSA
You enjoy saying that.

TARRIK
A little.

An imperial-priority tone sounds. Lyessa stands; Tarrik remains seated. It repeats and the projection activates without his acceptance. Caelus wears an embroidered crimson robe, no regalia; a dressing covers Selene's wound on his chest. Relief warms his face.

CAELUS
My boy.

Tarrik rises.

TARRIK
My Emperor.

CAELUS
Caedryn. I am told you both made a spectacular mess of Neon Veil.

LYESSA
Reports have been exaggerated.

CAELUS
I have met Hayden Cross. That seems unlikely. You found it.

Tarrik opens his hand. At the white Crownmark core, Caelus goes completely still. Relief passes into an unreadable mixture of hunger and grief.

CAELUS
The King's mark, After all these years.

TARRIK
Did you know where it was?

CAELUS
I knew Dead Hand had spent much of his life circling Neon Veil.

TARRIK
That is not what I asked.

Caelus's eyes sharpen and soften again.

CAELUS
No. I wish I could hold it.

TARRIK
You will.

CAELUS
Soon.

A quiet beat passes.

CAELUS
The King has opened his road to you.

TARRIK
Perhaps.

CAELUS
Perhaps?

Lyessa watches Tarrik. He gives neither the Witness nor the broken seal.

TARRIK
The site was difficult to interpret.

CAELUS
They built those places to outlast an age. I would expect nothing less.

TARRIK
Cross wants a complete report.

CAELUS
He should.

Caelus does not ask what the relic showed him. Tarrik registers the omission.

TARRIK
How much does Cross know about the King's Road?

CAELUS
Enough to help you find it.

TARRIK
That is not an answer.

CAELUS
No. When you return to Lyr, we will speak without intermediaries. You have questions.

TARRIK
Yes.

CAELUS
Good. An Emperor surrounded by people who never question him is already dead. He simply has not discovered the body.

TARRIK
Will you answer them?

CAELUS
When you are standing before me.

Caelus's gaze returns to the Crownmark.

CAELUS
Bring it home.

Tarrik's private memories of the King's refusal and breathing seal remain unsaid. Caelus regards him with paternal affection.

CAELUS
Bring it home, my son.

Tarrik deliberately bows his head instead of reporting those truths.

TARRIK
Yes, my Emperor.

Caelus smiles; the transmission ends. Lyessa moves toward the door.

TARRIK
If he asks you directly about the Witness?

LYESSA
I was unconscious from neural trauma after an explosion.

TARRIK
You were standing beside me.

LYESSA
Prove it.

A real smile reaches Tarrik, then fades.

LYESSA
We understand what this is first.

TARRIK
And then?

LYESSA
Then we decide what truth costs.

Lyessa leaves. Tarrik activates the relic again: three Witnesses awake, two waiting. The destination still alternates throne and wound. The projection fades into the white core. A faint violet color stirs beneath it, pulses once, then again. Hold the contradiction without explanation.

SCOR 07 THE MISSING RECORD

28 INT. RESOLVER - FORWARD OBSERVATION CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-07-CS01

Selene counts the eleventh pulse. Her disabled predictive display briefly overlays Tarrik holding white-gold light, then records nothing. Lyric enters with the black isolation case.

SELENE
You were instructed to leave the Ianis Crownmark in isolated containment.

LYRIC
I did. Then I un-isolated it.

SELENE
Why?

LYRIC
Because yours has been calling mine.

Lyric opens the case. Ianis answers Caerion. Displays black out. Tharne rushes in with one boot unsecured.

THARNE
The artifacts are synchronizing.

LYRIC
Excellent diagnosis.

Selene's glance restores focus. Geometry aligns; symbols gather in an index rather than a star route.

THARNE
These are not route coordinates.

SELENE
What are they?

THARNE
Index marks. The formatting is archaic, but the hierarchy is familiar.

LYRIC
Sacred filing cabinets inside the King's jewelry.

ON SCREEN:
SOVEREIGN MERIDIAN

SELENE
Sovereign Meridian.

THARNE
Sixty-two percent semantic confidence.

SELENE
The King's Road may never have been a road.

THARNE
If the five locations form a distributed reference structure, each Crownmark may contribute part of a larger coordinate solution.

The indexed Final Civic Admonition opens beside the public text for comparison.

SELENE
The Crownmark reference predates the Sundering, The archive version does not.

THARNE
The oldest surviving Reformation copy dates to the First Council.

SELENE
How long after the Sundering?

THARNE
Twenty-seven years.

Selene tests authenticated neighboring records. Their continuity chains survive migration. 7283 remains a clean hole.

SELENE
Where is 7283?

LYRIC
Someone removed it.

SELENE
Data loss does not prove intent.

LYRIC
The Crownmark says the record existed. Your archive has a hole exactly where it should be.

Keeper credentials prompt an archive response.

ON SCREEN:
HISTORICAL CONTINUITY MATERIAL
CLEARANCE REQUIREMENT EXCEEDS ACTIVE CIVIC AUTHORITY
REQUEST FORWARDED TO CENTRAL INFORMATION INTEGRITY

THARNE
Good. They can resolve the provenance.

SELENE
Did the request include my search history?

THARNE
All of it.

Tharne's relief disappears. Neon Veil becomes steady white-gold.

ON SCREEN:
WITNESS COMPLETE
NODE ACTIVE
MERIDIAN CONTINUITY: 3 / 5

THARNE
The Dominion found one.

SELENE
Someone found one.

29 INT. RESOLVER - COMMAND COMPARTMENT - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-07-CS02

Six hours later. Mestria fills the glass. Priority landing clearance confirms, followed immediately by debrief.

ON SCREEN:
CENTRAL INFORMATION INTEGRITY REQUESTS DEBRIEF UPON ARRIVAL

THARNE
They are responding.

LYRIC
Very quickly.

THARNE
They should.

LYRIC
That is what worries me.

THARNE
Not every efficient response is sinister.

The cockpit remains ordinary. Only Selene sees two lines flash across her disabled predictive display.

ON SCREEN:
ARCHIVAL RECORD 7283
LOCATION: SUBLEVEL IX

Her schematic lists eight sublevels. The ninth briefly appears with a service elevator, cold storage and a false wall. It vanishes from system history.

LYRIC
You all right?

SELENE
I'm fine.

Both companions wait. Selene lets the automatic answer die.

SELENE
Change of plan. We are not going directly to Central Information Integrity.

THARNE
Our debrief is already scheduled.

SELENE
Reschedule it.

THARNE
For when?

SELENE
After I verify something. The Crownmark evidence establishes enough discrepancy to justify an independent archival review.

THARNE
Independent through what authority?

SELENE
Mine.

THARNE
That is not what I meant.

SELENE
I know.

LYRIC
Where are we going?

SELENE
Somewhere that does not exist.

Lyric grins. Tharne closes his eyes. Resolver continues descent.

THARNE
Of course.

SCOR 08 THE FOURTH LIGHT

30 INT. SUPREMACY - MEDICAL BAY - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-08-CS01

UNIDENTIFIED WEATHERED VOICE (V.O.)
The carnage you wreak...

Tarrik wakes gripping his mattress. Empty room. He sits; his left calf catches. A medic enters as he silences the monitor.

MEDIC
High Centurion.

TARRIK
Doctor.

MEDIC
I am not a doctor.

TARRIK
You sound disappointed.

MEDIC
I sound like someone who has spent six hours repairing the leg you keep trying to destroy. Sit.

She probes healing tissue. Tarrik's breath stops.

TARRIK
You did that deliberately.

MEDIC
Yes.

TARRIK
Why?

MEDIC
To see if you would lie.

She wraps the calf again and holds up an inner dressing stained violet.

TARRIK
That was blood.

MEDIC
Mostly.

TARRIK
Eclipse residue?

MEDIC
Unknown. The lab report has not posted.

TARRIK
Keep the report away from Cross.

MEDIC
That is not a medical request.

TARRIK
No.

Tarrik walks unevenly from the medical bay into the analysis chamber. Inactive Dominion hardware surrounds the freely extracted mark.

ON SCREEN:
MERIDIAN CONTINUITY: 3 / 5

TARRIK
What is the Sovereign Meridian?

ANALYSIS TECHNICIAN
We assumed you knew.

Tarrik calls Cross. The technician withdraws to the instruments.

CROSS
An obsolete King-era navigational concept.

TARRIK
Navigation to where?

CROSS
Unknown.

TARRIK
A throne?

CROSS
Possibly.

TARRIK
Or a wound?

Cross stops breathing for a beat. Tarrik turns his full attention toward the channel.

TARRIK
Interesting.

CROSS
What?

TARRIK
You went quiet.

UNIDENTIFIED WEATHERED VOICE (V.O.)
...will not stop...

The lab tears into a burning sky. Armored bodies vanish in white fire; an immense shape moves behind clouds. Back in the lab Tarrik grips the rail.

CROSS
What happened?

TARRIK
Nothing.

CROSS
You should be in medical.

TARRIK
I was.

CROSS
I meant your neural state.

Tarrik disconnects. Lyessa enters carrying a medical kit; the calf remains wrapped and unstable.

31 INT. SUPREMACY - SECURE ANALYSIS CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-08-CS02

Lyessa kneels and reseals Tarrik's calf wrap. Familiarity hurts because trust has changed.

LYESSA
You limp less when you are angry.

TARRIK
That cannot be real.

LYESSA
It is.

A fourth circle flickers. Lyessa recognizes the prefix before the name resolves.

TARRIK
You know that designation.

LYESSA
No.

ON SCREEN:
CAULDRON
FOUNDATION: PRE-SUNDERING

TARRIK
Why is there a Crownmark at Cauldron?

LYESSA
I don't know.

Tarrik opens Cross's channel.

CROSS
Do not proceed.

TARRIK
I did not say I was.

CROSS
You were going to. Cauldron is compromised.

TARRIK
The Crownmark beneath Neon Veil was integrated into a containment seal, Removing it opened a fracture. Something beneath the city reacted.

CROSS
Any active Eclipse emergence?

TARRIK
No.

CROSS
Then containment held.

TARRIK
Secondary containment held.

Another silence. Tarrik ends the channel. Lyessa faces him across Cauldron.

LYESSA
We agreed.

TARRIK
I know.

LYESSA
Then why tell him?

TARRIK
Because he was already afraid of Cauldron.

LYESSA
We should tell Caelus.

TARRIK
Directly.

LYESSA
Yes.

Caelus appears in crimson with a visible shoulder brace. He calls Cross into the same transmission.

CAELUS
Did you know there was King-era infrastructure beneath Cauldron?

CROSS
No confirmed Crownmark intelligence existed there.

CAELUS
That was not my question.

CROSS
Yes, Your Glory.

ON SCREEN:
WITNESS STATE: DORMANT
SEAL STATE: ACTIVE

CAELUS
What happened beneath Neon Veil?

TARRIK
Removing the Crownmark weakened the seal.

CAELUS
Did something escape?

TARRIK
No.

CAELUS
You are certain?

TARRIK
No.

Allow the truth to land. Caelus looks at the unknown battlefield within the geometry.

CAELUS
Tarrik. Go.

CROSS
Your Glory, the risk is unacceptable.

CAELUS
The risk of ignorance is greater. The mission has changed. Investigate the site and determine why the King placed a node beneath Cauldron. Recover whatever records survive. You will not remove the Crownmark unless you understand what doing so will change. If it can be secured without compromising containment, bring it home. You know the site. Take him there, and put whatever happened during the original operation in his briefing.

LYESSA
Yes, Your Glory.

32 INT. SUPREMACY - SECURE ANALYSIS CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-08-CS03

LYESSA
You're not going to ask.

TARRIK
No.

LYESSA
You have asked every time.

TARRIK
You said you would tell me when you were ready. I want to know if you meant it.

Lyessa moves to the viewport. The answer takes effort.

LYESSA
Cauldron was not what the reports say, There was Eclipse contamination. Some people changed quickly. Others carried it for days without symptoms. The command structure lost containment. People died. I was there.

TARRIK
Cross?

LYESSA
Yes.

TARRIK
Dead Hand?

LYESSA
Yes.

TARRIK
Was he lying about Cauldron?

LYESSA
Dead Hand lied about many things.

TARRIK
Was Cauldron one of them?

LYESSA
No.

TARRIK
How much of what he said was true?

LYESSA
I can't do this here. This is not me avoiding you. I am trying to tell you without giving you half of it.

TARRIK
You have had years to assemble the full version.

LYESSA
That does not make it easier.

TARRIK
No. It makes the silence a choice.

She flinches. A vision interrupts Tarrik: fire, ink, a man writing beneath a starless sky. He closes his hand on the table.

LYESSA
What happened?

TARRIK
Nothing.

She recognizes the same evasion. Neither names it. A route appears under Cauldron's geological layers.

LYESSA
That route wasn't there when we were deployed.

ON SCREEN:
COURSE CHANGE ACCEPTED
DESTINATION: CAULDRON

A private neural tone sounds at Lyessa's collar.

LYESSA
Caedryn. Understood.

TARRIK
What did he want?

LYESSA
For us to be careful.

Tarrik does not believe that was everything. Hold them apart while the fourth node burns.

SCOR 09 SUBLEVEL IX

33 INT. RESOLVER / MESTRIA PUBLIC TRANSIT CAR - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-09-CS01

Selene sends a medical-delay message before landing. Lyric sees the response field close.

LYRIC
Was that a lie?

SELENE
No.

LYRIC
You're not going to medical.

SELENE
I experienced anomalous neurological activity. The statement does not specify where the review will occur.

LYRIC
You're doing the thing governments do when they lie but want to feel morally clean because the grammar survived.

THARNE
It is not a lie if every factual assertion is accurate.

Transit carries students, medical technicians and a mother with two children. A maintenance drone supports a woman with a failed mobility brace. Selene looks away.

LYRIC
Because monsters are easier when they decorate properly.

THARNE
We have not established that anyone is a monster.

LYRIC
I implied that a government can maintain excellent transit while lying about history.

THARNE
That hypothesis now warrants investigation.

They enter the Archive concourse below its unadorned name. Tharne studies the eight-level schematic.

THARNE
We should request access.

SELENE
No.

THARNE
You have Keeper authority.

SELENE
Not for Continuity-class founding records.

THARNE
If we find what you think we may find, the provenance of the discovery will matter almost as much as the record itself. Entering restricted infrastructure without authorization gives anyone who wants to discredit the evidence somewhere else to begin.

SELENE
Formal authorization creates a record of our intent before we know whether the record still exists.

THARNE
That is what oversight is for.

SELENE
And if the same oversight apparatus removed it?

THARNE
We do not know that the current institution removed anything.

SELENE
Because whoever controls access controls whether we ever see it.

Selene establishes public routes until exhausted, no unnecessary damage and no external connection beyond documented infrastructure.

THARNE
You are certain?

SELENE
No. But I am going.

Biometric gates clear Selene and then verify Tharne. Lyric wears a requisitioned support uniform hiding her neck's violet marks.

LYRIC
Do I look bureaucratic?

THARNE
No.

LYRIC
Rude.

THARNE
That was not criticism.

His glance lingers; he turns toward the wall. Selene closes the credential window.

SELENE
Your identifier is active for ninety minutes.

34 INT. CENTRAL ARCHIVE - SUBLEVEL VIII - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-09-CS02

ON SCREEN:
ACCESS

Selene reaches toward an invisible circle. Tharne catches her wrist then releases it.

THARNE
There is nothing there.

SELENE
To you.

Her palm rests on the wall. Hold two silent seconds of doubt. A concealed panel clicks open.

THARNE
Founding era.

He wipes dust from hardware physically built over by newer construction. Nine circles light beside a lift shaft.

THARNE
IX.

LYRIC
Tharne.

THARNE
I see it. Classified infrastructure.

LYRIC
Maybe.

THARNE
Founding Council continuity storage.

LYRIC
Maybe.

Selene selects IX. The depth gauge descends through what the schematic calls bedrock.

LYRIC
Apparently the rock was classified.

Tharne nearly laughs. Lift doors expose pristine King-era arches threaded with later Reformation supports.

THARNE
These supports were installed twenty-one years after the Sundering.

SELENE
Before the earliest authenticated version of the Admonition.

THARNE
Yes.

Restricted Historical Variance expands from hundreds into thousands of omitted records. Selene reads a founding memorandum.

ON SCREEN:
SOCIAL STABILITY REQUIRES COHERENT FOUNDATIONAL MEMORY

LYRIC
That sounds healthy.

Seventy meters in, a polite security notice replaces the index.

ON SCREEN:
UNAUTHORIZED HISTORICAL CONTINUITY ACCESS
PLEASE REMAIN IN PLACE

THARNE
We should stop.

SELENE
Why?

THARNE
Because Central Information Integrity knows we are here. If this level is governed by founding Continuity authority, your clearance does not apply.

SELENE
I know.

THARNE
Then we stop.

SELENE
No.

THARNE
You said procedure matters.

SELENE
It does.

THARNE
Then why abandon it?

SELENE
Because procedure is the thing standing between us and the record.

THARNE
That does not make procedure corrupt.

SELENE
No.

THARNE
It means you no longer trust the people administering it.

SELENE
Yes. You can leave. Tell them I ordered you to. Tell them I ignored your recommendation.

THARNE
I did not ask to leave.

He takes one step toward the lift, stops and looks at Lyric.

THARNE
I am not leaving you here without an analyst.

LYRIC
That your official reason?

THARNE
No. I stay.

SELENE
You understand what that may cost.

THARNE
No. But neither do you.

SELENE
Fair.

35 INT. CENTRAL ARCHIVE - SUBLEVEL IX ORIGINAL WITNESS - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-09-CS03

Caerion warms at Selene's waist. Its light traces the wall and exposes the original inscription.

ON SCREEN:
SOVEREIGN RECORD 7283
FINAL CIVIC ADMONITION
ORIGINAL WITNESS

THARNE
If this is original...

SELENE
Then the public version cannot be.

THARNE
Not both.

Wall panels retract. Inside a small circular chamber the cylinder waits above a narrow pedestal. A crude modern relay awakens beside the entrance.

VOSS
Keeper Veyne. Step away from the record.

SELENE
Why?

VOSS
There are reasons that material is excluded from the civic archive.

SELENE
Then tell me.

VOSS
This is not an appropriate channel.

SELENE
You contacted me. You knew this level existed. You knew 7283 existed.

VOSS
Leave the chamber.

SELENE
Why does the Crownmark identify this as the original Final Civic Admonition?

VOSS
Historical continuity is more complicated than a provenance chain.

SELENE
That sounds like something Tharne would say.

He is faintly offended; Lyric almost laughs. Then both watch Selene's hand approach the pedestal.

VOSS
There are truths whose survival depends upon responsible people understanding when they should not be made public.

SELENE
Truth survives by being hidden.

VOSS
That is not what I said. History without context can destroy civilizations built by people who no longer possess the circumstances necessary to interpret it.

SELENE
Then you know what is inside.

VOSS
Step away.

THARNE
Selene.

His use of her name stops her. He fears the moment after knowledge, not simply arrest.

SELENE
This is where you leave.

THARNE
No.

LYRIC
Loehs that.

VOSS
Keeper Veyne, this is a direct order from the Chancellor of the Reformation. Step away from Record 7283.

Selene studies ancient stone and modern suppression hardware. She places the Caerion Crownmark against the pedestal. Warm light spreads.

VOSS
Selene.

The cylinder starts opening. Selene's hand rests beside it; her companions stand behind her. The relay remains live.

SCOR 10 THE TRUTH BOX

36 INT./EXT. SUPREMACY / CAULDRON LANDING FIELD - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-10-CS01

Cauldron rotates black and ember-red beneath the Supremacy. Cross's upload terminates at a northern quarantine bunker, several kilometers from the southeast Crownmark.

TARRIK
The node is southeast.

CROSS
Yes.

TARRIK
Your route goes north.

CROSS
The southern basin is geologically unstable.

TARRIK
How unstable?

CROSS
Enough. Follow the approved approach, Walcur.

TARRIK
No. The King-era foundation predates the settlement. The Crownmark is active. Your route avoids both.

CROSS
My route avoids getting you killed before you reach either.

LYESSA
That depends where you intend to land.

TARRIK
Close enough to walk.

Cut through ash and cabin lightning to a hard shuttle landing beside the main-field memorial. Tarrik stands in partial rig, favoring his calf. Heat hits the open ramp.

ON SCREEN:
THE FALLEN OF CAULDRON
CIVILIANS AND SOLDIERS MURDERED IN THE REFORMATION ASSAULT

TARRIK
You knew this was here.

LYESSA
Yes.

TARRIK
You've seen it.

LYESSA
Yes.

TARRIK
When?

LYESSA
After.

They follow the forensic trail southeast. At the administrative block Tarrik crouches beside narrow-to-wide entry scarring.

TARRIK
Plasma.

LYESSA
Yes.

TARRIK
Dominion. The attack came from within.

LYESSA
Some of it.

A civilian transport has rear hatches fused shut. Fire traveled from the street into passengers.

TARRIK
Why were our weapons firing into civilians?

LYESSA
Containment.

TARRIK
Of what?

LYESSA
Eclipse exposure.

A fissure opens under the street; his mark reports stability.

ON SCREEN:
SEAL PROXIMITY
WITNESS STATE: DORMANT
BOUNDARY INTEGRITY: STABLE

Nine turret bases point toward residential market and school. Cross remains radio-only.

CROSS
Do not interact with the perimeter.
It remains contaminated.

TARRIK
What were they keeping in?

CROSS
Contamination.

TARRIK
Were the people infected?

LYESSA
Some.

TARRIK
And the rest?

LYESSA
We didn't know.

Let the ash fill the silence. Lyessa turns toward the eastern basalt wall.

LYESSA
There was a hospital.

TARRIK
How do you know?

LYESSA
Because I was there.

Near the hospital, crust breaks beneath Tarrik. Lyessa catches his forearm. They hold a moment longer than terrain requires.

LYESSA
Careful.

Inside, a lamp finds children's shoes neatly beside the wall. Neither speaks. They continue into the lower wards.

37 INT. CAULDRON CIVIC MEDICAL CENTER - LOWER LABORATORY - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-10-CS02

ON SCREEN:
CAULDRON INCIDENT + 32 DAYS

LYESSA
After.

Blue restraint hardware occupies old bronze surgical rooms. Tarrik's first relief at blaming another faction is visible; Lyessa catches it.

LYESSA
You were about to use it.

TARRIK
Use what?

LYESSA
This. To make what happened before easier.

TARRIK
The Reformation doing this does not make what happened here right.

LYESSA
No.

TARRIK
It means more people were wrong.

LYESSA
Yes.

ON SCREEN:
NULL ADAPTATION TRIAL
HOST SURVIVAL: 11.3%
CAULDRON CIVILIAN REGISTRY MATCH

LYESSA
They used them.

A long-fingered hand presses observation glass. A human eye lifts beside a Reformation optic; black tissue moves under violet veins.

EXPERIMENTAL SURVIVOR
Remain... Remain still. Treatment is... Necessary.

Glass ruptures. Lyessa brings Egdredil forward; Tarrik unfolds Velkorran. Tarrik battles the lone survivor until the creature staggers.

Tarrik cuts through one arm; Lyessa's bolts strike shoulder then leg. The creature rolls. Its human eye clears for half a second.

EXPERIMENTAL SURVIVOR
Please.

Both hesitate. Violet flares; it lunges. Tarrik drives Velkorran through its chest, buckling his wounded leg. Black tissue crawls up the blade; he tears it free. The body falls. Receding tissue exposes Cauldron district registration.

UNIDENTIFIED WEATHERED VOICE (V.O.)
...the Eclipse of life.

The laboratory vanishes into an ink-handed old man writing beneath a colorless sky and violet fire. His eyes almost meet Tarrik's. The vision leaves no diagnostic trace. Return to Lyessa's hand on Tarrik's shoulder.

LYESSA
Tarrik.

TARRIK
What?

LYESSA
You disappeared.

TARRIK
No.

LYESSA
You did. What did you see?

TARRIK
Nothing.

He gently pulls from her hand.

TARRIK
Keep moving.

38 INT. CAULDRON - SUBLEVEL C CONTAINMENT COMMAND - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-10-CS03

A radio replay bridges the lab to the lower access: Cross sees a transmitted still and demands destruction.

CROSS
Nothing produced in an Eclipse integration laboratory should survive. Do not enter Sublevel C.

The facility map lists only Lower Medical A and B.

TARRIK
Hayden. You really should stop helping.

Lyessa places a compact cutting charge on a hidden wall seam.

TARRIK
That seems aggressive.

LYESSA
You wanted subtle?

TARRIK
I wanted alive.

LYESSA
You should have brought someone else.

TARRIK
I tried.

LYESSA
You did.

A breach opens Dominion red-lit command. Tarrik descends and finds the isolated truth box behind cracked armored glass. Lyessa goes pale.

CROSS
Destroy it.

TARRIK
Why?

CROSS
Nothing recorded during the containment event can be considered reliable.

TARRIK
It is physically isolated.

CROSS
Eclipse contamination compromised the facility.

TARRIK
You have spent three days telling me Dominion records should be trusted over everyone else's. Pick one.

CROSS
Destroy it.

Tarrik sets the recorder on the command table. One tear cuts ash on Lyessa's cheek. Crownmark light wakes the dead cells.

ON SCREEN:
OPERATION CAULDRON

LYESSA
Please.

CROSS
Walcur, do not access that archive.

TARRIK
Is this it? The thing that changes everything?

LYESSA
What?

TARRIK
You told me you would tell me when you could do it without changing everything.

LYESSA
I was wrong.

TARRIK
About what?

LYESSA
That there was a way to tell you without changing it.

ON SCREEN:
COMMAND AUTHORITY: CLASSIFIED
CIVILIAN CONTAINMENT FAILURE
FINAL DIRECTIVE ATTACHED

CROSS
Tarrik. Destroy the recorder.

TARRIK
Were you here when this was issued?

Lyessa nods once.

TARRIK
Did you follow it?

She cannot answer. White-gold light flares under the deeper door. Tarrik looks back to the control.

ON SCREEN:
PLAY FINAL DIRECTIVE?

He reaches for playback. Cut before the recorder image opens. The machinery and her posture remain fixed.

SCOR 11 UNABRIDGED

39 INT. CENTRAL ARCHIVE IX / RADIANCE RECORDING ROOM - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-11-CS01

Cylinder opens and the modern relay dies mid-command. White-gold text floats over Selene's hand.

ON SCREEN:
WITNESS AUTHENTICATED
SOVEREIGN RECORD 7283
FINAL CIVIC ADMONITION

The final designation forms beneath the record name: UNABRIDGED. Hold the untouched full-record status before Tharne speaks.

THARNE
Unabridged.

Sublevel IX dissolves beneath a recorded room: pale stone, morning gardens and water, no throne. An adviser checks equipment. An ink-stained chronicler sits nearby.

ADVISER (RECORDED)
Continuity channels are open, Sovereign.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
No revisions. Not wording. Not context. Not correction. Record it as spoken.

ADVISER (RECORDED)
Yes, Sovereign.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
A civilization that depends forever upon the wisdom of one ruler has not built stability. It has built dependency. Power that cannot survive the death of the powerful was never order. It was only proximity.

Selene silently shapes the final familiar word. Tharne begins to relax.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Build laws that outlive those who write them. Divide authority so ambition cannot gather the Reach into a single hand merely because that hand claims good intentions. Record what is true while witnesses still live. Demand reason where fear would prefer instinct and evidence where devotion would prefer assumption. Do not praise rulers merely because they are loved. Love is not accountability. Do not preserve offices merely because they are ancient. Age is not virtue. A crown may become an idol long before the person beneath it realizes anyone has begun to kneel. Order exists that people may flourish. People do not exist that order may endure.

Selene freezes. The comfort in Tharne's shoulders disappears.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
A system is a tool. It possesses no conscience beyond the conscience of those who operate it. Do not surrender conscience to procedure merely because procedure is easier to obey. If a process produces cruelty, the fact that no single hand commanded it does not make the outcome clean. Beware cold systems and hollow order. Both will promise peace, claim neutrality, and assure you responsibility belongs somewhere else. Cruelty becomes especially easy when it is divided among enough responsible people that none believes himself responsible.

CHRONICLER (RECORDED)
They will remove that.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Why?

CHRONICLER (RECORDED)
Because men preserve permission better than warning. They will remember that you praised law, divided authority, and warned them against kings. They will forget what you said those things were for.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Write the part they forget.

CHRONICLER (RECORDED)
I am.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Then preserve the warning.

Selene's unlogged overlay briefly places the same chronicler older beneath violet fire. The recording remains unchanged for everyone else.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
The failure of institutions does not justify the worship of stronger rulers. A righteous sovereign can become an idol as readily as a system can become a cage. My victories do not grant my blood an eternal claim over yours. No battlefield creates divine right. Nor should you trade the warm tyranny of devotion for the cold tyranny of mechanism. You will be tempted by both. Some will tell you safety requires a ruler too strong to question. Others will tell you safety requires systems too complete to disobey. Both are asking you to stop being responsible. Do not. Reason is precious. Use it. But reason without mercy becomes arithmetic performed upon human lives. But if preserving an institution requires you to become unjust, preserve justice instead. If a system built to serve people demands that people serve its continuation, dismantle the system. If preserving order requires abandoning mercy, what you are preserving is no longer order. When I am gone, do not build another world that requires a King. But do not build one that requires people to become less human so that no king is needed. Build something better than me. Send it.

CHRONICLER (RECORDED)
They will hate you for parts of it.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Then perhaps they heard me.

Recording folds away. The public text appears beside the full original.

THARNE
Maybe it was abridged.

SELENE
Not inversion.

ON SCREEN:
ORDER EXISTS THAT PEOPLE MAY FLOURISH.
PEOPLE DO NOT EXIST THAT ORDER MAY ENDURE.
PEOPLE FLOURISH THROUGH ORDER.
ORDER ENDURES WHERE INDIVIDUAL JUDGMENT FAILS.

LYRIC
That is not abridgment.

SELENE
No.

Tharne checks subject, object and purpose clause; tests return no ambiguity. Missing warnings appear as clean gaps. Independent provenance verification passes. An associated founding memorandum dated twenty-two years after the Sundering opens.

ON SCREEN:
FOUNDATIONAL CONTINUITY REVIEW
CIVIC LANGUAGE STABILIZATION RECOMMENDATION
INVERT THE RELATIONAL CONSTRUCTION IN SECTION 12 TO PRESERVE THE INTENDED DEPENDENCE OF FLOURISHING UPON STABLE ORDER.

LYRIC
They wrote it down.

SELENE
Yes.

LYRIC
They wrote down that they were changing him.

SELENE
Yes.

THARNE
They thought they were preserving what he meant.

SELENE
By changing what he said.

THARNE
Yes.

Let the explanatory refuge collapse in him.

THARNE
That was wrong. It was wrong.

LYRIC
You all right?

SELENE
No.

Lyric steps nearer without offering innocence or consolation. Modern relay blue returns.

40 INT. CENTRAL ARCHIVE IX - WITNESS CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-11-CS02

VOSS
You have seen enough.

SELENE
How long have you known?

VOSS
I know the continuity history.

SELENE
You preserved a forgery. Is the current Council aware? The Keeper Directorate?

VOSS
Record 7283 remains restricted under founding Continuity authority. Surrender the Caerion artifact, relinquish all copied material, and return to the upper Archive for debrief.

SELENE
No.

VOSS
You are now in direct violation of a Chancellor-level Continuity order.

SELENE
I understand.

VOSS
Then comply.

SELENE
No.

VOSS
Ensign Vadem.

THARNE
Chancellor.

VOSS
Remove Keeper Veyne from the chamber. Secure Record 7283, confiscate all unauthorized copies, and escort Veyne and Lyric Vale to Central Information Integrity.

Tharne looks from original Witness to both women. Selene does not choose for him.

THARNE
I cannot execute that order. Record 7283 has been authenticated by a King-era Witness system and independently corroborated against surviving provenance architecture. Suppression prior to evidentiary review would violate continuity preservation protocol.

VOSS
You are not qualified to interpret founding Continuity law.

THARNE
No, Chancellor.

VOSS
Then comply.

THARNE
I cannot participate in suppressing authenticated evidence before review.

VOSS
That refusal is now recorded.

THARNE
Yes, Chancellor.

Lyric watches him with pride. Security map shows eight officers converging, detention only. Tharne works while permissions disappear.

SELENE
We need the record.

LYRIC
We have the transcript.

SELENE
Not enough.

THARNE
Authentication package. Full provenance, raw Witness data, editorial memorandum, integrity chain.

Lyric gives Selene her personal archive wafer.

SELENE
Contacts. Operational records.

LYRIC
Probably. Bit late for privacy. Put the King on it.

Tharne's module, Lyric's wafer and Selene's module receive separately signed transfers. Original data, provenance, comparison and review survive together.

ON SCREEN:
WITNESS CUSTODIAN
CHRONICLER AUTHORITY VERIFIED
V

Modern access cuts off before the field resolves. Tharne takes his module. They flee into the service corridor toward a dropping gate.

ARCHIVE OFFICER
Keeper Veyne, remain where you are.

LYRIC
No weapons discharge?

SELENE
That remains true.

LYRIC
They are arresting us.

SELENE
They are doing their jobs. Do not kill them.

Tharne dives under the dropping gate and overrides maintenance controls. Lyric and Selene slide under as a stun bolt hits the wall.

LYRIC
Very illegal.

THARNE
I am aware.

LYRIC
Still attractive.

At the gate's far side, Selene nearly surrenders. Her hand remains on the holstered Axiom.

SELENE
If I surrender the Witness, can you guarantee Record 7283 remains intact?

Tharne cannot answer.

SELENE
Can you guarantee the Council will release it for independent review?

THARNE
No.

Selene draws Axiom and fires into the fire-suppression pipe above the officers. Vapor fills the corridor. Every officer remains alive.

LYRIC
That was disappointingly responsible.

SELENE
Move.

They escape through the service passages without killing their pursuers.

41 INT. MUNICIPAL RECYCLING CENTER / KEEPER APARTMENT - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-11-CS03

Tharne forces a maintenance hatch. Morning light and normal recycling work receive them.

LYRIC
Most people would call this a tunnel.

THARNE
It is not a tunnel.

LYRIC
You are going to be unbearable if we survive.

THARNE
I have always been unbearable.

LYRIC
There he is.

Transit, coffee and a child's laughter continue three blocks from the Archive. Lyric touches Selene's arm.

LYRIC
We need to move.

Short travel cut to Keeper continuity apartment. Lyric locks the door; Tharne disables internal sensors. Terminal stays disconnected. Selene flattens trembling hands on the table.

THARNE
All intact.

Original and public lines float side by side. Selene studies them as something she enforced.

SELENE
They didn't mistranslate him.

THARNE
No.

SELENE
They understood the grammar and the argument.

THARNE
Yes.

SELENE
They corrected him. I used it during the Morrian labor dispute. Workers refused predictive scheduling. Administrators demanded compliance, and I told them people flourish through order. I used their words to justify enforcement.

LYRIC
Now you know.

She does not offer absolution. Keeper emergency authority admits a summons into Selene's otherwise disconnected display.

ON SCREEN:
KEEPER VEYNE
REPORT TO CENTRAL INFORMATION INTEGRITY
ALONE

LYRIC
Absolutely Loehsing not.

THARNE
You cannot go alone.

SELENE
I have to.

THARNE
No.

Selene almost smiles at his new word. Then she returns to the difficult distinction.

SELENE
I know the founders changed it, and I know Voss knows. I do not know whether she believes it should remain changed.

LYRIC
She ordered you not to see it.

SELENE
That tells me what she wanted me to do. It does not tell me whether this is inherited or chosen.

LYRIC
And if she says yes?

SELENE
I don't know.

THARNE
At least let us position nearby.

SELENE
You do not enter unless I call.

LYRIC
I make no such promise. You can have nearby.

Selene takes one evidence wafer. Tharne takes another. Lyric pockets the third. Outside, schools and clinics still work. Hold before returning to the unresolved Tarrik recorder.

SCOR 12 GATE NINE

42 INT. CAULDRON - COMMAND ROOM / HOSPITAL RECORDING - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-12-CS01

A mechanical click opens the truth box. Cross's protest cannot stop it.

ON SCREEN:
FINAL DIRECTIVE PLAYBACK
OPERATION CAULDRON
ARCHIVE AGE: 1 YEAR, 7 MONTHS, 12 DAYS

Tarrik stops breathing. Hold on the elapsed time, then cut to Cauldron alive: market fruit, school uniforms, workers on transit bridges. The recording jumps to hospital hour 00:17.

PHYSICIAN (RECORDED)
Exposure?

MINER (RECORDED)
Sector Four vent collapse.

PHYSICIAN (RECORDED)
Eclipse contact?

MINER (RECORDED)
If I saw Eclipse, doctor, I'd be screaming louder.

ON SCREEN:
NO ACTIVE ECLIPSE MARKERS

Recorded green miner violently transforms at 01:43. Cut on staff horror, not lingering injury. At 02:31 Lyessa carries a wounded boy into treatment and supplies her own diagnostic.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
Screen him again.

PHYSICIAN (RECORDED)
He was green five minutes ago.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
Use mine.

BOY (RECORDED)
Am I sick?

LYESSA (RECORDED)
No. You're scared. So am I. But scared is not the same thing as dead.

At 03:02 the same child attacks the physician. Lyessa's sidearm rises.

BOY (RECORDED)
Help me. No.

A shot sounds in the recording. Present Lyessa inhales; Tarrik does not look at her. At 04:11 a recognizably human Dead Hand enters Cross's command room.

DEAD HAND (RECORDED)
We have an evacuation lane.

CROSS (RECORDED)
No.

DEAD HAND (RECORDED)
Three medical ships are holding above the northern ridge. We load civilians, isolate in deep orbit, and vent any ship that turns.

CROSS (RECORDED)
You are proposing putting thousands of possible vectors into orbit.

DEAD HAND (RECORDED)
I am proposing we stop pretending uncertainty and infection are the same thing.

CROSS (RECORDED)
Eleven thousand eight hundred sixty-four.

DEAD HAND (RECORDED)
We know some are infected.

CROSS (RECORDED)
Yes.

DEAD HAND (RECORDED)
We know some are not.

CROSS (RECORDED)
We do not.

DEAD HAND (RECORDED)
Exactly. That uncertainty works both ways.

At 05:03 a green-screened teenager transforms aboard a civilian tram; crash cuts the feed. At 06:42 Lyessa and Dead Hand watch frightened ward occupants.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
We don't know if knowing is possible, The caldera crosses evacuation threshold in six hours.

DEAD HAND (RECORDED)
Fear tells me everything in this city might kill everyone outside it. It does not get to tell me everyone inside is already dead.

At 07:11 imperial seal and verified executive authority replace the ward. Originating name is obscured.

ON SCREEN:
IMPERIAL EXECUTIVE AUTHORITY VERIFIED

GENERAL (RECORDED)
Is that from Crownwatch?

CROSS (RECORDED)
Yes. By authority of Imperial Continuity Command containment failure at Cauldron is now classified absolute. All persons within designated quarantine sectors are to be treated as potential Eclipse vectors regardless of diagnostic status. No evacuation is authorized. No breach of quarantine will be permitted. Final Containment Protocol: Absolute. Terminate all biological activity within designated containment sectors.

The general cannot accept what he heard.

GENERAL (RECORDED)
Repeat.

Directive acknowledgement floods medical, civil defense and command channels. Dead Hand faces Cross's projection.

DEAD HAND (RECORDED)
No.

CROSS (RECORDED)
You have not heard the directive.

DEAD HAND (RECORDED)
I heard enough.

CROSS (RECORDED)
If one infected person reaches orbital traffic, we could lose a station. Ten, a planet. A hundred, the Reach.

DEAD HAND (RECORDED)
I understand the fear. I reject the conclusion.

CROSS (RECORDED)
Refusal will be treated as sedition during an extinction-level containment event.

DEAD HAND (RECORDED)
So call me a traitor.

Cut to present Tarrik, comprehending Dead Hand's earlier accusation for the first time. Recorder continues to Southern Field Command.

43 INT./EXT. FIELD COMMAND AND GATE NINE RECORDING - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-12-CS02

LYESSA (RECORDED)
Give us thirty minutes.

CROSS (RECORDED)
You have the directive.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
Rescreen everyone.

CROSS (RECORDED)
Screening is unreliable.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
Then twice.

CROSS (RECORDED)
Denied.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
People are green.

CROSS (RECORDED)
Green means nothing.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
It means we do not know.

CROSS (RECORDED)
Exactly.

Gate Six breach material shows green civilians transforming among still-human people; Lyessa drags a soldier clear and shoots a transforming child. Explosion removes senior officers from roster.

ON SCREEN:
FIELD COMMAND: CAEDRYN, L.
COMMAND ACCEPTANCE REQUIRED

LYESSA (RECORDED)
No.

CROSS (RECORDED)
Accept command.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
Hayden.

CROSS (RECORDED)
Accept command.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
Loehs you.

She closes her eyes and accepts. Gates close on outstretched hands. She authorizes turrets.

ON SCREEN:
TERMINAL CONTAINMENT ACTIVE

A mother raises her green-screened daughter across the barrier.

MOTHER (RECORDED)
Please My daughter is clean.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
I know.

MOTHER (RECORDED)
Then open it.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
I can't.

An infected body hits them. Turrets begin firing; infected and human fall together. Lyessa reaches the little girl a beat after a soldier shoots her. The child's movement stops.

SOLDIER (RECORDED)
I thought she was--

LYESSA (RECORDED)
CEASE FIRE!

Recorded hour 08:04. A wounded group arrives at South Gate Nine. Tarrik recognizes his brother's tired left-knee gait.

ON SCREEN:
SOUTH GATE NINE

DAREK (RECORDED)
Dominion line!

SOLDIER (RECORDED)
Stay back.

DAREK (RECORDED)
Are you blind? We are Dominion personnel. We have wounded.

SOLDIER (RECORDED)
Quarantine is absolute.

DAREK (RECORDED)
Lyessa!

LYESSA (RECORDED)
Darek.

DAREK (RECORDED)
Twenty-eight personnel. Nine wounded. Two critical.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
Status?

MEDIC (RECORDED)
Twenty-six green. Two amber.

DAREK (RECORDED)
The ambers are trauma response.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
We don't know that.

DAREK (RECORDED)
You know me.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
Yes.

DAREK (RECORDED)
You know Tarrik. Do you think I'm Eclipse?

LYESSA (RECORDED)
No.

DAREK (RECORDED)
Then open the gate.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
I can't. I said I don't think you are infected. I cannot know.

Personnel transform. Darek defends them and drags the medic toward the barrier.

DAREK (RECORDED)
They're turning!

LYESSA (RECORDED)
I know!

DAREK (RECORDED)
THEN OPEN IT!

A tendril pierces Darek's side. Dark tissue spreads under armor; his band remains green. Keep his human face lucid.

DAREK (RECORDED)
Open... No.

TARRIK
No.

DAREK (RECORDED)
Lyessa.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
I'm sorry.

DAREK (RECORDED)
Tarrik.

Lyessa fires chest then throat. Darek falls. Present Tarrik lunges toward the recorder as if image distance can be crossed.

TARRIK
STOP.

CROSS (RECORDED)
Maintain the line. Agent Caedryn.

LYESSA (RECORDED)
Fire.

Turrets resume. Tarrik slams playback off. Return to red-lit real command, where Lyessa stands opposite him.

44 INT. CAULDRON - DOMINION COMMAND ROOM - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-12-CS03

LYESSA
Tarrik.

TARRIK
Don't. How many times did I ask you?

LYESSA
I remember four.

TARRIK
Every time I talked about Darek.

She covers her mouth and moves toward him.

TARRIK
No. Don't touch me.

LYESSA
I watched people clear screening and turn before they reached the next room We believed if Cauldron got out, there would be no Cauldron. There would be no Reach.

TARRIK
Dead Hand didn't. He was willing to admit he didn't know. Caelus knew.

LYESSA
Yes.

TARRIK
Did he give the order?

LYESSA
I don't know. I never saw the originator.

TARRIK
Cross transmitted the directive.

LYESSA
Yes.

TARRIK
The cover story.

LYESSA
Yes.

TARRIK
You shot my brother.

LYESSA
Yes.

TARRIK
Was he infected?

LYESSA
I don't know.

TARRIK
Was Darek infected?

LYESSA
I DON'T KNOW!

She cannot contain the grief anymore. Tarrik turns, then faces her again.

TARRIK
Why didn't you tell me?

LYESSA
I knew what it would do to you.

TARRIK
No. You knew what it would do to the way I saw you. You were protecting the version of you I loved, and the version of me that loved you.

LYESSA
Yes.

TARRIK
I went to his memorial with you You stood beside me. You held my hand and let me believe the Reformation killed him. You let me say I would have saved him.

LYESSA
I know.

TARRIK
Why didn't you?

LYESSA
Because I wanted one more day.

He stops. She makes herself finish.

LYESSA
One more day where you loved me the way you did before you knew.

TARRIK
You made that choice for me.

LYESSA
Yes. Would you have opened that gate?

Tarrik wants certainty and cannot honestly produce it.

TARRIK
I don't know. Dead Hand looked at the same uncertainty and refused to pretend uncertainty was guilt.

LYESSA
He could have killed the Reach.

TARRIK
Yes. And you could have killed eleven thousand innocent people.

LYESSA
Yes.

CROSS
Walcur. Operational context matters.

Tarrik tears the transceiver from the wall and stomps it silent. No attack on Cross's person occurs.

TARRIK
How many?

LYESSA
Seven thousand four hundred sixteen civilians. Six hundred nine Dominion personnel.

TARRIK
Confirmed infected?

LYESSA
Two thousand one hundred eighty-three.

TARRIK
I still love you. That is the problem.

LYESSA
I love you.

TARRIK
I don't know how to believe you anymore.

LYESSA
I understand.

TARRIK
No. You do not get to tell me what you understand about me anymore.

She nods. His calf fails on the second step. She catches him; he automatically leans against her, realizes it and draws away gently.

TARRIK
I can stand.

LYESSA
I know.

She steps back. The deeper door reads bearer access ready.

ON SCREEN:
WITNESS ACCESS READY
SEAL STATE: ACTIVE
AUTHORIZED BEARER PRESENT

LYESSA
I can stay here.

Tarrik packs the truth box instead of destroying it.

TARRIK
No. You wanted me to know the whole thing.

LYESSA
Yes.

TARRIK
Then you are coming.

They approach side by side, not touching. Crownmark rises in its cradle. The door divides. Love survived. Trust did not.

SCOR 13 CHOSEN, NOT INHERITED

45 INT. CONTINUITY APARTMENT / CII EXECUTIVE OFFICE - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-13-CS01

LYRIC
No armor.

SELENE
No.

LYRIC
No concealed plate.

SELENE
No.

LYRIC
And you're dressing for work.

SELENE
I am going to work.

In the main room Tharne arranges evidence readers and cables. Selene sits across from him.

SELENE
What happens if I do not return?

THARNE
The first package duplicates to seven independent continuity repositories.

SELENE
Which ones?

THARNE
I am not telling you. If you are detained you cannot reveal what you do not know. Each repository receives enough to authenticate the existence of the larger archive. Confirmation from any two releases the complete record through three additional channels.

SELENE
When?

THARNE
Ninety minutes after your arrival. You can cancel only in person with the local authentication wafer.

SELENE
If all three of us are detained?

THARNE
It still moves.

They agree on seven minutes. Selene takes public transit alone past a clinic, tribunal, school and water authority. In the CII lobby, Mira Sol smiles.

MIRA SOL
Good to see you back. We heard Caerion was difficult.

SELENE
It was.

MIRA SOL
Anything useful?

SELENE
Yes.

Evidence teams work elections, military casualties and discriminatory modeling. Executive lift takes Selene into Voss's unguarded office.

VOSS
You came.

SELENE
You asked.

VOSS
I ordered.

SELENE
That distinction is becoming less useful.

VOSS
How many copies?

SELENE
Enough.

VOSS
Destinations?

SELENE
I don't know.

VOSS
Ask.

SELENE
Was the public Final Civic Admonition deliberately altered?

VOSS
Yes.

SELENE
Did the First Council authorize it?

VOSS
Yes.

SELENE
Did founding Keeper authority participate?

VOSS
Yes.

SELENE
Does the current Council know?

VOSS
Yes.

SELENE
Keeper Directorate?

VOSS
Selected leadership with Continuity clearance.

SELENE
How long?

VOSS
Eleven years. I was Deputy Keeper Director.

SELENE
What changed?

Voss darkens the city glass. Projections show post-Sundering royal claimants, burned food depots, failing hospitals and sovereign ships firing on one another.

VOSS
The Sovereign disappeared The Reach did not become free. It became contested.

Early Dominion military/logistical authority restores shipping, food and medicine, then central authority acquires crimson ceremony.

SELENE
They stabilized entire regions.

VOSS
Yes. And concentrated power while doing it. The first central administrators insisted the arrangement was temporary.

SELENE
The people who founded the Reformation were Dominion citizens.

VOSS
They believed the Dominion had correctly identified the danger of fragmentation and answered it with the wrong cure.

Reformist legal assemblies and royal blockades expose the secession crisis.

VOSS
A secession movement made largely of Dominion citizens needed legitimacy. The Dominion claimed continuity through the King's authority. The reformists claimed continuity through his restraint.

SELENE
They preserved everything that challenged dynastic sovereignty.

VOSS
Yes.

SELENE
And removed everything that could challenge the institutions replacing it.

VOSS
Yes.

The historic city burns across the glass while Selene waits to ask about the living choice.

46 INT. CII - EXECUTIVE OFFICE - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-13-CS02

SELENE
If I surrendered every copy. If Tharne dismantled the contingency and Lyric surrendered her archive. If Record 7283 belonged entirely to you again, would you release the original Final Civic Admonition tomorrow?

Voss watches the city for ten seconds.

VOSS
No.

SELENE
Why?

VOSS
The public text is embedded in four centuries of jurisprudence.

Modern projections map legal dependencies and a Dominion exploitation headline. Confidence and secession-pressure models appear.

SELENE
You modeled it.

VOSS
Of course.

SELENE
The data is indicative. Your conclusion is not.

VOSS
You are quoting Caerion II.

SELENE
Yes. Prediction does not give you moral certainty.

VOSS
It gives me responsibility. I will not gamble the stability of the Reformation so that a dead man can be quoted more accurately.

SELENE
Do you hear yourself?

VOSS
Clearly. I choose the living.

SELENE
No. You choose the civilization the lie helped preserve.

VOSS
Yes.

SELENE
Then you choose the lie.

VOSS
Yes.

Silence establishes a present choice. Voss then offers a way to continue.

VOSS
Your work. Your Keeper status remains intact. Your archive violations can be classified under emergency Continuity authority.

SELENE
Tharne?

VOSS
Administrative discipline. No criminal referral.

SELENE
Lyric?

VOSS
I can suppress the security referral arising from Sublevel IX. I am not offering immunity for everything Lyric Vale has done. You retain the Caerion II Crownmark under monitored Continuity authority and continue investigating the Meridian.

SELENE
In exchange.

VOSS
You surrender every unauthorized copy and terminate the release contingency. The public Admonition remains unchanged. You may advocate internally for structured disclosure when disclosure presents less systemic risk than concealment.

SELENE
That was four centuries ago. When does the Reformation become strong enough for the truth?

Voss does not answer.

SELENE
You abolished the throne But someone still decides what everyone else may know.

VOSS
Governments classify information.

SELENE
You think because you do not wear a crown, you are not claiming sovereignty.

VOSS
That is rhetoric.

SELENE
No. That is a throne.

VOSS
That is governance.

SELENE
That is what every throne calls itself.

Voss steps closer and forces Selene to face her own restricted release.

VOSS
You have held Record 7283 for hours and have not released it. You chose repositories, recipients, timing, and how much evidence each receives. You withheld the full record because you fear uncontrolled consequences. You already accept my premise.

Selene nearly answers too quickly. Let her reassess.

SELENE
I am buying time to preserve the truth You are buying permanence for the lie. I will make sure the evidence survives challenge and cannot be dismissed as fabrication before it reaches the public. I will consider context and how it should be released.

VOSS
Regardless of consequences?

SELENE
No. Not regardless. But I will not decide they never receive it.

VOSS
Give me the Crownmark.

SELENE
No. What happens when all five Crownmarks activate?

VOSS
I do not know. Central Information Integrity inherited compartmentalized restrictions concerning several pre-Sundering sites and records The Crownmarks were never identified to us as a unified system. Which is why I want Caerion II.

SELENE
You are afraid I will activate something.

VOSS
You already have.

Voss's limitation is real. Selene refuses certainty and refuses surrender.

SELENE
I understand exactly why you are doing it. I still think it is wrong.

VOSS
If you walk out the offer remains open until your evidence leaves controlled channels. Once public exposure begins, I may no longer be able to protect you.

SELENE
If I do not leave this building under my own authority, the first packet releases.

VOSS
Do you know what happens if the Dominion receives that record?

SELENE
They publish the forgery.

VOSS
And the warnings against systems. They omit the anti-dynastic passages and everything that condemns them.

SELENE
Then our responsibility is to make the complete record harder to fragment. Not preserve the fragment that favors us. I am leaving.

Cooling ventilation reaches her damp uniform. Voss does not stop her.

VOSS
The next time you enter this building, I may not be able to allow you to leave.

SELENE
Because you will choose differently?

VOSS
Because choices narrow.

SELENE
Only if you let them.

VOSS
You are still a Keeper.

SELENE
Yes.

Outside, no security waits. A junior administrator approaches with a slate.

JUNIOR ADMINISTRATOR
Keeper Veyne? Could you authorize a transfer?

Selene reads and signs. Ordinary permission validates.

ON SCREEN:
KEEPER VEYNE
AUTHORIZATION VALID

JUNIOR ADMINISTRATOR
Thank you.

No alarms or pursuit. Selene takes the executive lift down and steps into gray daylight.

47 INT. MESTRIA - CIVIC LIBRARY LOWER LEVEL - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-13-CS03

Companions wait beneath an open-door secession monument. Selene appears, early.

ON SCREEN:
ORDER WITHOUT SOVEREIGNTY

THARNE
You are early.

SELENE
By nine minutes.

THARNE
I know.

Selene authenticates her return in person on Tharne's local wafer. In her presence he cancels the ninety-minute absence trigger. Seven preserved evidence repositories remain intact and unreleased.

LYRIC
Did she monologue?

SELENE
No.

LYRIC
Inherited?

SELENE
Chosen.

THARNE
What does that mean?

SELENE
The current Council knows. So do Voss and selected Continuity leaders. The record remains suppressed.

Tharne sits because his legs stop supporting him.

THARNE
Then we need independent review.

LYRIC
You are magnificent.

Voss's exhibits return in a brief visual memory as Selene recounts the bargain and secession rationale.

THARNE
So they preserved the half of the King's argument that legitimized leaving.

SELENE
And removed the half that restrained what they built afterward.

LYRIC
And Voss thinks the lie created enough stability to build this.

SELENE
She thinks it helped.

THARNE
That does not prove causation.

LYRIC
So we release it.

SELENE
No. The Dominion will publish the forgery and the warnings against systems while burying everything that condemns dynasties. Central Information Integrity will call the record fabricated or compromised. If we release it now, each faction receives the fragment it already wants.

THARNE
Independent authentication.

SELENE
Outside Central Information Integrity and current executive control. Then we release the complete record.

LYRIC
All of it?

SELENE
All.

LYRIC
The part about kings.

SELENE
Yes.

LYRIC
The part about systems.

SELENE
Yes.

LYRIC
The part that makes the Reformation look like liars and Dominion inheritance look incomplete.

SELENE
Yes.

LYRIC
Fine.

Tharne's reconstructed supplemental transfer manifest resolves.

ON SCREEN:
EXTERNAL CONTINUITY MIRROR
GLASS CITADEL

THARNE
Transfer occurred before Sublevel IX was sealed Founding testimony, Sovereign records, original-language legal archive.

SELENE
Independent?

THARNE
At the time. The repository predates the Reformation. King-era, then used during the early Dominion period.

SELENE
Current authority?

THARNE
Provincial autonomous. Its status is restricted, but not by Central Information Integrity.

SELENE
Can we reach it?

THARNE
Yes.

SELENE
Without CII authorization?

THARNE
Yes.

Selene checks her concealed Crownmark. Three points burn; two remain dark.

ON SCREEN:
MERIDIAN CONTINUITY: 3 / 5

LYRIC
So what now?

SELENE
We prove it somewhere they cannot correct. Then we make sure no one can correct him again.

The trio remains in the library. Cut back to Cauldron threshold.

SCOR 14 BOTH TRUTHS

48 INT. CAULDRON - WITNESS IV / RADIANT MERCY RECORDING - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-14-CS01

At the threshold Lyessa does not reach for Tarrik.

LYESSA
We can stop. We can seal the door Return to the Supremacy. Leave this until you've had time.

TARRIK
Time. No. Stopping has done enough.

He enters. Pure white-gold chamber circles a split pedestal. Cauldron's mark remains embedded; Neon Veil's extracted mark rises before his chest.

LYESSA
The pedestal is broken.

TARRIK
No. It was made that way.

ON SCREEN:
BEARER RECOGNIZED
WITNESS IV
PRINCIPLE: CONSEQUENCE
FOREIGN TESTIMONY DETECTED
UNVERIFIED RECORD

A shelf extends. Tarrik lays his scarred recorder onto it.

ON SCREEN:
TESTIMONY RETAINED

LYESSA
Do not use it to forgive me. Not yet.

TARRIK
I wasn't planning to.

LYESSA
I know.

She realizes she has again claimed knowledge of him.

LYESSA
Sorry. I won't tell you what you're planning.

TARRIK
Good.

Stars swallow the chamber. Ilyran's engineered aperture spans between giant Echo pylons around a dead moon. Civilian traffic flees a fleet of living corrupted hulls. Radiant Mercy's bridge appears; younger King is bleeding in broken white-gold armor.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Third Spear, rotate twelve degrees counter-solar.

OFFICER (RECORDED)
Third Spear is engaged.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
I know. Rotate them anyway. Port lances Fire through Third Spear's wake.

WEAPONS OFFICER (RECORDED)
They're inside the firing corridor.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
For seven seconds. In eight they won't be.

Gold plasma threads friendly ships and destroys a carrier. Debris redirects onto nearby vessels.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Purification teams to Twelve through Eighteen Burn anything that moves after impact.

ON SCREEN:
EVACUATION POPULATION: 8,614,223,907

An Eclipse organism engulfs Fifth Crown. King opens direct command channel.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Can you clear the organism?

FIFTH CROWN CAPTAIN (RECORDED)
No.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Can you overload your core?

FIFTH CROWN CAPTAIN (RECORDED)
Yes. Make the gate matter, Sovereign.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
I will.

Fifth Crown detonates with the organism. A weathered warning intrudes only on Tarrik.

UNIDENTIFIED WEATHERED VOICE (V.O.)
They will call you King... but you will die a beggar.

Creature boarding impacts shake Radiant Mercy.

OFFICER (RECORDED)
Boarding breach, lower ventral.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Seal the affected decks.

OFFICER (RECORDED)
Four thousand crew inside.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Confirmed contamination?

OFFICER (RECORDED)
Unknown.

Tarrik flashes to Gate Nine's green bands.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Seal the decks Do not vent them. Deploy containment teams.

OFFICER (RECORDED)
They may spread.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Yes. We still know the difference between possibility and a corpse.

Lyessa lowers her eyes. The gate overloading under the convoy becomes the next battle problem. A brief older-King/broken-sky vision seizes Tarrik.

LYESSA
Tarrik?

TARRIK
I'm fine. I'm not.

She respects the correction without claiming certainty about him. Witness continues.

49 INT. RADIANT MERCY - BRIDGE RECORDING - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-14-CS02

A four-hundred-kilometer corrupted moon fires through the gate pylon. Civilians return warped from damaged transit. King turns Radiant Mercy and surviving capital ships.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Kill it.

WEAPONS OFFICER (RECORDED)
With what?

King's look is enough.

WEAPONS OFFICER (RECORDED)
Everything forward.

Thirty-four lances destroy moon. A fragment heads toward the damaged pylon. Radiant Spear and Halcyon ram it, sacrificing themselves to divert the mass.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Names.

OFFICER (RECORDED)
Radiant Spear and Halcyon.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Record them.

NAVIGATOR (RECORDED)
Ten minutes to convoy completion.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Eclipse?

NAVIGATOR (RECORDED)
Six.

ENGINEER (RECORDED)
The lattice can be destroyed by simultaneous pylon overload.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
How many would remain inside the collapse zone?

ON SCREEN:
327,841,209

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Give me another choice.

ENGINEER (RECORDED)
We could collapse only the damaged pylon.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Would it stop the Eclipse?

ENGINEER (RECORDED)
No.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Next.

WEAPONS OFFICER (RECORDED)
We hold the mouth.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
For how long?

WEAPONS OFFICER (RECORDED)
Two minutes. Perhaps three.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Next.

No answer. He asks whether the Crown network can hold the gate.

ENGINEER (RECORDED)
You could reinforce the damaged pylon manually through the Echo core.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
For how long?

ENGINEER (RECORDED)
We don't know.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Estimate.

ENGINEER (RECORDED)
Four minutes.

OLDER ADVISER (RECORDED)
And when the core overloads?

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
I die.

Willingness to die does not become permission to abandon other theaters.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
No. If I die here, Fleet Crown loses coordination across three theaters. Then I purchase four minutes here with trillions of lives elsewhere. Unacceptable. Prepare collapse.

ON SCREEN:
ILYRAN CORRIDOR WILL COLLAPSE IN FOUR MINUTES
ALL VESSELS EXCEED TRANSIT LIMITS
DO NOT STOP
VESPER'S MERCY
CIVILIAN MEDICAL CARRIER
POPULATION: 84,311
ESTIMATED GATE ARRIVAL: 6 MINUTES, 19 SECONDS

Hospital captain appears with medical staff behind her.

ALENYA VOSSARIN (RECORDED)
Is the collapse order yours?

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Yes.

ALENYA VOSSARIN (RECORDED)
Will it stop them?

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
I believe so.

ALENYA VOSSARIN (RECORDED)
Believe.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Yes.

ALENYA VOSSARIN (RECORDED)
We cannot make the gate.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
No.

She turns toward an Eclipse carrier attacking the escape flank.

ALENYA VOSSARIN (RECORDED)
We are dead when that corridor closes. We can die flying straight, or we can die useful.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
You do not owe me that.

ALENYA VOSSARIN (RECORDED)
No. I owe them. Keep the gate open as long as you can.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
I will.

Unarmed medical ship accelerates under repeated fire. Its captain remains on feed with blood from her nose and flames behind.

ALENYA VOSSARIN (RECORDED)
Still here. Make it count.

Impact and reactor detonation clear the evacuation flank. The King never looks away.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Record every name.

ON SCREEN:
CIVILIANS WITHIN TERMINAL ZONE: 312,406,118

At thirty seconds a captured civilian liner returns black-windowed, violet-engined toward the gate.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Destroy that ship.

OFFICER (RECORDED)
One hundred twenty thousand aboard.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
It no longer carries them.

Liner is destroyed. At zero the King meets a doomed captain's eyes.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Collapse the corridor.

ENGINEER (RECORDED)
With civilians inside?

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Yes.

Pylons overload. Space folds around military, civilians and Eclipse alike. Eight billion survive; 312,406,118 do not. No one cheers.

Hours later aboard damaged Radiant Mercy. King signs reports in blood-dark armor; chronicler writes by hand. Tarrik recognizes his cadence.

TARRIK
Him.

LYESSA
The voice?

TARRIK
Yes.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Names.

OLDER ADVISER (RECORDED)
There are more than three hundred million.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
I know.

OLDER ADVISER (RECORDED)
Compiling them will take months.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Then begin. They had names before they became a number.

OLDER ADVISER (RECORDED)
Civilian losses sustained during Eclipse destruction of the Ilyran Corridor.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Who collapsed the corridor?

OLDER ADVISER (RECORDED)
You did.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Then write the answer.

OLDER ADVISER (RECORDED)
You had no viable alternative.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
We did not find one.

OLDER ADVISER (RECORDED)
That is the same thing.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
No. It is not. If I were given the same conditions tomorrow, I would collapse the corridor again.

Lyessa makes one small sound.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
And three hundred twelve million people died because I gave that order.

OLDER ADVISER (RECORDED)
The Eclipse forced you.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
No. The Eclipse created the circumstance. I gave the order.

OLDER ADVISER (RECORDED)
We are trying to protect your legacy.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
From whom?

King turns toward the chronicler's physical book.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
The captain?

CHRONICLER (RECORDED)
Alenya Vossarin.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
All of it?

CHRONICLER (RECORDED)
All.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
No revisions. If the Reach requires me to be innocent in order to remain stable, then I have built something too fragile to deserve stability. I can believe the order was necessary and believe those people deserved better than necessity. Both truths belong in the record. Power is not a machine that produces innocence when operated correctly. I gave the order Put my name beside the consequence.

Witness folds away. Gold chamber returns around two people who can no longer use necessity as innocence.

50 INT. CAULDRON - WITNESS IV - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-14-CS03

ON SCREEN:
WITNESS COMPLETE
PRINCIPLE: CONSEQUENCE

LYESSA
Oh.

Ancient geometry tests recorder hardware, timestamps and command integrity.

ON SCREEN:
FOREIGN TESTIMONY VERIFIED
EVENT CORRELATE: CAULDRON
RECORD INTEGRITY: AUTHENTIC

LYESSA
The King's system verified it.

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
Cross cannot prove corruption.

TARRIK
He can say anything.

LYESSA
But now we can prove it.

TARRIK
Yes. He made a similar choice.

LYESSA
No.

TARRIK
Not the same. Similar. People would die if he waited. He did not know with absolute certainty. He killed people who might otherwise have lived.

LYESSA
It still isn't the same.

TARRIK
Why?

LYESSA
Because he told them. He put his name on it. He did not make the Eclipse responsible for the act merely because it created the circumstance. He did not turn necessity into innocence.

TARRIK
No.

LYESSA
I think I did. I kept telling myself Cauldron was one decision That the terrible thing happened, and afterward I was only surviving it. I stopped counting how many new choices I made afterward.

TARRIK
I don't know if I can forgive you.

LYESSA
I won't ask you to. Not until you decide what forgiveness would mean.

TARRIK
Do not decide what I need.

LYESSA
You're right. Tell me when I do it.

TARRIK
I will.

Tarrik inspects the interface. The Cauldron mark remains within its pedestal; Neon Veil floats near his chest. He studies the warnings.

ON SCREEN:
WITNESS IV READY FOR MERIDIAN CONTINUITY
AWAKEN NODE?
LOCAL SEAL ANCHOR WILL REMAIN INTEGRATED

LYESSA
The Crownmark stays here.

TARRIK
Yes. The King never asked anyone to collect them.

LYESSA
No.

TARRIK
Only to wake them.

LYESSA
We did Neon Veil wrong.

TARRIK
Yes.

ON SCREEN:
MERIDIAN ACTIVATION WILL TRANSFER CONTAINMENT LOAD

LYESSA
What does that mean?

TARRIK
I don't know.

ON SCREEN:
SEAL STATE: ACTIVE

LYESSA
We could wait.

She leaves the choice his. Tarrik considers the active local seal and the people who would decide in his absence. He hesitates.

TARRIK
Awaken.

The mark rises only centimeters within housing; never extracted. Gold clamps bridge the split stone.

ON SCREEN:
WITNESS STATE: COMPLETE
NODE ACTIVE
SEAL STATE: ACTIVE
MERIDIAN LOAD TRANSFER: ACCEPTED

Pressure resonates through boots. Four remote points gather.

LYESSA
Something moved.

TARRIK
The system did.

ON SCREEN:
MERIDIAN CONTINUITY: 4 / 5

Selene appears overlaid in a book-lined civic library, navy Keeper uniform, Caerion mark before chest. Tarrik reaches for Velkorran, but Cauldron still holds his body and Lyessa.

TARRIK
You.

His mouth moves, but his voice does not cross. Selene sees him and the embedded IV behind him. Understanding settles on her face. She gives no audible reply. Lyric and Tharne stand behind her.

LYESSA
What?

Lyessa cannot see Selene. Both bearers turn toward a dark fifth point.

ON SCREEN:
FINAL NODE: DORMANT
SOVEREIGN SEAL: TERMINAL
AURELION
AURELION WOUND
PRIMARY CONTAINMENT CONVERGENCE
PRISON BOUNDARY
BOUNDARY INTEGRITY DEPENDENT UPON FIVE ANCHORS

Four lit anchors distribute their burden inward to terminal seal. Recognition drains Selene's face.

ON SCREEN:
CONTAINMENT RELEASE PROGRESSION: 4 / 5
ROUTE SOLUTION: INCOMPLETE
REFERENCE AUTHORITY REQUIRED
GLASS CITADEL

Selene recognizes the final name. Connection breaks; Tarrik staggers in Cauldron. Lyessa starts forward, stops herself.

LYESSA
What happened?

TARRIK
The fifth Crownmark is at Aurelion.

LYESSA
The Aurelion.

TARRIK
Yes. He did not place the Crownmark there because Aurelion mattered to the road The road points there because that is where the prison is.

LYESSA
We're opening it.

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
Four of five.

TARRIK
Yes.

51 INT./EXT. CAULDRON - WITNESS IV AND HOSPITAL - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-14-CS04

Tarrik physically links recorder to field slate and signs duplicates through Witness verification. No outbound transmission occurs.

ON SCREEN:
AUTHENTICATED TESTIMONY DUPLICATE

LYESSA
What do we tell Caelus?

TARRIK
Nothing.

The answer comes too fast. He closes his eyes and corrects it.

TARRIK
No. We tell him when he cannot erase it.

LYESSA
That is what I said. You're hiding it.

TARRIK
For now.

LYESSA
So did I.

TARRIK
Yes. I intend to tell them I intend to place the complete record somewhere no one in Dominion command can alter or deny it.

LYESSA
When?

TARRIK
When Cross cannot make it disappear.

LYESSA
That could remain convenient for a very long time.

He accepts her challenge.

TARRIK
Then we set a condition. Glass Citadel.

LYESSA
You don't know what it is.

TARRIK
No.

LYESSA
Where it is.

TARRIK
No.

LYESSA
Whether we can reach it.

TARRIK
No.

LYESSA
You're becoming comfortable with that word.

TARRIK
I've had a difficult day.

A memory of laughter passes, not laughter itself.

TARRIK
The Meridian needs Glass Citadel to resolve Aurelion Selene recognized the name. If it can authenticate Cauldron outside Dominion control, we release the record.

LYESSA
To whom?

TARRIK
The Dominion first.

LYESSA
Caelus?

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
Cross?

TARRIK
No.

LYESSA
And if Caelus authorized Cauldron?

TARRIK
I am going to find that out too.

He offers one duplicate while retaining the other.

TARRIK
Take it. If they take mine, yours survives.

LYESSA
Tarrik...

TARRIK
This is not trust. It is redundancy.

LYESSA
I accept the distinction.

She seals it inside her armor. IV settles into the pedestal, its seal intact.

ON SCREEN:
WITNESS IV: ACTIVE
SEAL ANCHOR: INTEGRATED
LOCAL BOUNDARY: STABLE
MERIDIAN CONTINUITY: 4 / 5

LYESSA
He would have put his name on the memorial.

TARRIK
The King.

LYESSA
He would have put his name beside Darek's.

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
I should have.

TARRIK
Yes.

Stone closes behind them. They ascend through Dominion command, Reformation lab and hospital. At the dead subject Tarrik stops; the human eye is closed, optic dark, district scar uncovered. He continues to the memorial.

ON SCREEN:
DAREK WALCUR
MURDERED IN THE REFORMATION ASSAULT

Lyessa faces the false line. A vision strikes Tarrik: the old King at a broken star, a nameless chronicler and violet fire.

UNIDENTIFIED WEATHERED VOICE (V.O.)
They will call you King... but you will die a beggar. The end is nigh, my King.

LYESSA
The voice?

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
Who is he?

TARRIK
I don't know.

LYESSA
But he was at Ilyran. He wrote for the King.

TARRIK
Yes. The first phrase I heard The carnage you wreak... ...will not stop... ...the Eclipse of life.

LYESSA
An accusation.

TARRIK
Maybe.

LYESSA
Or a warning.

TARRIK
Maybe.

LYESSA
Or something he wrote.

TARRIK
For the first time I think those words already happened.

LYESSA
You're remembering them.

TARRIK
Someone is making me remember.

Neither forces an answer. Cut to departing shuttle: Lyessa sits across from Tarrik, never beside him. Ash erases the planet. He opens Meridian.

ON SCREEN:
ROUTE SOLUTION: INCOMPLETE
REFERENCE AUTHORITY: GLASS CITADEL

LYESSA
When do we go to Aurelion?

TARRIK
We don't. Not yet Glass Citadel.

LYESSA
Selene will go there.

TARRIK
You saw her?

LYESSA
No.

TARRIK
She knew the name.

LYESSA
How can you tell?

TARRIK
I saw her face.

LYESSA
And when both of you have the route?

Tarrik has no answer. Four points dim against dark fifth; the people remain in separate seats and separate rooms. Cut to Selene's Glass Citadel approach.

SCOR 15 THE IMMUTABLE RECORD

52 INT. MESTRIA CIVIC LIBRARY / WEST ORBITAL COURIER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-15-CS01

Caerion II burns beneath Selene's coat. Tharne catches her arm; Tarrik appears across an overlaid white-gold chamber. Neither voice crosses. Lyessa stands beside him, unable to see Selene.

ON SCREEN:
MERIDIAN CONTINUITY: 4 / 5
PRISON BOUNDARY
CONTAINMENT RELEASE PROGRESSION: 4 / 5
GLASS CITADEL

The exchange collapses. Tharne steadies Selene at the library table.

THARNE
What did you see?

SELENE
Four Crownmarks are active.

THARNE
Cauldron.

SELENE
Walcur awakened it. The fifth Crownmark is at Aurelion.

LYRIC
The broken star. The place the Eclipse disappeared.

SELENE
The Meridian called it a prison boundary.

Selene opens the Glass Citadel record. Tharne lays the tracked Resolver authorization chain beside it.

THARNE
Central Information Integrity placed a passive locator inside the vessel authorization chain.

LYRIC
Legal?

THARNE
Yes.

LYRIC
Boring.

Tharne restores seven dark repository nodes. They turn white; public release remains visibly disabled. Lyric places three courier contract identities beside the transit map.

LYRIC
An accredited archival courier leaves Mestria orbit in three hours.

THARNE
Archival freight requires accredited personnel.

LYRIC
Good news.

THARNE
They are competently constructed. They are also fraudulent.

SELENE
We leave in forty minutes.

A brief montage: Selene removes the conspicuous Keeper coat; the three board the charter courier; Mestria falls away. Orpheon's rings illuminate crystal towers more than a kilometer high. Tharne falls silent.

LYRIC
This is your cathedral.

THARNE
Yes.

LYRIC
I get it.

In the arrival hall, Selene stops at crystal-embedded original records.

ON SCREEN:
ORIGINAL INSCRIPTIONS MAY NOT BE MODIFIED
CORRECTIONS REQUIRE SUPERSEDING RECORD

LYRIC
But no one can go back and make the lie disappear.

THARNE
No.

The intake terminal verifies their covers. Dr. Sera Vann's writ opens Tier Two access. The camera settles behind Selene.

53 INT. GLASS CITADEL - TIER TWO AND MAINTENANCE ROUTE - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-15-CS02

ON SCREEN:
EXTERNAL EXECUTIVE PRESERVATION HOLD
ORIGIN: REFORMATION CENTRAL INFORMATION INTEGRITY

LYRIC
Efficient woman.

THARNE
Public derivatives remain accessible, The original is in the Mirror Vault.

Tharne expands the opaque white-gold sphere beneath the crystal towers. Its access conditions resolve.

THARNE
Authenticated Witness authority. If you invoke the Crownmark, Citadel authentication will resolve your actual identity. It will appear in every access audit. There will be no plausible denial.

SELENE
Use the Witness authority.

THARNE
Subtle phase complete.

SELENE
It lasted longer than I expected.

Caerion II opens a previously invisible King-era corridor. The party descends three levels. A beautiful tone interrupts them.

CITADEL VOICE
Keeper Selene Veyne. Your presented credentials do not correspond with authenticated Witness identity. Please remain in place while Custodian review is initiated.

LYRIC
There goes Dr. Vann.

THARNE
Six security officers responding.

SELENE
Move.

Pale-gray officers pursue them through upper floors. Opacity fields hide junctions; Tharne reroutes lifts. Selene follows an unsourced leftward direction into an old service alcove. Later, white-gold light catches a dark-violet line beneath Lyric's collar.

ON SCREEN:
ECLIPSE CONTAMINANT DETECTED
QUARANTINE SCREEN ACTIVE

LYRIC
Oh, rude.

THARNE
Can you continue?

LYRIC
Yes.

THARNE
Too fast.

LYRIC
I dislike the question.

THARNE
Answer it anyway.

LYRIC
Yes. I can continue.

Caerion II opens a narrow channel. Lyric's body jerks on contact. Tharne catches her hand and keeps it.

THARNE
Slowly.

LYRIC
Tharne.

THARNE
Slowly.

He guides her through. Lyric locks her jaw and bears the pain. He releases her too quickly on the far side.

LYRIC
Thank you.

THARNE
Of course.

Selene turns away to spare them scrutiny. The circular Mirror Vault door fills the frame.

54 INT. GLASS CITADEL - SOVEREIGN MIRROR VAULT - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-15-CS03

Thousands of crystal plates orbit a central column. One separates at Selene's request.

SELENE
Record 7283.

ON SCREEN:
FINAL CIVIC ADMONITION
PRIMARY MIRROR COPY

SELENE
Compare.

Tharne connects the Sublevel IX copy. The Citadel reads both.

ON SCREEN:
SOURCE MATCH: 100.000%
PRE-SECESSION CUSTODY VERIFIED
NO REFORMATION EDIT AUTHORITY
NO DOMINION EDIT AUTHORITY

THARNE
It's real twice.

SELENE
It was always real.

THARNE
Yes, but now nobody can say it isn't.

The provisional certificate binds to their preserved evidence.

LYRIC
There. We can prove it. Now we leave.

SELENE
No.

THARNE
Selene.

SELENE
Aurelion.

THARNE
Less than three minutes.

SELENE
We came for two answers.

The modern star query fails. Tharne selects the oldest index and compensates four centuries of drift. A blue-white star divides into the two contemporary remnants around an absent center.

ON SCREEN:
AURELION WOUND
REMOTE ANCHORS: FOUR
TERMINAL ANCHOR: ONE
PRIMARY CONTAINMENT: CLOSED

THARNE
Then the prison has not opened. The four remote anchors are only prepared to release.

LYRIC
Then nobody touches the fifth.

THARNE
No one.

The sealed Sundering testimony rotates into view, still inaccessible.

ON SCREEN:
TERMINAL WITNESS ACCESS REQUIRES MERIDIAN COMPLETION

LYRIC
Does completion open it?

THARNE
Not necessarily. The language distinguishes readiness from execution. Completing the Meridian appears to unify release authority at the terminal anchor.

SELENE
So it gives whoever stands there the choice.

LYRIC
That is unbelievably unfair.

SELENE
Deliberate.

ON SCREEN:
NEXT OCCURRENCE: 19 DAYS, 6 HOURS

LYRIC
There's our clock.

All three copy the pre-split stellar frame. Caerion II absorbs its reference; Selene cannot stop the pulse. The access session seals, binding BOTH queries to the finalized certificate.

ON SCREEN:
EXTERNAL CONTINUITY CERTIFICATE FINALIZED

ASTELL
Keeper Veyne.

SELENE
Custodian Prime Astell.

ASTELL
You are in violation of Glass Citadel archival sovereignty.

SELENE
Yes.

ASTELL
Then surrender the copies.

SELENE
No. My government altered the record your archive just authenticated.

ASTELL
I am Custodian Prime. Record 7283 is authentic. That does not authorize theft.

SELENE
If I surrender the copy, will you transfer it to Central Information Integrity?

ASTELL
No.

SELENE
Will you publish it?

ASTELL
No.

SELENE
Why?

ASTELL
Glass Citadel does not unilaterally intervene in political disputes between signatory governments.

SELENE
They falsified foundational history.

ASTELL
Yes.

SELENE
And you remain neutral.

ASTELL
Neutrality is not endorsement. The appropriate mechanism is archival tribunal.

SELENE
How long?

ASTELL
Initial review begins within fourteen days.

Selene glances from the ingress countdown to the approaching Custodian lights.

ASTELL
Surrender.

SELENE
No.

ASTELL
Then Custodian authority will detain you.

LYRIC
And now?

SELENE
Now we steal our own history.

The three run toward the closing exit. Stun drones emerge along the path.

55 INT. GLASS CITADEL - BRIDGE SUPPORT AND PURGE CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-15-CS04

The Caerion-opened bridge seam admits the party into a narrow transparent service artery.

LYRIC
This is deeply unpleasant.

THARNE
You're afraid of heights.

LYRIC
I'm afraid of falling.

A stun pulse fractures the floor. Lyric drops through. Tharne catches her wrist; Selene braces his harness before the edge breaks.

THARNE
Selene.

LYRIC
Tharne.

THARNE
I have you. Pull.

Selene leans back. They drag Lyric through; she lands across Tharne, breathless and without a joke.

LYRIC
Thank you.

THARNE
Of course.

Another pulse drives them onward. Two corridors later, a white-gold field catches Lyric.

ON SCREEN:
CONTAMINANT PURGE

Violet detonates beneath her skin. Her body locks; the pistol rises toward Tharne. Selene stops his first step and raises Axiom.

SELENE
Don't.

THARNE
Lyric.

Her trigger finger trembles. Tharne steps once, open-handed.

THARNE
Stay here.

LYRIC
Tharne...

THARNE
Stay here.

The violet light flickers. Lyric lowers the pistol and collapses into Tharne's arms.

LYRIC
I almost...

THARNE
I know.

LYRIC
You're allowed that one.

She pulls away, terrified but regaining enough voice to offer the efficient sacrifice.

LYRIC
I stay. The field reacts to me, and I can hold this corridor.

SELENE
No.

LYRIC
It is tactically cleaner.

SELENE
No.

LYRIC
You cannot save everyone because the King said beautiful things.

SELENE
No. But I will not leave you while another option exists.

THARNE
There is another. A narrow maintenance spine. It adds four minutes.

SELENE
Then we take four minutes.

The three hurry through the maintenance passages to the courier. Tharne takes the pilot seat; Custodian officers enter the bay.

THARNE
Launch authority denied.

LYRIC
Override.

THARNE
I cannot.

SELENE
Legally?

THARNE
Yes.

LYRIC
Launch the ship, Tharne.

One clamp releases. The second stays locked. Selene opens Astell's channel.

SELENE
We are leaving.

ASTELL
I had gathered.

SELENE
I will submit to tribunal after the evidence exists beyond unilateral Reformation seizure.

ASTELL
That is not how tribunal review works.

SELENE
I know.

ASTELL
Then stop pretending this is procedural.

SELENE
Fair.

THARNE
Selene.

SELENE
Do it.

Tharne overloads the emergency release. Custodians dive behind cover; none fires. The courier clears the towers. A Reformation cutter's targeting lock appears, then Astell's sovereign command cancels it.

ON SCREEN:
WEAPONS AUTHORITY DENIED WITHIN CUSTODIAL SOVEREIGNTY

At the neutral boundary the lock returns. Tharne opens the Echo corridor before a weapon discharges. The courier vanishes.

ON SCREEN:
ARCHIVAL VIOLATION RECORDED

56 INT. CHARTER COURIER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-15-CS05

ON SCREEN:
RECORD 7283: AUTHENTIC
IMMUTABLE MIRROR MATCH CONFIRMED

THARNE
All seven accepted the certificate. The evidence is preserved.

LYRIC
Then trigger public release.

SELENE
No.

LYRIC
Again?

SELENE
Not yet.

Lyric unstraps and turns fully toward her.

LYRIC
You broke into the oldest neutral archive in the Reach to prove the record is real. We proved it, and now you sit on it.

SELENE
For now.

LYRIC
Voss would be proud.

THARNE
The certificate is bound to the complete access session. That chain now includes Selene's Witness authority, the sovereign stellar index, and our Aurelion query.

Selene looks at the point where she extended the session.

SELENE
I joined those two answers. That was my decision.

LYRIC
Then redact the query.

THARNE
The chain would no longer be independently verifiable.

LYRIC
So publishing the proof exposes the prison.

Selene nods. Four ready anchors circle the dark fifth.

SELENE
The Dominion will accelerate its hunt for Crownmark V.

LYRIC
Then make sure it ends. No transition period. No when conditions permit. No responsible group deciding everyone else is never ready. You tell them when the thing that could open hell is no longer waiting for whichever idiot reaches it first.

SELENE
And if that takes years?

LYRIC
Then you become Voss.

SELENE
Good. Hold me to that.

THARNE
We define the endpoint.

SELENE
Containment stabilized and terminal release authority disabled. Or twenty-four hours after the ingress window closes. Whichever comes first.

LYRIC
Even if we fail?

SELENE
Especially if we fail.

LYRIC
And then?

SELENE
We release everything: the complete Final Civic Admonition, the founding alteration memorandum, the Caerion Witness, and every authenticated containment record we carry.

LYRIC
Everything?

SELENE
Everything.

Tharne opens a record. Lyric signs first, Tharne second, Selene last. Their three names seal into all seven packages. Voss's five-word message interrupts.

ON SCREEN:
DISCLOSURE COMMITMENT
DO NOT COMPLETE THE MERIDIAN

THARNE
She knows.

SELENE
Something, Enough to warn me.

Caerion II opens the Meridian without permission. The missing stellar frame races into all four active nodes.

ON SCREEN:
MERIDIAN ROUTE SOLUTION: PROPAGATING
NEXT VIABLE WINDOW: 19 DAYS, 5 HOURS, 41 MINUTES

THARNE
Walcur has the route.

SELENE
If his Crownmark received the same propagation.

LYRIC
You know it did.

No one argues. Selene closes the projection, leaving three people inside a dark cabin with one fewer answer they can safely publish.

SCOR 16 PUT MY NAME BESIDE IT

57 INT. SUPREMACY QUARTERS / RATHIS APPROACH SHUTTLE - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-16-CS01

Tarrik types before the blackened recorder; Lyessa enters without armor and stops well short of him.

ON SCREEN:
OFFICIAL IMPERIAL HISTORY IS FALSE

Three notices go to Fleet Crown, Imperial legal review and military casualty archive. No recording attaches.

LYESSA
You sent it.

TARRIK
I sent notice.

LYESSA
Cross will call it insubordination.

TARRIK
He can call it whatever he wants.
The record still exists.

The propagated Meridian reference resolves. Caelus's private channel opens beside it.

ON SCREEN:
NEXT VIABLE INGRESS: 19 DAYS, 5 HOURS, 41 MINUTES

CAELUS
You found it.

TARRIK
Yes.

CAELUS
Did you find what you feared?

TARRIK
No. Worse.

CAELUS
Were you involved?

Caelus's gaze rests on Lyessa. Tarrik answers the fact; she offers no defense.

TARRIK
Yes.

CAELUS
You filed notice without the evidence. Why?

TARRIK
So the truth cannot die with the file.

CAELUS
Good.

Rathis and Orison expand over the table. Power lines drain from hospitals into the relay.

TARRIK
It is copying the route.

CAELUS
Attempting to.

TARRIK
The Meridian calls Aurelion a prison boundary. The four awakened Crownmarks have advanced a containment release. The fifth is the terminal seal.

CAELUS
Containing what?

TARRIK
The Eclipse.

Caelus opens the civil-grid report.

TARRIK
Three hospitals lost primary service.

CAELUS
Two held on backup.

TARRIK
The third?

CAELUS
Nineteen deaths are currently attributed to the interruption.

TARRIK
Who? Not how many. Who?

Caelus supplies the individual names. Tarrik reads every one, including the nine-year-old child. The occupied relay district shows civilians, armed splinters and trapped Dominion personnel.

CAELUS
I am sending you because no available commander understands the active Crownmark system as well as you do. Your Crownmark may be required to enter Orison's original core, and your reputation precedes you. Do not confuse my confidence in your mercy with permission to lose Orison.

Caelus closes. Cross replaces him on a separate channel.

TARRIK
You transmitted the Cauldron order.

CROSS
You saw the circumstances.

TARRIK
You lied.

CROSS
Cauldron is not repaired by my confession.

TARRIK
No. But this conversation begins with the truth.

CROSS
And what truth did you give him?

LYESSA
All of it.

CROSS
If the mirror completes, Crownwatch can turn a bearer-only transit into a fleet ingress.

Cross's channel closes. The Supremacy turns. Cut to Rathis's dead hospital district below their shuttle.

KAID
We recommend immediate precision suppression of anti-air assets before insertion.

TARRIK
They are inside residential sectors.

KAID
Yes.

TARRIK
Then no.

KAID
High Centurion, those batteries can hit your shuttle.

TARRIK
Then I suggest we fly better.

The shuttle drops between refinery towers. Construction drones climb toward it; Cinderline comes against Tarrik's shoulder. He aims at the charges.

58 EXT. RATHIS - ORISON PERIMETER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-16-CS02

KAID
They have killed twenty-three of mine.

TARRIK
How?

KAID
Three were dragged from a checkpoint and beaten to death. The others died in combat. Seventy-one remain confirmed alive inside the district. Worker medics treated six wounded personnel before the southern splinter cells seized access.

TARRIK
Why did the protest become an insurrection?

KAID
Because they are seditionists.

TARRIK
That is a classification. I asked what happened.

Kaid's report shows dispersal ordered after civilian systems failed. Initial armed status is blank.

TARRIK
Who fired first?

KAID
An explosive device was thrown toward the security line.

TARRIK
Before or after live fire?

Kaid cannot answer.

TARRIK
Find out.

KAID
My soldiers are dead.

TARRIK
Then the people who killed them face charges.

Tarrik opens the public worker channel. Tessa appears in a grease-streaked grid jacket, exhausted and bandaged.

TESSA
What do you want?

TARRIK
Orison intact. The civilian grid restored. Full hospital reserve, food-distribution priority, and a protected corridor for noncombatants.

TESSA
Why?

TARRIK
You should not trust me, Trust what I am willing to put on the record.

ON SCREEN:
NO COLLECTIVE SEDITION DESIGNATION FOR UNARMED PARTICIPANTS
INDIVIDUAL REVIEW FOR VIOLENT OFFENSES
INDEPENDENT MIXED PANEL FOR SECURITY USE OF FORCE
CIVILIAN MEDICAL RESERVE: IMMEDIATE RESTORATION

TESSA
Immediately.

TARRIK
Yes.

TESSA
Orison remains staffed by our engineers.

TARRIK
Civilian engineers remain at surface grid control under joint supervision. The military secures the ancient core.

TESSA
Then no.

TARRIK
You do not need access to the core to keep power running.

TESSA
And armed participants?

TARRIK
They disarm. Anyone tied to murder or other violent offenses is detained. Everyone else is processed individually.

TESSA
No mass roundup.

TARRIK
No.

TESSA
And the people whose only crime was standing outside because their children were cold?

TARRIK
They go home.

TESSA
There are groups inside who stopped listening to the labor council hours ago, Ash Banner was armed before the blackout. They are opportunists wearing politics.

TARRIK
Get your people out.

TESSA
And power?

TARRIK
I said immediately.

TESSA
Put your signature on it.

Tarrik signs before command and civil networks. Tessa signs after him.

CROSS
Do not restore full civilian reserve. If the draw drops below eighty-six percent, the handshake may degrade beyond recovery in thirty-eight minutes.

TARRIK
How much does hospital reserve cost?

CROSS
Twelve percent.

TARRIK
Restore the hospitals.

CROSS
You may lose the only fleet-usable copy of the Aurelion solution.

TARRIK
Then move faster. Grid command, restore full civilian medical reserve. Now.

Amber recedes from Orison. The hospital wakes floor by floor. A father outside lifts his face; others simply remain standing.

ON SCREEN:
37:00

The evacuation corridor opens. Over eighteen minutes, worker medics carry a Dominion private, a boy carries a respirator battery. Then the southern relay explodes.

TESSA
Ash Banner breached switching. They have lower relay and--

A small impact hits Tessa; her channel dies. The tactical display shows three exits sealing and Tessa captive with forty-three Dominion hostages.

KAID
You negotiated, and they betrayed you.

TARRIK
No. They didn't. Ash Banner did. How many troops can you give me without turning the evacuation corridor into a battle?

KAID
Twelve troops.

TARRIK
Six.

KAID
Ten.

TARRIK
Eight.

LYESSA
Nine.

TARRIK
Nine.

Kaid brings eight soldiers and joins them himself. Tarrik moves toward the turbine access with Lyessa beside him.

59 INT. ORISON - NAVIGATION CORE AND UPPER GANTRY - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-16-CS03

The ancient route column receives Tarrik's Crownmark. Lyessa recognizes the Caerion bearer relay.

ON SCREEN:
BEARER RELAY: CAERION II
LOCAL FLEET PACKAGE: 71%

LYESSA
She made it.

TARRIK
Yes.

Joren calls down from the gantry in a black-painted mining exosuit. A reactor charge rests across his chest. Tessa kneels between two fighters; the forty-three hostages fill the transparent barrier behind them.

JOREN
Turn it off.

TARRIK
What is your name?

JOREN
Does it matter?

TARRIK
Yes.

JOREN
Joren Vale.

TESSA
He does not speak for the district.

JOREN
The district surrendered.

TESSA
The district chose to live.

JOREN
You turned off hospitals for that.

TARRIK
The Dominion did.

JOREN
You admit it?

TARRIK
Yes.

JOREN
You are going to use it for something worse.

TARRIK
Possibly.

Even Lyessa looks at him. Tarrik starts up the ramp, Velkorran lowered.

TARRIK
You may be right about what the Dominion eventually does with Orison. But you do not get to kill forty thousand people because you are afraid of what might happen.

JOREN
That is exactly what your Empire does.

TARRIK
Yes. And it is wrong.

Joren arms the first contact. Kaid raises his rifle; Tarrik holds him off.

ON SCREEN:
ARMED
FINAL CONFIRMATION REQUIRED

TARRIK
Don't.

JOREN
You think mercy fixes this.

TARRIK
No.

JOREN
Then what does?

TARRIK
Nothing fixes the people already dead.

JOREN
Convenient.

TARRIK
You killed people too.

JOREN
So did you.

TARRIK
Yes. The difference is not that my hands are clean.

JOREN
Then you understand.

TARRIK
No.

Joren's thumb descends. Lyessa's line to his head clears; Tessa remains close enough to die in the blast.

LYESSA
Tarrik.

It is a question. Tarrik sees the controller, Tessa and the angle. He reaches the top of the ramp.

TARRIK
Take it.

Egdredil cracks. One flash of Darek behind glass crosses Tarrik's senses. Joren's hand opens before the final contact. Tarrik catches the controller against the gantry and tears the arming lead free. Red holds for a second, then dies.

TARRIK
My order.

LYESSA
Yes.

Tessa retakes switching. The hostage barrier opens; all forty-three leave alive. Ash Banner mostly surrenders; the remaining two resist, one killed and one wounded. Tarrik sets his Crownmark to the original core.

ON SCREEN:
MIRROR STABILITY: RECOVERING
ESTIMATED COMPLETION: 17 MINUTES

60 EXT. RATHIS - COMMAND PERIMETER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-16-CS04

Kaid opens the order. Its first reasonable provisions scroll into organizer detention, ration pressure and housing demolition.

ON SCREEN:
ORGANIZER DETENTION: MANDATORY
RATION PRIORITY SUSPENSION: SEVEN DAYS
RESIDENTIAL STRUCTURES UTILIZED FOR ARMED RESISTANCE: DEMOLITION AUTHORIZED

TARRIK
After surrender?

KAID
Standard protocol.

TARRIK
Are they firing?

KAID
No.

TARRIK
The hostages are recovered, and Orison is secure. Why demolish homes?

KAID
So the next district thinks before trying this.

CROSS
Execute the protocol.

TARRIK
What military necessity requires destroying housing after the district has surrendered?

CROSS
Deterrence is imperial necessity.

TARRIK
Then punish the people who committed crimes. You are demolishing surrendered families for what strangers may do tomorrow.

CROSS
If armed occupation produces restored power, negotiated surrender, and individual judicial review, others will learn the tactic.

Tarrik looks toward the same homes he refused to strike from orbit.

CROSS
You are ordered to execute Imperial Stability Protocol.

TARRIK
No.

CROSS
Repeat.

TARRIK
No.

CROSS
Your refusal will be entered as formal insubordination.

TARRIK
I expect it to be, Write it accurately. Put my name beside it.

KAID
High Centurion, I cannot disregard authenticated Stability authority.

TARRIK
You aren't. I am. Record the refusal under High Centurion authority.

KAID
You are taking sole responsibility. This could end your command.

TARRIK
Yes.

A separate authenticated channel addresses Lyessa. Tarrik does not speak for her or ask her to stand with him.

ON SCREEN:
CONTINUITY FIELD RELIEF AUTHORITY
AGENT LYESSA CAEDRYN

CROSS
Agent Caedryn, High Centurion Walcur is in direct refusal of authenticated Stability authority. Activate field relief and assume Continuity command.

LYESSA
Negative.

CROSS
Clarify.

LYESSA
High Centurion retains command.

CROSS
You remain under Imperial Intelligence authority.

LYESSA
Then record my refusal too.

CROSS
Lyessa.

LYESSA
Add my name.

Cross disconnects. Lyessa stays half a meter from Tarrik. She does not look to him for a reward. The camera holds their unchanged distance, then follows surrendered weapons being catalogued and security evidence sealed for independent review.

61 INT./EXT. RATHIS EVACUATION CORRIDOR / ORISON CORE - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-16-CS05

A widow spits at Tarrik's boots. Kaid starts forward; Tarrik stops him with one hand. She wears a Dominion citizenship band.

WIDOW
My husband died in the hospital, He was conscious when the backup failed. I was holding his hand.

TARRIK
What was his name?

WIDOW
Marek Sol. You came after.

TARRIK
Yes.

He offers no justification. She walks away. Later, the ancient core requests verification; the relay engineer meets him beneath a completed route column.

ON SCREEN:
MERIDIAN ROUTE SOLUTION: LOCAL MIRROR COMPLETE
FLEET NAVIGATION PACKAGE: GENERATED
CONTINUITY MIRROR TRANSMISSION COMPLETE

TARRIK
Where did it transmit?

RELAY ENGINEER
Central Sovereign authority.

TARRIK
What does that translate to now?

ON SCREEN:
DESTINATION: CROWNWATCH

TARRIK
No one authorized that.

RELAY ENGINEER
It never requested authorization.

Cross appears beside the completed routing record.

CROSS
Thank you, Tarrik.

TARRIK
You used me.

CROSS
I assigned you an objective.

TARRIK
You knew the relay would transmit.

CROSS
I suspected.

TARRIK
You keep turning suspicion into permission.

CROSS
Someone has to act before certainty arrives.

TARRIK
And someone has to survive whatever you do while you are guessing. What did Crownwatch receive?

CROSS
Aurelion's identification, ingress timing, pre-split stellar frame, and a fleet-compatible approach solution.

The entire payload is marked received.

TARRIK
Create three authenticated copies of the transmission audit. Routing, timestamps, recipient authority, and payload verification. Exclude the navigational data.

One audit enters Tarrik's field case. He gives the second to Kaid; the third uploads to the military casualty archive.

KAID
Why me?

TARRIK
Because you disagree with what I did today.

KAID
That is an unusual basis for trust.

TARRIK
I did not say trust.

KAID
Redundancy.

TARRIK
Yes.

Hours later aboard the Supremacy, civilian light fills Rathis below. Lyessa stands beside the viewport.

LYESSA
You could have lost the relay, The route.

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
You restored the hospitals anyway.

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
I would have chosen Orison. Before I saw what necessary becomes when nobody decides where it stops.

Tarrik neither rewards nor corrects her. Caelus's channel opens.

CAELUS
Cross has filed three complaints, two disciplinary notices, and one recommendation that I relieve you.

TARRIK
Efficient.

CAELUS
You will answer for the refusal when you return.

TARRIK
Yes.

CAELUS
Return to Crownwatch.

TARRIK
No. Not yet.

CAELUS
Why?

TARRIK
Glass Citadel is the condition I set for releasing the Cauldron record. It can authenticate the evidence outside Dominion control.

CAELUS
Twenty-four hours, Then you return.

TARRIK
And if I find something?

CAELUS
You report it.

Caelus closes. In the Meridian display, modern Dominion crimson adds a new priority beside the ancient dark point.

ON SCREEN:
CROWNWATCH CONTINUITY PRIORITY: AURELION

SCOR 17 ELEVEN MINUTES

62 INT. COURIER / CENTRAL CIVIC FORUM BACKSTAGE - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-17-CS01

ON SCREEN:
ARCHIVAL SOVEREIGNTY VIOLATION RECORDED
IDENTIFIED PARTY: KEEPER SELENE VEYNE, REFORMATION CENTRAL INFORMATION INTEGRITY

Mestria grows beyond the courier glass. Public headlines multiply around the sparse violation notice. Voss's secure coordination room interrupts the feed.

VOSS
You violated the sovereignty of the one independent archive in the Reach whose continued cooperation I specifically needed preserved.

SELENE
It authenticated Record 7283.

VOSS
I assumed that was why you went.

SELENE
Then why are you angry?

VOSS
Because now everyone else knows you went.

SELENE
It published an accurate record.

Voss replaces competing headlines with a Forum schedule.

VOSS
You give a civic address.

SELENE
No.

VOSS
People trust you.

SELENE
That seems like a terrible reason to use me.

VOSS
It is the only reason public statements matter.

SELENE
And if I stand beside you repeating approved language, I become part of the concealment.

VOSS
Then do not repeat language you believe is false.

SELENE
I will speak, I have conditions. I will not call Record 7283 false or challenge Glass Citadel's authentication. I will not claim every active Crownmark is under Reformation control, and I will not deny that undisclosed Sovereign material exists.

VOSS
Accepted.

SELENE
And I will not use the altered Admonition sentence.

VOSS
Send me your draft.

The three work. Government reassurances are deleted from the draft rather than read aloud as truth. Tharne separates the sealed operational annex from a public attestation.

ON SCREEN:
DISCLOSURE DEADLINE: FIXED
DISCRETIONARY EXTENSION: PROHIBITED

LYRIC
A promise that proves when it was made without saying why.

THARNE
Yes.

LYRIC
That is almost elegant.

Cut to Forum backstage. Selene adjusts her Keeper collar. Tharne carries two viewmakers; Lyric hides the painful violet line beneath her own collar.

LYRIC
They may take it from you after tonight.

SELENE
Yes.

LYRIC
Then why wear it?

SELENE
Because Voss does not own it.

Voss waits with Selene's draft.

VOSS
You may use the authentic construction.

SELENE
Why?

VOSS
I am allowing it because it is what he said. The cost is why I can make the Council endure hearing it. You will not accuse the First Council of deliberate alteration, mention the Foundational Continuity Review, or discuss the Meridian's terminal function. And you will not mention Aurelion.

SELENE
I won't.

VOSS
Do not make me regret letting you speak.

SELENE
You already do.

VOSS
Yes.

A coordinator signals the remaining two minutes. Selene walks toward the stage entrance; the crowd becomes audible.

63 INT. MESTRIA - CENTRAL CIVIC FORUM AMPHITHEATER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-17-CS02

The room gradually stills. Selene sees the Council-cleared text, then lifts her eyes to the public lens.

SELENE
There is no active evacuation order for Mestria. Civil transit, medical services, power distribution, and public communications remain stable across the capital region. At this time, there is no verified evidence of an active Eclipse breach within Reformation territory. There are, however, active Sovereign-era systems that we do not fully understand. That uncertainty is real. It does not justify panic, and it does not justify anyone pretending to possess certainty they do not have.

Journalists begin writing. Selene allows the room to settle further.

SELENE
Many of you are here because Glass Citadel issued a public notice identifying me. The notice is accurate. I entered Glass Citadel under credentials that were not my own. I accessed restricted Sovereign continuity materials without Custodian authorization, and when the Citadel ordered me to remain for review, I did not. Glass Citadel recorded those facts accurately. So will I. My conduct should be reviewed. Procedure does not become irrelevant because the person violating it believes the cause is important. The reason I entered Glass Citadel is equally important. Sovereign-era material relevant to current Continuity questions required authentication outside the custody of Central Information Integrity. The record was authenticated.

Voices rise. Selene waits, one hand raised, until she can continue.

SELENE
There are people tonight asking whether discoveries in an old archive make the Reformation less worthy of trust. They should ask. Trust that cannot survive examination is not trust. It is dependency. I remain a Keeper of the Reformation because there is much here worth preserving. Hospitals treat people without asking which political inheritance their family claims. Courts continue operating after elections replace the people who govern. Water systems succeed so quietly that most citizens rarely have to think about them. Our schools, transit grids, and civil authority over military power are real achievements. A false sentence in history does not make every hospital false. A compromised record does not make every court corrupt. A failure by people in power does not erase four centuries of ordinary citizens serving one another through institutions that have done enormous good.

Tharne lowers one viewmaker. Hope, rather than triumph, enters his face.

SELENE
But the good does not make the false true.

On the official teleprompter, PEOPLE FLOURISH THROUGH ORDER advances. Selene does not read it.

SELENE
The public Final Civic Admonition contains a sentence familiar to nearly every citizen of the Reformation. The independently authenticated Sovereign record contains different wording. The King said, 'Order exists that people may flourish.'

Let the first sentence reach the room. Voss becomes completely still.

SELENE
'People do not exist that order may endure.'

Journalists and provincial feeds replicate the quotation. No riot or collapse follows.

SELENE
Those words exist within a Sovereign record independently authenticated by Glass Citadel. Systems are tools. Law is a tool. Procedure is a tool. Their value lies in what they protect, not merely in their continued existence. The Reformation is strongest when its institutions help people remain responsible for one another. It becomes weaker when procedure convinces good people that moral judgment belongs somewhere else. None of this requires abandoning institutions. It requires remembering what institutions are for. No government, army, political movement, or claimant should race toward ancient machinery simply because it carries the King's name. Inheritance is not permission.

The last phrase appears on a live side-feed before she has finished.

SELENE
There will be questions now, We should answer them.

Hands and press markers rise. Voss closes her eyes once; the next scene begins without a time jump.

64 INT. MESTRIA - CENTRAL CIVIC FORUM AMPHITHEATER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-17-CS03

PROVINCIAL CORRESPONDENT
Keeper Veyne, are the Crownmarks dangerous?

SELENE
They are consequential.

PROVINCIAL CORRESPONDENT
That was not my question.

SELENE
It was the accurate answer. We have evidence that interaction with one Sovereign system can change the state of others, but we do not yet understand every consequence.

Another journalist receives recognition.

PROVINCIAL CORRESPONDENT
Does the Reformation control all active Crownmarks?

SELENE
No.

PROVINCIAL CORRESPONDENT
Who does?

SELENE
I will not identify individual bearers while active security risks remain.

A Mestria University historian rises. Selene recognizes the question before he asks it.

HISTORIAN
Those are not stylistic differences. They invert the moral relationship.

SELENE
They do.

HISTORIAN
Was the public Admonition altered?

Hold Selene's face. Behind her eyes: the verified memorandum, dark fifth point, signed deadline. She knows; neither ignorance nor uncertainty excuses this answer.

SELENE
That question is part of an active provenance review.

HISTORIAN
You already know, don't you? Keeper?

SELENE
What I can tell you tonight, is that the record exists and has been independently authenticated.

HISTORIAN
The people of the Reformation deserve to see it.

SELENE
Yes.

Selene opens Tharne's public attestation on every Forum display.

ON SCREEN:
DISCLOSURE DEADLINE: FIXED
DISCRETIONARY EXTENSION: PROHIBITED

SELENE
A signed disclosure commitment now exists outside CII custody. Seven independently verifiable packages carry it. The complete evidentiary record will be released when the associated Continuity hazard is neutralized, or within twenty days whether it has been neutralized or not. Whichever occurs first.

HISTORIAN
Who can extend the deadline?

SELENE
No one.

HISTORIAN
Complete?

SELENE
Yes.

HISTORIAN
Without redaction?

SELENE
The authenticated record, Not a summary prepared by the government it implicates.

A Dominion press marker gains the floor. Voss straightens.

DOMINION CORRESPONDENT
Keeper Veyne, does Reformation legitimacy survive if its founders deliberately falsified the King's final civic instruction?

SELENE
Does Dominion legitimacy fail if the King rejected hereditary sovereignty? The difficulty with using history only as a weapon, is that eventually someone reads the rest of it. The King's civic counsel challenges both of our civilizations. If the Reformation altered his warnings regarding institutions, that matters. If the Dominion inherited his symbols while ignoring his warnings regarding personal sovereignty, that matters too.

DOMINION CORRESPONDENT
So you concede the Reformation altered the record.

SELENE
I said no such thing.

DOMINION CORRESPONDENT
Your wording implies it.

SELENE
Your question implied your preferred conclusion before I answered.

A few people laugh, then the young provincial reporter receives the final question without a rhetorical trap.

YOUNG REPORTER
Keeper Veyne, if the Reformation has made mistakes about its own history, why should anyone trust it now?

SELENE
Because trust is not the belief that an institution has never failed. It is the judgment that the institution remains capable of confronting failure without requiring everyone inside it to pretend the failure never happened. I believe in law. I believe in evidence. I believe institutions can protect people from the failures of rulers, generals, charismatic leaders, and frightened majorities. I also believe no institution becomes righteous merely because it survives.

She looks from judges to Keepers to Voss.

SELENE
The Reformation does not need a perfect past. It needs the courage to tell the truth about the past it actually has. Order exists that people may flourish. If we believe that, then we should be strong enough to live by it.

Selene leaves the lectern. After two seconds a small section applauds; others join, some remain seated. The applause never becomes unanimous. She passes into the backstage corridor.

65 INT. CENTRAL CIVIC FORUM - BACKSTAGE - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-17-CS04

The public feed fills with Selene's face beside the King's wording.

VOSS
Before tonight, you were an internal compliance problem.

SELENE
I am not a problem.

VOSS
You broke into Glass Citadel.

SELENE
Fair.

VOSS
Now people can organize around you.

SELENE
I did not ask them to.

VOSS
Neither did he.

A new phrase appears on the feed.

ON SCREEN:
VEYNE DOCTRINE

VOSS
You have spent two days arguing that civilization must not surrender moral responsibility to singular authority.

SELENE
Yes.

VOSS
Then you stood before the Reach and became one.

SELENE
No.

VOSS
You do not get to decide that.

Lyric steps close, her voice no longer teasing.

LYRIC
The historian asked whether the Admonition had been altered. You knew the answer.

SELENE
Yes.

LYRIC
You gave him a review. How did it feel?

SELENE
Necessary.

LYRIC
That was not what I asked.

SELENE
Awful.

LYRIC
Good. Keep it awful.

THARNE
She defined an endpoint.

VOSS
What?

THARNE
The disclosure hold. We created a signed commitment. The complete record will be distributed when terminal containment is stabilized and release authority is disabled, or twenty-four hours after the current ingress window closes. Whichever comes first.

SELENE
No extensions, No discretionary review. No later conclusion that the Reach remains unready.

VOSS
You built a procedural safeguard against becoming me.

SELENE
Yes.

VOSS
Good. You may need it.

A small shared silence ends when Voss returns to governing.

VOSS
Your public operational authority is suspended. Your Keeper commission remains active pending review. CII access is frozen, further media appearances require Council authorization, and your travel authority is suspended inside Reformation jurisdiction pending Glass Citadel review. Ensign Vadem, professional conduct review effective immediately. System credentials suspended.

THARNE
Understood.

Tharne's archives, provenance tools and analytical layers turn gray. He carefully locks the screen.

VOSS
Agent Vale, your deferred security files are reopened.

SELENE
That is retaliation.

VOSS
It is leverage.

A last cached alert changes Selene's classification.

ON SCREEN:
ADVERSARIAL CONTINUITY VARIABLE

The open Glass Citadel log replaces the revoked internal feed: Supremacy petition, Dominion legation, Reformation legal craft and Defense Council escorts.

VOSS
We did not authorize the military escorts.

SELENE
Who did?

VOSS
Defense Council. I am Chancellor, not sovereign. Orison completed a local mirror of the Meridian route. Crownwatch received a fleet-compatible navigation package: Aurelion's stellar frame, ingress timing, and approach corridor.

Selene reads Tarrik's independent operational authentication petition separately from the legation's terminal inquiry.

VOSS
Go somewhere difficult to find.

SELENE
You suspended my travel authority.

VOSS
I know.

SELENE
That sounded suspiciously like an instruction.

VOSS
It was not official. The safeguard. Keep it.

Voss leaves. Later, the Forum empties. Beyond the window Mestria's transit, hospitals and restaurants still function; Lyric rests with a hand against her collar.

THARNE
Eleven minutes.

SELENE
What?

THARNE
The first exact quotation entered a provincial academic mirror eleven minutes after you spoke it. That mirror replicated into independent civic archives, Dominion historical networks, legal repositories, and local Reformation systems. Central Information Integrity could erase every official recording of the speech tonight, It would not matter.

LYRIC
Your cathedral again.

The independent web of copies expands. Selene looks at it without a victory smile.

SCOR 18 LAST THRONE, LAST WOUND

66 INT./EXT. AURELION OBSERVATION PLATFORM / GLASS CITADEL - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-18-CS01

HISTORICAL FRAME: nine days after Aurelion's Sundering. An injured ink-stained chronicler sits beneath a fractured observation window. The King is absent; no answer to his fate is supplied. He writes in a physical book.

ON SCREEN:
When four lights burn around the Wound, the gates of Aurelion will remember the hand that made them.

Match the paper to Lyessa's hand on the black recorder case aboard the present-day shuttle. Glass Citadel replaces Dominion channels with its sovereign notice.

ON SCREEN:
REMOTE COMMAND AUTHORITY: SUSPENDED
WEAPON SYSTEMS: PROHIBITED
RECORD ALTERATION ATTEMPT: AUTOMATIC EXPULSION

LYESSA
They remain optimistic about expulsion.

TARRIK
Selene got out.

LYESSA
That is not the reassuring example you think it is.

The shuttle docks. Astell waits at the threshold with officers holding compact weapons low.

ASTELL
High Centurion Walcur, Glass Citadel has received your petition.

TARRIK
Then you know what I'm carrying.

ASTELL
You also requested independent authentication, permanent neutral custody, and public replication upon verification.

TARRIK
Yes.

ASTELL
Your supplemental witness?

LYESSA
And a participant.

ASTELL
You will surrender every communication device, weapon, mutable storage system, and active command credential before entry. Your vessel may remain in approach jurisdiction for four hours. Dominion support craft will not cross the outer boundary.

TARRIK
Agreed.

ASTELL
If Crownwatch orders you to leave?

TARRIK
They already have.

ASTELL
Then we should not waste your remaining time.

All weapons and devices are surrendered before crossing. In the verification room, instruments inspect the recorder while both participants keep their hands visible. An image of younger Lyessa freezes one second before she fires at Darek behind the barrier.

ASTELL
Your statement identifies you as the officer who accepted field command.

LYESSA
Yes.

ASTELL
You acted under an Imperial Continuity order.

LYESSA
Yes.

ASTELL
Do you claim coercion?

LYESSA
I claim context.

ASTELL
That was not my question.

LYESSA
No. Do not classify the statement as coerced.

ASTELL
Do you claim diminished responsibility due to age, command pressure, or incomplete information?

LYESSA
Those facts belong in the record, They do not remove my name from it.

ASTELL
Once replicated, your testimony cannot be withdrawn.

LYESSA
I know.

ASTELL
It may result in criminal review by Dominion or Reformation authority.

LYESSA
I know.

ASTELL
It will not establish forgiveness.

Lyessa looks at Tarrik for the first time in the testimony. There is no appeal.

LYESSA
I know.

An outer table credential receives repeated Crownwatch and Cross calls, then Caelus's sovereign priority. Tarrik does not move.

ASTELL
You may answer from the docking chamber.

TARRIK
Is the record authenticated?

ASTELL
Not yet.

TARRIK
Then he can wait.

67 INT. GLASS CITADEL - NEUTRAL VERIFICATION CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-18-CS02

The Cauldron reconstruction dissolves into the external certificate.

ON SCREEN:
WITNESS IV RECORD: AUTHENTICATED
INTERNAL SEQUENCE: COMPLETE
MODERN SUPPLEMENTAL TESTIMONY: VOLUNTARILY ATTESTED
EXTERNAL CUSTODIAL AUTHORITY: GLASS CITADEL

Astell opens two release fields. Index images show Dominion containment order, Reformation assault and experiments, Darek's death and Lyessa's supplemental statement. No disputed aggregate appears.

ASTELL
The record contains no Aurelion route data, Operational details of current terminal containment are not part of this release. Living medical subjects will be identified by case designation where public naming would create additional harm. No political or command authority names have been removed. Authorization belongs to the depositing bearer.

LYESSA
Release it.

Tarrik turns toward her.

LYESSA
You said the Dominion first, Give them enough time to know the truth reached them before everyone else reads what they do with it.

TARRIK
After that, your name goes with it.

LYESSA
It already should have.

Tarrik places his palm against the first field. The authenticated record transmits to Crownwatch. Hold nine seconds in restrained real time, watching receipt. He touches the second field.

ON SCREEN:
PUBLIC REPLICATION: AUTHORIZED

Copies propagate into neutral mirrors, Dominion civic archives, Reformation evidence networks and Cauldron memorial repositories. Cross's name, Lyessa's name and Reformation command identities remain visible. The recorder withdraws into permanent custody.

ASTELL
Glass Citadel has not vindicated you, High Centurion.

TARRIK
I didn't ask it to.

ASTELL
Good. History is not absolution.

Tarrik reads Darek's entry without moving.

TARRIK
No. But it can stop the lie from being the only thing that survives him.

68 INT. SUPREMACY - COMMAND ROOM - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-18-CS03

Cauldron records await in every officer's queue beneath the Aurelion projection. Cross addresses the Supremacy's remote panel.

CROSS
You distributed classified operational evidence during an active Continuity crisis.

TARRIK
Glass Citadel authenticated it.

CROSS
That is not a defense.

TARRIK
No. It is provenance.

CROSS
The record exposes containment doctrine, field identities, and historical vulnerabilities to hostile analysis.

TARRIK
It exposes what you did.

CAELUS
Cauldron will receive a separate command inquiry. The record will not be withdrawn. It cannot be withdrawn, You kept your condition.

TARRIK
Yes.

CAELUS
Then you will bear what follows it.

TARRIK
Yes.

CAELUS
Tell me what the fifth Crownmark does.

TARRIK
It completes the release authority. Whatever happens after that, it puts opening the prison in someone's hands.

CONTINUITY SCHOLAR
That remains an interpretation.

TARRIK
The Meridian calls the structure a prison and tracks containment release progression. Four remote anchors are release-ready. The fifth is the terminal authority. Completing it unifies control of the release sequence.

CAELUS
Then that is the strongest argument yet for ensuring the Reformation does not control it.

TARRIK
They'll say the same about us.

CAELUS
Then they should stay away.

The neutral terminal lexicon offers multiple readings. Dominion's chosen rendering overlaps the mark's response.

ON SCREEN:
LAST THRONE
LAST WOUND

TARRIK
I believe everyone keeps finding the version of the King they already wanted.

CAELUS
And you?

TARRIK
I'm trying not to.

Amber capital ships, carriers and troop transports form around the projected ingress corridor.

CAELUS
We are not activating anything. Our mandate is access denial and site security. Form the Sovereign Expeditionary Group, Establish staging positions outside the ingress corridor. No vessel enters the Wound before the calculated window. Crownmark Five will not be activated without direct Sovereign authorization.

VAREN
If Reformation vessels establish the perimeter first?

CAELUS
They will be instructed to withdraw.

VAREN
And if they refuse?

CAELUS
Remove them.

TARRIK
You're building a fleet around a lock you claim you won't touch.

CAELUS
I am building a fleet around a lock I will not allow someone else to touch.

TARRIK
The distinction may disappear when both fleets arrive.

CAELUS
Then make certain ours arrives in control. You will accompany the expedition.

TARRIK
Cross?

CAELUS
He comes. You know more about this architecture than any officer under my command. You believe Crownmark Five could endanger the Reach. Good. Stand where the decision will be made.

TARRIK
Fine.

After the council, Tarrik stands on the Supremacy observation deck. Lyessa stops half a meter beside him.

LYESSA
Are you going?

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
Because Caelus ordered you?

TARRIK
No. I'm going because if I'm not there, Cross will be.

LYESSA
And if Caelus orders you to take Crownmark Five?

TARRIK
I don't know. And you?

LYESSA
I'm going.

TARRIK
Because I am?

LYESSA
No. Because my name is in that record, Cross is going to Aurelion, and I know what happens when he decides uncertainty is permission. You decide what you do, I'll decide what I do.

She leaves him with the assembled fleet.

69 INT. MESTRIA - CONTINUITY COUNCIL CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-18-CS04

Seven voting positions surround the oval table. Dominion force estimates appear above it; Selene's public outer deadline counts beside them.

SOL
Crownwatch has authorized an expeditionary concentration around the Aurelion approach region. Current estimate is four capital vessels, nine carriers, twenty-two lance cruisers, and support sufficient for sustained independent operations.

SELENE
What is the proposed response?

SOL
Deployment.

SELENE
Already authorized?

SOL
Under consideration. We require your assessment of the terminal risk.

SELENE
Crownmark Five is not simply another relic, The authenticated terminal record identifies it as release authority. Primary containment remains closed because the terminal anchor remains sealed.

PROVINCIAL DELEGATE
What occurs upon activation?

SELENE
The most responsible answer is that we do not know.

SOL
We cannot permit Dominion forces to establish uncontested control of terminal architecture.

SELENE
You are saying exactly what Caelus is saying.

SOL
The motives are not equivalent.

SELENE
No. The behavior is.

Neither she nor the Council finds comfort in the comparison.

SOL
Keeper Veyne, if Crownmark Five controls the containment architecture you described, permitting a hostile sovereign power to possess it would be negligent.

SELENE
I agree. Which is why none of us should possess it.

SOL
Neutral custody?

SELENE
Glass Citadel.

SOL
Glass Citadel cannot defend Aurelion from a Dominion expeditionary force.

SELENE
It can authenticate a mutual-exclusion agreement.

SOL
It cannot enforce one.

VOSS
Then negotiate joint exclusion.

NAVAL OFFICER
If Dominion establishes the outer perimeter first, every Reformation vessel arriving later can be classified as the aggressor.

SOL
Then we arrive first.

Voss's diplomatic-first motion faces Naval Command's deployment-in-parallel response. The proposed mandate appears.

ON SCREEN:
NO CROWNMARK ACTIVATION WITHOUT COUNCIL AUTHORIZATION

Seven votes appear: Voss and two provincial delegates no; four yes. Deployment is authorized. No applause.

ON SCREEN:
DEPLOYMENT AUTHORIZED: 4-3

SOL
Keeper Veyne will accompany the Protection Group under emergency Continuity authority.

SELENE
My travel authorization was suspended two hours ago.

SOL
Emergency authority supersedes the suspension.

LYRIC
Congratulations. She has been unsuspended into a war.

SELENE
Tharne comes.

SOL
Ensign Vadem remains under professional review.

SELENE
He reconstructed the Glass Citadel provenance chain and understands the Meridian better than anyone your current credentials can summon. He comes.

SOL
Agreed.

LYRIC
And the corrupted revolutionary?

VOSS
Agent Vale will accompany Keeper Veyne under medical and intelligence supervision.

The room empties. Tharne negotiates temporary credentials; Lyric disputes monitored status. Selene remains beside Voss at the fleet model.

SELENE
You wanted a government no single person could command.

VOSS
I still do. Then accept that sometimes no single person can stop it either. I voted against deployment, I lost.

SELENE
You think that will be enough?

VOSS
No.

SELENE
If they order me to activate the fifth Crownmark while primary containment remains closed, I will refuse.

VOSS
Do not make promises before you understand the situation.

SELENE
No. If primary containment is closed and the Council orders activation, I will refuse.

VOSS
If you obstruct lawful Continuity authority at Aurelion, I will no longer be able to treat you as a Keeper exercising professional judgment.

SELENE
What will you treat me as?

VOSS
An adversary.

SELENE
Then don't ask me to choose between your authority and keeping the prison closed.

Voss starts to leave, then stops.

VOSS
Whatever you think of the vote, go to Aurelion.

SELENE
Why?

VOSS
Because if everyone there becomes convinced that they alone are the responsible one, I want at least one person present who remains frightened by that thought.

70 INT. SUPREMACY / ACCORD - PREPARATION ROOMS - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-18-CS05

A transparent transfer bridge to the Accord. Ianis's ordinary pulse catches; violet lines move beneath Lyric's collar. She braces against the wall. Tharne stops himself before touching her.

THARNE
What do you feel?

LYRIC
Pressure.

SELENE
From Ianis?

LYRIC
No.

THARNE
Then from what?

LYRIC
Attention. It knows something changed.

SELENE
How do you know?

LYRIC
I don't. That's what it felt like.

On the Supremacy, Lyessa plays Selene's public recording. The familiar Keeper stands before her crowd.

SELENE (RECORDED)
Inheritance is not permission.

LYESSA
She was talking about us.

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
And them.

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
Do you trust her?

TARRIK
No. But I trust that she went to Glass Citadel when her government wanted the record contained. I trust that she told the Reach enough to wound her own authority and still kept Aurelion off the public feed.

LYESSA
That is not trust in her.

TARRIK
No. I trust the choices.

On the Accord, Tharne brings Selene the independently authenticated Cauldron index and a three-source Rathis report. Lyric drops her boot from the console when she reads Lyessa's voluntary testimony.

SELENE
She testified against herself.

LYRIC
People occasionally surprise you when given terrible options.

THARNE
Central Information Integrity's behavioral model for Tarrik Walcur is materially inaccurate.

Selene reads denied orbital suppression, restored medical power and refused collective punishment.

SELENE
He doesn't trust them anymore.

THARNE
That does not imply he trusts us.

SELENE
No. But perhaps he sees the same problem.

The fleets enter their parallel staging formations, amber and blue. The same terminal glyph appears under two operation names.

ON SCREEN:
OPERATION LAST THRONE
OPERATION LAST WOUND

On the Supremacy command deck, Lyessa studies Tarrik's actual goal.

LYESSA
Before the Reformation?

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
Before Crownwatch?

TARRIK
Before anyone who believes possession gives them the right to decide.

LYESSA
To take the Crownmark?

TARRIK
No.

LYESSA
Secure it?

TARRIK
No.

LYESSA
Then what?

TARRIK
Keep anyone from touching it.

On the Accord, Lyric and Tharne read their own mandate. Selene answers its real purpose.

THARNE
We are racing them to secure the terminal site.

SELENE
No.

LYRIC
Then what exactly are we doing?

SELENE
Keeping anyone from touching it.

LYRIC
Good.

Neon Veil and Caerion II lift in separate ships. Each bearer sees the other's room and assembled fleet. Neither voice crosses. Tarrik shakes his head once; Selene answers the gesture with her own. The connection breaks, leaving both armies in place.

LYRIC
What did he mean?

SELENE
I don't know.

THARNE
That may be the most accurate diplomatic exchange either faction has managed all day.

HISTORICAL INTERCUT: the chronicler's ink nearly runs out. His final warning is visible as writing, not a spoken proclamation.

ON SCREEN:
The gates will not fail when the wicked conquer the Reach. They will fail when the righteous become certain that only they may hold the lock.

In the abandoned Cauldron chamber, no character watches the local reading degrade. Beneath distant Aurelion, no fleet receives the terminal warning.

ON SCREEN:
LOCAL BOUNDARY: DEGRADED
REMOTE ANCHORS: 4 / 4 RELEASE-READY
TERMINAL ANCHOR: SEALED
PRIMARY CONTAINMENT: CLOSED
BOUNDARY PRESSURE: RISING

Beyond the contained side of the sensor field, a vast violet shape moves slowly without resolving. It passes out of sight.

ON SCREEN:
BOUNDARY CONTACT: DETECTED
ORIGIN: CONTAINED SIDE

Over eighteen days staging positions fill, neutral traffic diverts, and carrier counts and defensive requests answer each other. The ingress clock falls.

ON SCREEN:
EIGHTEEN DAYS OF STAGING

Cut to black.

SCOR 19 FIRE AND FROST

71 INT. GY SUPREMACY BRIDGE / ACCORD TACTICAL CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-19-CS01

Eighteen days after the fleets began moving.

The Supremacy emerges from transit. The white remnant burns hard; the red remnant sheds plasma. Between them, background stars bend around a black absence. Neutral-channel negotiation fragments show reciprocal withdrawal demands, then silence.

CAELUS
Status.

VAREN
Gravitational shear remains within the Glass Citadel projection. The western ingress corridor is stabilizing. Estimated window in seventeen minutes.

The navigation count reaches zero.

ON SCREEN:
INGRESS WINDOW OPEN

CAELUS
You feel it?

TARRIK
Yes.

CAELUS
The terminal anchor?

TARRIK
Inside the Wound. Or beneath it. The Meridian still cannot distinguish the geometry.

CAELUS
Then the order remains exact. You will enter the terminal architecture and establish its condition. You will not touch Crownmark Five. You will not complete the Meridian. If stabilization is possible without either act, you will report it before proceeding.

TARRIK
Understood.

CAELUS
Advance.

Dominion engines ignite like crowns. Reformation lights appear on the opposite approach. Neon Veil responds to the Accord.

LYESSA
They're early.

TARRIK
No, They think we're late.

Cut to Accord. Sol's non-initiation order plays over the drone lanes. Tharne enlarges the two references until the difference is obvious.

SOL
All units maintain non-initiation posture. Dominion exclusion broadcasts are not recognized outside treaty-defined navigational safety authority. Weapons remain cold unless fired upon.

THARNE
The Dominion perimeter is calculated from Orison's fleet solution. Ours uses Glass Citadel's pre-Sundering reference.

SELENE
How far?

THARNE
Seven-point-three kilometers.

SELENE
Why did neither side identify this during negotiation?

THARNE
Each concluded the other's reference was derivative.

SELENE
Command, this is Keeper Veyne. Dominion and Reformation perimeter models are misaligned. Mapping Group Three is inside their declared exclusion zone.

SOL
Confirmed. We transmitted a correction notice four minutes ago.

SELENE
Recall the drones.

SOL
They are establishing the ingress field.

SELENE
They are also crossing a line Dominion point defense has been authorized to defend.

SOL
Keeper, they are unarmed.

SELENE
So were the people who walked into the streets on Rathis.

The drones turn under recall. Shear delays the shared update; the lead unit's shorter return vector points briefly toward the Dominion cruiser. A human override request lags behind the defense threshold. Two drone marks vanish.

SOL
Confirm hostile action.

SELENE
Automated response to a disputed boundary incursion, Do not answer. If we fire now, the next shot becomes a choice.

Sol lets two seconds pass. His decision is human, not another automatic response.

SOL
One proportional response.

Sol owns the order before narrowing its intended damage.

SOL
Disable the firing system. No hull strike.

SELENE
We can establish that neither side will turn a machine's decision into a war.

The missile is already away. The emitter explodes; the Dominion secondary battery tears three decks from Meridian Cold. Weapons paths multiply. Cut to Supremacy.

TARRIK
Order every ship cold.

CAELUS
I have. Local acknowledgments are delayed by the Wound. Varen, push through every tightbeam and Echo repeater.

Acknowledgments arrive out of order. Sovereign Mercy's lance charges outside Supremacy's control.

TARRIK
Don't.

The lance erases a Reformation carrier's drone deck. Reformation drones blind Sovereign Mercy. A cruiser splits amidships. Tarrik watches crews become debris.

TARRIK
This is insane.

LYESSA
Yes.

The red remnant erupts. Both fleets turn to survive the same plasma wall while still firing. The Wound's edge deepens.

72 INT./EXT. AURELION COMBAT GRID / DOMINION INSERTION SHUTTLE - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-19-CS02

An engine-dead King-era ship rotates without thrust. Black tissue replaces its missing hull. Fine violet connections trail back through the Wound. It closes around a Reformation destroyer.

VAREN
Unknown contact entering the combat grid.

EMERGENCY VOICE
Boarding event. Seal deck nine. Something is inside the walls. Cut power. Cut power now.

The destroyer's relit engines burn violet. Other tethered shapes press through. One corrupted vessel fires on Dominion armor, then the Accord's drones. The drones rotate toward their own carrier.

THARNE
Control contamination.

SELENE
Sever every external command link.

THARNE
Already attempting it.

Point defense clears most drones. One strikes Accord with a hard knock. Black tissue enters its hull; Lyric collapses without physical contact.

SELENE
Lyric.

LYRIC
I know.

THARNE
What do you feel?

LYRIC
Not ships.

THARNE
What?

LYRIC
They aren't separate.

SELENE
What is touching us?

LYRIC
All of it. They're awake.

SELENE
Who?

LYRIC
Everything on the other side.

ON SCREEN:
OUTER BOUNDARY CONTACT: MULTIPLE
PRIMARY CONTAINMENT: CLOSED
TERMINAL STABILIZATION STATUS: UNKNOWN

LYRIC
I can feel them touching the ship.

SELENE
Can they feel you?

Lyric takes too long to answer.

LYRIC
Yes.

THARNE
Look at me. Lyric.

Her gaze finds him; the violet ring recedes slightly. Sol opens the insertion channel.

SOL
Keeper Veyne, terminal telemetry is deteriorating. Extraction Group Seven is cleared for immediate insertion. You will proceed to the access complex and establish whether the terminal anchor can stabilize the outer boundary without Meridian completion.

ON SCREEN:
SPECIMEN RECOVERY PLATFORMS: 2

SELENE
Why are sample recovery units attached to a stabilization team?

SOL
They are attached to the mission, not your team.

SELENE
You brought cages into an active containment failure.

SOL
We brought research assets capable of identifying how contamination crosses Echo systems. The next outbreak will not wait for us to become morally comfortable with understanding it.

LYRIC
Do not let them put anything in those.

SELENE
Keep the recovery platforms away from my insertion route.

SOL
That is an operational command decision.

SELENE
Then make a better one.

She cuts the channel and helps Lyric stand. Match cut to three black cylinders ringed in amber in Supremacy's bay.

TARRIK
You're coming down?

CROSS
No. But those are.

TARRIK
What are they?

CROSS
Field resonators. They isolate contaminated biomass from the surrounding Echo environment long enough to determine how it propagates.

TARRIK
You brought cages.

CROSS
I brought countermeasures.

TARRIK
Against something you intend to bring home.

CROSS
Against something that will come home eventually whether we understand it or not.

TARRIK
You watched Cauldron. You saw what one uncertain exposure became, and your answer was to collect another.

CROSS
My answer was to study the thing that nearly ended civilization. For four centuries there has been nowhere else to do that.

TARRIK
Then wait another four.

CROSS
The resonators carry separate Sovereign authorization. Your mission is terminal stabilization.

LYESSA
The shuttle is ready.

TARRIK
Those do not go near the terminal.

Cross does not answer. Tarrik boards. The shuttle crosses a gravitational veil; white-gold rings surround black-rock fragments. A Reformation craft crosses ahead.

LYESSA
Tracking.

TARRIK
Only tracking.

LYESSA
It is heading toward the same site.

TARRIK
So are we.

LYESSA
That is traditionally why I prepare to shoot things.

TARRIK
Not yet.

ON SCREEN:
BOUNDARY EXTRUSION: PROXIMAL

A black shape penetrates the forward pressure shell. Violet filaments grow between the glass layers.

PILOT
Contamination, Forward pressure shell is changing state.

TARRIK
Open the rear pressure door.

PILOT
We're in vacuum.

TARRIK
I know. Seal suits, Open it.

Suit seals and magnetic boots engage. The rear door releases. Tarrik drives Velkorran into the infected wall, sends Cinder through the tissue and tears the biomass into vacuum. Its tether snaps. Something strikes the port engine.

The terminal fills the cockpit. Impact whites out the image. Tarrik, Lyessa and five surviving Dominion soldiers emerge from the wreckage.

73 INT. AURELION - DOCKING CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-19-CS03

The dropship slides sideways into a structural support. Its restraints lock. Gravity chooses a new floor. Selene braces her forearm.

SELENE
Anchor.

A tether catches an ancient rib. A second catches the opposite wall. The dropship hangs thirty meters above the new floor; gravity changes again. Landing struts collapse, but the cabin holds.

The rear hatch opens onto frost-lit white-gold walls with black stains beneath the ice. Lyric steps down and sags; Tharne catches her. She accepts the support.

THARNE
Talk to me.

LYRIC
I hate that sentence.

THARNE
Talk anyway.

LYRIC
There are things inside this place.

Selene draws the circular hilt of Verity; its opposed blue-white edges ignite.

SELENE
What kind?

LYRIC
The kind that know we came.

An already-moving shadow gives Selene present evidence. A limb punches through the wall. She channels Frost through Verity, arrests the impact, freezes the joint and shatters it with the opposite edge.

Black droplets crawl toward Lyric. Tharne's pulse round scatters them.

THARNE
Move.

Selene and her team run into the corridor.

74 INT. AURELION - FIRST INTERIOR CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-19-CS04

A soldier screams. Black tissue has entered his gauntlet; violet light advances beneath his forearm. Tarrik catches his shoulder.

TARRIK
Cut it.

MALIK
What?

TARRIK
The arm. Now.

Lyessa draws a field blade. Malik sees it.

MALIK
No.

For an instant, green diagnostic bands and Darek at Gate Nine fracture across Tarrik's perception. Return to the black line advancing another centimeter. Lyessa meets Tarrik's eyes and waits for him to own the order.

TARRIK
Do it.

Lyessa cuts. Malik falls. The severed limb is consumed; the man remains human. Tarrik kneels and seals the wound.

TARRIK
Name.

MALIK
Varo.

TARRIK
Full name.

MALIK
Centurion Malik Varo.

TARRIK
Stay with us, Malik.

Malik stares at the consumed arm. He cannot finish the question.

MALIK
Was I...

TARRIK
I don't know, But you're still here.

Tarrik holds his eyes long enough for the distinction to land. Distant fire shakes the corridor. Two soldiers take Malik between them.

TARRIK
Move.

The two carriers support Malik as the group continues onward.

75 INT. AURELION - CIRCULAR CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-19-CS05

The frozen passage opens over a vast white-gold shaft. Amber and blue-white fire crosses the transparent ceiling. Lyessa emerges first. Selene flashes on a dark-haired woman with a weapon beneath a red sky; Tarrik kneels ahead of her. The image vanishes.

ON SCREEN:
DO NOT LET HIM KNEEL.

Tarrik follows, Velkorran lit. Rifles rise on both sides.

TARRIK
Veyne.

SELENE
Walcur.

TARRIK
Hold fire.

SELENE
Hold fire.

TARRIK
No one approaches the terminal.

SELENE
I agree.

TARRIK
Then withdraw your team.

SELENE
So yours can continue?

TARRIK
My orders are to establish terminal condition without activating it.

SELENE
So are mine.

LYRIC
If everyone is finished proving they brought rifles, the prison is trying to eat the building.

LYESSA
What happened to you?

LYRIC
Long story. Poor timing.

Tarrik moves toward the shaft. Selene puts herself in his path.

TARRIK
Move.

SELENE
No.

TARRIK
Something inside the Wound is using the terminal structure to reach both fleets.

SELENE
Which is why neither faction enters alone.

TARRIK
You are offering joint custody?

SELENE
I am refusing unilateral access.

TARRIK
That sounds familiar.

SELENE
Good. Then you understand it.

ON SCREEN:
OUTER BOUNDARY LOAD: RISING

TARRIK
I am going down.

SELENE
No.

He steps. She fires her tether around his weapon arm. He catches it before the reel triggers. Egdredil unfolds.

TARRIK
Hold means hold.

SELENE
Hold fire.

Both teams obey. Tarrik pulls; Selene deliberately rides the momentum. Verity meets Velkorran. Selene engages Tarrik, meeting each exchange with Frost and evasive steps.

76 INT./EXT. AURELION - CIRCULAR SHAFT AND FALLING CARRIER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-19-CS06

A configured duel finisher brings Verity to Velkorran near Tarrik's throat. Heat burns crystal from the blade.

TARRIK
You brought an army to a prison.

SELENE
So did you.

TARRIK
Your fleet fired the first intentional shot.

SELENE
After yours killed our drones.

TARRIK
They crossed our perimeter.

SELENE
According to your history of where the star used to be.

The ceiling turns blue-white. A Dominion lance misses Accord and removes the engines from the carrier behind it. The ship begins falling.

THARNE
Selene!

ON SCREEN:
CREW: 7,184
IMPACT: 00:01:31

Selene reads the crew count, then the armed man between her and the shaft. She turns away from him and runs to the ancient control ring.

SELENE
Come on.

ON SCREEN:
INSUFFICIENT FIELD POWER
INSUFFICIENT THRUST
TERMINAL IMPACT PROBABILITY: 96.2%

THARNE
The local stabilizers were designed to hold station mass, not redirect a carrier.

SELENE
Give me its remaining propulsion.

THARNE
Primary engines are gone.

SELENE
Maneuvering jets.

THARNE
They cannot move seven million tons.

SELENE
They do not need to. They need to move the impact line.

Tharne links the damaged guidance net through Accord. At the stabilizer Selene sustains Frost while he synchronizes the remaining jets.

The field coheres for less than two seconds. Remaining jets fire. The hull moves almost imperceptibly. Seven million tons passes less than three hundred meters above the complex, scrapes a tower and falls beyond the impact line.

The tactical field still carries 7,184 crew. They are alive, not certified safe. Selene releases the stabilizer and turns. Tarrik has not moved into her back or toward the shaft. Velkorran remains lowered.

They exchange a silent look. Wounded voices scream below. Tarrik looks once at the fifth-anchor shaft, then runs toward the people. Selene checks Lyric and Tharne and follows.

SCOR 20 AT THE SAME TIME

77 INT. AURELION - LOWER BREACH CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-20-CS01

A four-meter organism carries a living Dominion officer inside its torso. His face is still human.

OFFICER
Kill me.

Tarrik drives Cinder through the organism's center, killing the officer before the body falls. He reaches a Reformation marine pinned beneath plating. The man hesitates at the enemy hand, then takes it.

TARRIK
Move.

Selene's Stillfield slows a ceiling attacker; Tarrik breaks the opening. They turn toward the regenerating organism.

SELENE
Hold it.

Tarrik holds position. Selene freezes the limb; Velkorran shatters the joint. Cinder heats the core armor while Frost arrests the same surface. Lyessa's Egdredil round ruptures the exposed core.

Lyric staggers in, violet lines across her face and eye. Tharne stays close enough to catch her.

LYESSA
What is happening to you?

LYRIC
Charming concern.

LYESSA
Answer me.

LYRIC
The prison knows what I am.

Her attempted joke fails. She collapses into Tharne; black patterns race down both arms.

THARNE
Lyric.

SELENE
Look at me.

LYRIC
No. No, no...

THARNE
What do you see?

LYRIC
They aren't leaking.

SELENE
What?

LYRIC
They're reaching.

The floor convulses.

LYRIC
They know the marks are here.

Her head snaps toward Tarrik with inhuman exactness. The person remains, but another attention presses through. Tarrik raises Velkorran. Tharne puts himself between blade and Lyric.

THARNE
Don't.

TARRIK
Get her away from the Crownmarks.

THARNE
I am trying.

Lyric grips Tharne's wrist hard enough to hurt. He leaves his hand with her.

THARNE
Lyric. Stay here. Not there, Here.

Her gaze finds his. Hold silence until she blinks and breathes.

LYRIC
Tharne.

THARNE
I'm here.

She sees his wrist and lets go.

LYRIC
Sorry.

THARNE
Later.

LYRIC
You keep saying that.

Her laugh is weak and human. A new alarm draws attention to two containment platforms outside the terminal.

78 INT. AURELION - LOWER BREACH - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-20-CS02

The external feed shows an amber-ringed Dominion resonator around a wounded extrusion and a Reformation cold-field around living hull tissue.

TARRIK
Yours?

SELENE
One of them. And yours.

LYRIC
Kill them.

SELENE
The specimens?

LYRIC
The cages.

Black tissue maps the cold-field boundary and enters its emitters' control paths. Fleet systems flicker.

THARNE
It's learning the containment architecture.

LYRIC
No. It's using it.

Amber harmonics carry the same invasion into Dominion remote control without a physical crossing of vacuum.

TARRIK
Destroy the resonator.

CROSS
Negative.

TARRIK
It has entered the control architecture.

CROSS
We can isolate the feedback.

TARRIK
You cannot.

CROSS
Tarrik, disengage from the platform.

TARRIK
Destroy it.

CROSS
We have the first intact autonomous Eclipse specimen recovered since the war.

TARRIK
Exactly.

Tarrik acquires the nearby external node with his High Centurion authority. Cross sees the transfer.

CROSS
Do not.

Tarrik confirms his decision. His lance battery vaporizes the Dominion platform, sample and compromised systems.

ON SCREEN:
UNAUTHORIZED FRIENDLY FIRE
SOVEREIGN REVIEW REQUIRED

At her separate fire-control node, Selene takes position.

SOL
Keeper Veyne, stand down.

SELENE
The field is transmitting contamination into fleet systems.

SOL
We can sever the platform.

SELENE
You should have severed it before putting the Eclipse inside your network.

SOL
Release fire control.

SELENE
No.

SOL
Veyne.

LYRIC
Do it.

Selene confirms. Accord's missiles fire. First volley destroys the drone and field; the second erases the fragment.

ON SCREEN:
UNAUTHORIZED FRIENDLY FIRE
CONTINUITY REVIEW REQUIRED

The leads meet each other's eyes while Cross and Sol continue issuing orders. Neither obeys. Outside, a Reformation destroyer saves a damaged Dominion cruiser; the cruiser's lance then clears the destroyer's pursuer.

THARNE
Selene, I can bridge local targeting.

SELENE
Between the fleets?

THARNE
Dominion and Reformation systems still share King-era ancestry. The authentication layers disagree. The threat grammar does not.

TARRIK
Can you keep command access isolated?

THARNE
Tracks and firing corridors only. No weapons authority.

TARRIK
Do it.

SELENE
Do it.

Tharne strips incompatible political certificates from the emergency exchange and connects the older syntax.

ON SCREEN:
LOCAL INTEROPERABILITY CHANNEL OPEN
THREAT CLASS: ECLIPSE
COMMAND AUTHORITY: ISOLATED

Amber lances and blue-white missiles turn toward the same tethered targets. This is local cooperation, not peace.

79 INT. AURELION - QUARANTINE JUNCTION - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-20-CS03

White-gold barriers ignite. Gravity pulls the group sideways.

ON SCREEN:
CONTAMINANT PATH ISOLATION
BEARER ROUTE PRESERVED

The floor divides between Tarrik and Lyessa. She jumps too late; a barrier rises.

LYESSA
Tarrik.

TARRIK
Lyessa.

A second wall drops between Selene and Tharne. Lyric is with him. Selene strikes it with Verity; Frost leaves no mark.

SELENE
Tharne.

THARNE
We're here.

Lyric screams behind him.

SELENE
Her condition?

THARNE
Worse.

SELENE
Move her away from the conduits.

THARNE
I am.

Another barrier cuts the channel. Selene extinguishes Verity's edges but keeps its ring in her hand. Tarrik stands alone across the chamber; only the descending corridor remains open.

TARRIK
I am not letting your fleet take it.

SELENE
I am not letting yours take it.

TARRIK
Good.

Velkorran's Cinder goes dark. Neither weapon is surrendered.

TARRIK
We go.

SELENE
Together?

TARRIK
At the same time.

SELENE
Acceptable.

They enter. The barrier shuts behind them; the battle sound vanishes. White-gold light follows their steps. Neon Veil warms; Caerion II answers.

ON SCREEN:
BEARER CONTINUITY DETECTED
SECONDARY CONTINUITY DETECTED

The interface pauses before resolving the designation.

ON SCREEN:
CONTRARY WITNESS CONFIRMED

SCOR 21 CONTRARY WITNESS

80 INT. AURELION - LOWER GALLERY - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-21-CS01

On the approach Selene studies the contrary designation. Their inactive weapons stay accessible.

SELENE
Contrary.

TARRIK
I noticed.

SELENE
I'm trying to determine whether it means ideological opposition, incompatible bearer signatures, or independent Continuity lineage.

TARRIK
That sounded more like Tharne than you.

SELENE
He is contagious.

They descend along the floor-lit passage. At the circular gallery, the black-gold geometry becomes legible.

SELENE
The Crownmark.

TARRIK
Subtle.

SELENE
I suspect subtlety was not among the design requirements.

Beyond the transparent boundary an immense violet movement withdraws inside the Wound.

SELENE
So much for the breach being finished.

TARRIK
It isn't through.

SELENE
No. But it's still reaching.

The door opens without either relic touching it. Human-scale Crownmark Five sits within vast concentric machines. The bearers stop short of it.

ON SCREEN:
MERIDIAN CONTINUITY: 4 / 5
REMOTE ANCHORS: 4 / 4 RELEASE-READY
TERMINAL ANCHOR: SEALED
PRIMARY CONTAINMENT: CLOSED
BEARER CONTINUITY A: VERIFIED
BEARER CONTINUITY B: VERIFIED
CONTINUITY RELATION: CONTRARY

SELENE
The terminal isn't treating one of us as subordinate to the other. It requires two independently resolved authorities.

TARRIK
One person can't complete it.

SELENE
Apparently not.

ON SCREEN:
WITNESS V ACCESS REQUIRES MERIDIAN COMPLETION
MERIDIAN COMPLETION WILL ENABLE TERMINAL AUTHORITY

TARRIK AND SELENE
No.

TARRIK
We leave it sealed.

SELENE
Wait.

Selene opens the diagnostic. Four vectors deliver asynchronous load toward a dark fifth node.

ON SCREEN:
REMOTE ANCHOR LOAD: ASYMMETRIC
TERMINAL REFERENCE: INCOMPLETE
BOUNDARY DEGRADATION: ACTIVE
CONTAINMENT STRESS: RISING

SELENE
The system was never meant to remain at four.

TARRIK
It's still sealed.

SELENE
The physical seal is holding. The reference array isn't. Every awakened Witness transferred containment load into the Meridian. Four remote anchors are active, but the terminal has never accepted their shared reference. It keeps correcting against an incomplete geometry.

TARRIK
That's why the Eclipse can reach through.

SELENE
It appears so.

ON SCREEN:
BOUNDARY PRESSURE: 138%
FORECAST TO CRITICAL FAILURE: 02:11:43

SELENE
There must be a way to return the remote anchors to dormancy.

ON SCREEN:
WITNESS COMPLETION: IRREVERSIBLE
REMOTE DORMANCY RESTORATION: UNAVAILABLE

Tarrik checks Neon Veil's withdrawal and Selene checks Caerion II. Both requests are denied.

ON SCREEN:
ANCHOR III WITHDRAWAL: DENIED
CONTAINMENT LOAD COMMITTED

TARRIK
Physical reintegration? Put Neon Veil back into its seal.

SELENE
It might repair the local fracture under the city. It would not erase the Witness or reverse the load transfer.

TARRIK
Cauldron stayed integrated.

SELENE
And still became release-ready. Custody never determined Meridian state. We assumed the Crownmarks were objects because objects are what we could carry.

TARRIK
They're references.

SELENE
And records. And locks.

An impact subtracts seventeen seconds from the forecast.

SELENE
If we do nothing, the boundary fails.

TARRIK
And if we complete the Meridian, we enable the authority Glass Citadel warned could open the prison.

SELENE
Yes.

TARRIK
So the choice is between arming the lock and letting the wall around it collapse.

Lyessa's comm breaks through nearby weapons fire.

LYESSA
We found a route around the quarantine barrier. Cross has Crownwatch teams moving toward the lower junction.

TARRIK
Keep them out.

LYESSA
I'm trying.

CROSS
Tarrik, Neon Veil's diagnostic harness is mirroring terminal status into the Crownwatch channel.

TARRIK
Then stop reading my armor.

CROSS
Complete the Meridian.

TARRIK
No.

CROSS
You have less than two hours before primary boundary failure. If you leave the system incomplete, the Eclipse crosses in force while two damaged fleets are sitting directly above it.

TARRIK
And after I complete it?

CROSS
We determine terminal control.

TARRIK
That is precisely the part I'm concerned about.

LYESSA
He said no.

CROSS
I was not speaking to you.

LYESSA
No. You were speaking around him, like you always do.

TARRIK
Do not come farther. Keep Cross's teams out.

Lyessa considers the choice rather than merely obeying.

LYESSA
I'll try.

Her channel dies. Tharne's opens over Lyric's scream.

THARNE
Pressure increased when the terminal recognized you. Ianis responded.

SELENE
Move her away from the conduits.

THARNE
I did.

SELENE
Tharne, is she conscious?

THARNE
Mostly.

SELENE
Mostly is not a medical state.

THARNE
I am aware.

LYRIC
Selene.

SELENE
I'm here.

LYRIC
Don't leave it like this. It's pulling.

SELENE
What is?

LYRIC
Everything.

THARNE
Her corruption is responding to the incomplete reference state. The terminal pressure and whatever connection exists between her and the contained side appear to be reinforcing each other.

SELENE
Can she survive two hours?

THARNE
I don't know.

LYRIC
Make it quiet.

The channel cuts. The two bearers stand silently with the cost. Neither assents.

81 INT. AURELION - FIFTH-ANCHOR INTERFACES - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-21-CS02

Tarrik stops several meters from Crownmark Five. Selene waits beside him.

TARRIK
I've heard this argument before.

SELENE
What argument?

TARRIK
That there is no other choice. People usually say it just before making something unforgivable sound inevitable.

SELENE
Then we don't pretend inevitability makes us innocent. If we leave the Meridian incomplete, containment continues degrading, That is a choice. If we complete it, we stabilize the boundary and create another danger. That is also a choice. We decide between the risks that exist, not the innocence we wish existed.

TARRIK
If this is wrong...

SELENE
Then we put our names beside it.

TARRIK
You saw Ilyran.

SELENE
No. I did not see what you saw, But I think I understand what it taught you.

ON SCREEN:
MERIDIAN COMPLETION PROTOCOL
INDEPENDENT ASSENT REQUIRED
CONSEQUENCE RECORD: PERMANENT

TARRIK
Independent.

SELENE
No bearer can authorize the other.

TARRIK
No command hierarchy.

SELENE
No.

TARRIK
No Emperor.

SELENE
No Council. Only us.

They hold each other's gaze, then each places a hand on a separate interface.

ON SCREEN:
BEARER A: ASSENT PENDING
BEARER B: ASSENT PENDING

TARRIK
If this begins opening the boundary, we stop.

SELENE
If we can.

TARRIK
Do you always do that?

SELENE
What?

TARRIK
Find the more frightening version of every sentence.

SELENE
Accuracy matters.

Tarrik straightens toward his interface and confirms his own assent.

TARRIK
My name is Tarrik Walcur. If this decision is wrong, that belongs in the record.

ON SCREEN:
BEARER A: IDENTITY RECORDED

Selene faces her separate interface and makes her own declaration.

SELENE
My name is Selene Veyne. We are completing the Sovereign Meridian to restore primary containment stability.

ON SCREEN:
BEARER B: IDENTITY RECORDED

TARRIK
Knowing that terminal authority may become available afterward.

SELENE
Yes.

TARRIK
Yes.

Each voluntarily presses forward. The chamber goes dark. Ianis, Caerion II, Neon Veil, Cauldron and Aurelion light without faction ownership colors. The geometry closes.

A single breath catches in Selene. For less than a second, the faces register fear held in discipline and grief held in purpose. The awareness vanishes; both withdraw their hands. Neither names it.

ON SCREEN:
MERIDIAN CONTINUITY: 5 / 5
SOVEREIGN MERIDIAN: COMPLETE

The Wound contracts; the terminal becomes still. Pressure descends, briefly oscillates, then continues recovering.

ON SCREEN:
BOUNDARY PRESSURE: FALLING

TARRIK
It worked.

SELENE
For that part.

ON SCREEN:
WITNESS V: AUTHENTICATED
ACCESS CONDITION: SATISFIED

The present chamber disappears around the two observers.

82 INT./EXT. RADIANCE COMMAND VESSEL / AURELION RECORDING - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-21-CS03

Whole blue-white Aurelion fills the sky. White-gold fleets burn beneath black-violet masses. Evacuation lanes vanish. Tarrik and Selene stand unseen at the edge of a failing bridge. The King's damaged shoulder and bloodied face hold no victory pose.

BRIDGE OFFICER
Third line gone. Eclipse mass through eastern evacuation. Radiant Mercy no longer responding. Anchor crews ready.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Confirm all five.

ENGINEER
Ianis ready.

BRIDGE OFFICER
Caerion ready. Neon ready. Cauldron ready. Aurelion terminal ready pending Sovereign reference.

The tactical sphere reveals a deliberate retreat funnel pulling every remaining mass toward Aurelion. A thin elderly chronicler with ink-stained fingers and a book strapped at his hip approaches.

TARRIK
Him.

SELENE
You know him.

TARRIK
I've heard him.

VESRYN
The Reach is groaning.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
I know.

VESRYN
Your armies fall.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
I know.

VESRYN
The Echo weeps, and you are drawing every remaining mass toward one system.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Yes.

VESRYN
There are civilian ships inside the convergence radius.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
I know.

VESRYN
Your own fleet is inside it.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
I know.

VESRYN
The carnage you wreak will not stop the Eclipse of life.

Tarrik recognizes the completed fragment. The King finally turns.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
No. But it may give us somewhere to bury it.

BRIDGE OFFICER
Sovereign, modeled convergence at eighty-three percent.

VESRYN
You asked me to record your reign.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
I asked you to record the truth.

VESRYN
Then stop giving me things I do not want to write.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
That is why I chose you.

VESRYN
You will kill millions.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Yes.

VESRYN
Possibly billions.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Yes.

VESRYN
You do not know whether this will work.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
No.

BRIDGE OFFICER
Convergence at ninety-one percent.

The King walks toward the forward glass. He names the chronicler without explanation.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Vesryn.

VESRYN
You still have ships inside.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Order every vessel capable of withdrawal beyond collapse radius.

NAVIGATION OFFICER
Some cannot make it.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
I know.

NAVIGATION OFFICER
Do we abandon them?

Grief crosses the King's face. He cannot remove it through certainty.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Transmit the warning anyway. Tell them exactly what is happening. Give them every second we have left.

The warning leaves. Ships accelerate; many cannot make it. Convergence approaches completion.

VESRYN
They will call you King.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
They already do.

VESRYN
Not like this. They will make the moment clean. Build monuments from what survives. Put you above the dead and call the height victory.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
They should build graves.

Convergence reaches one hundred percent. White-gold Echo lights the King's damaged blade.

VESRYN
But you will die a beggar.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Then let them bury me without a crown.

He drives the blade toward the star. Half a second passes. The star tears apart. Pressure below hearing shakes the Witness as the core splits into unequal remnants. Human and Eclipse ships vanish together. The King watches friendly crews die and does not look away.

Space folds inward between the remnants. Black-violet masses stretch toward the forming Wound. Four remote anchors seal; the terminal remains unresolved.

ON SCREEN:
REMOTE ANCHOR I: SEALED
REMOTE ANCHOR II: SEALED
REMOTE ANCHOR III: SEALED
REMOTE ANCHOR IV: SEALED
TERMINAL ANCHOR: REFERENCE PENDING

ENGINEER
Remote load climbing Terminal geometry cannot resolve the interior frame.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Why?

ON SCREEN:
SOVEREIGN REFERENCE REQUIRED BEYOND BOUNDARY

VESRYN
No. There is another way.

The engineer cannot answer that promise.

VESRYN
Find one.

ENGINEER
The four anchors can hold the exterior topology, The terminal cannot close without a retained reference inside the fold. We have minutes.

VESRYN
Transfer the reference.

ENGINEER
Sovereign authority can designate another living carrier.

VESRYN
Then send someone else.

The King looks at bloodied engineers and soldiers holding failing stations.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Who?

Vesryn has no answer. The King's face softens.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Exactly.

VESRYN
I'll go with you.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
No.

VESRYN
You told me never to obey you simply because you are King.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
I remember.

VESRYN
Then you cannot order me to remain.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
I am not asking as King.

Vesryn goes still.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
I am asking as the man who needs someone left behind to tell the truth.

Vesryn's grip falls from the King's arm.

VESRYN
They will call this victory.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
A lock is not a victory. Tell them I did not destroy the Eclipse. Tell them I closed a door.

VESRYN
The end is nigh, my King.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Perhaps.

VESRYN
I have seen what comes after.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
What?

VESRYN
Fragments.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Of what?

VESRYN
Fire. Frost. A bear beneath a crown. An eagle leaving its nest.

The two present observers look toward each other but cannot intervene.

VESRYN
The gates fail. I can tell you what I saw.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
No.

VESRYN
Why?

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Because I still have to choose.

VESRYN
You may die.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Yes.

VESRYN
You may fail.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Yes.

VESRYN
And you are still going.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Yes.

ENGINEER
Sovereign, the interior reference can be established, but retained authority will remain bound to your signature. If the boundary is accessed again--

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Then change the release condition.

ENGINEER
Sovereign?

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
No singular Witness receives terminal release authority.

ENGINEER
The terminal requires authenticated bearer execution.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Then require two.

The authority lattice spreads from one sovereign signature.

ENGINEER
Aligned concurrence?

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
No. Contrary witnesses.

ENGINEER
Opposed authority?

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Independent authority. Neither derived from the other. Neither capable of commanding the other's assent.

One path divides into two.

ON SCREEN:
RELEASE EXECUTION CONDITION: CONTRARY WITNESS CONCURRENCE

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
If the people who inherit this cannot find someone who disagrees with them, they have no business opening the door.

The threshold opens against the Wound. A vast movement waits beyond. Vesryn takes one step.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Do not follow me.

Vesryn stops. The King looks at him one final time.

GOOD KING (RECORDED)
Write what they forget.

Vesryn touches his book with an ink-stained hand. His jaw trembles.

VESRYN
All of it.

The King crosses. White-gold light catches his silhouette for one second; darkness closes behind him.

ON SCREEN:
SOVEREIGN REFERENCE: ACQUIRED
REFERENCE LOCATION: CONTAINED SIDE
TERMINAL ANCHOR: SEALED

Crownmark Five ignites. The historical record ends.

83 INT. AURELION - FIFTH CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-21-CS04

The present chamber returns. Neither hand remains on an interface. Let silence precede their response.

TARRIK
He didn't leave.

SELENE
He stayed.

TARRIK
Vesryn.

SELENE
He was there.

TARRIK
At Ilyran?

SELENE
No. In the Final Civic Admonition. He sat beside the King when Record 7283 was made.

TARRIK
You saw him.

SELENE
Yes.

TARRIK
He has been speaking to me.

SELENE
What does that mean?

The terminal interrupts before he can explain.

ON SCREEN:
ALL WITNESSES COMPLETE
SOVEREIGN MERIDIAN COMPLETE
PRIMARY CONTAINMENT: CLOSED
BOUNDARY STABILITY: RECOVERING
PRIMARY CONTAINMENT AUTHORITY: OPEN

Tarrik draws Velkorran; Selene finds Verity's activation surface.

ON SCREEN:
BOUNDARY STATE: CLOSED

Neither ignites a weapon.

SELENE
The authority lattice is open. Not the prison.

ON SCREEN:
TERMINAL AUTHORITY: AVAILABLE
RELEASE COMMAND: WITHHELD
SOVEREIGN COMMAND PATH: AVAILABLE
EXECUTION SAFEGUARD: CONTRARY BEARER CONCURRENCE

TARRIK
So we armed the lock.

SELENE
Yes.

White-gold bands integrate Crownmark Five more deeply into its housing.

ON SCREEN:
COMMAND GRAMMAR SYNCHRONIZING TO ACTIVE NODES

SELENE
No.

TARRIK
Stop synchronization.

No response. Command syntax propagates outward; no release command travels with it.

SELENE
Interrupt Meridian synchronization.

ON SCREEN:
MERIDIAN SYNCHRONIZATION CANNOT BE INTERRUPTED

TARRIK
Of course.

ON SCREEN:
EXTERNAL CONTINUITY QUERY DETECTED
SOURCE: REFORMATION CENTRAL INFORMATION INTEGRITY
AUTHORITY: INSUFFICIENT
CROWNWATCH SOVEREIGN QUERY DETECTED
AUTHORITY: INSUFFICIENT

TARRIK
We gave them the door.

SELENE
No. We gave them the language to ask the door to open.

ON SCREEN:
TERMINAL RELEASE REQUIRES CONTRARY BEARER CONCURRENCE

TARRIK
They still need us.

SELENE
Yes.

TARRIK
Both of us.

SELENE
Yes. A Sovereign command path can request release. It cannot execute without contrary concurrence.

TARRIK
He really trusted no one.

SELENE
Maybe he trusted disagreement.

ON SCREEN:
BOUNDARY PRESSURE: 61%

Pressure falls through forty-three percent. Beyond the boundary, some tethered organisms collapse; others draw backward into the Wound. The door stays shut. Selene's comm reconnects.

THARNE
Selene.

SELENE
Lyric?

LYRIC
Still annoyingly alive.

SELENE
How bad?

LYRIC
Quieter.

THARNE
The acute response stopped when Meridian pressure fell. I need a medical station before I can tell you more.

SELENE
And the corruption?

THARNE
Not reversing.

SELENE
The barrier is retracting. Stay where you are.

LYRIC
I have developed a sudden affection for resting.

Tarrik's comm reconnects.

LYESSA
Doors are opening.

TARRIK
Status?

LYESSA
Alive.

TARRIK
Cross?

LYESSA
Unfortunately. Crownwatch wants you back immediately.

TARRIK
Of course.

LYESSA
Did you activate it?

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
Why?

TARRIK
The incomplete Meridian was degrading the boundary. We had just over two hours before critical failure. We completed it. Containment stabilized.

LYESSA
What did it cost?

TARRIK
I'll tell you when you get here.

LYESSA
Cross's teams are moving again.

TARRIK
Keep them outside the chamber.

LYESSA
For how long?

Tarrik looks to Selene.

TARRIK
A little longer.

ON SCREEN:
SOVEREIGN PRIORITY
RETURN TO CROWNWATCH
KEEPER VEYNE
REPORT TO MESTRIA
DO NOT AUTHORIZE TERMINAL RELEASE

TARRIK
Voss?

SELENE
Yes.

TARRIK
What does she want?

SELENE
For me not to open the prison.

TARRIK
Reasonable.

SELENE
Caelus?

TARRIK
Return immediately.

SELENE
Also reasonable.

The recovering chambers give them a way out. Selene looks from the summons to Tarrik.

SELENE
They want us back.

TARRIK
Of course they do.

SELENE
Immediately.

Tarrik considers the returning companions, then chooses a conversation no machinery requires.

TARRIK
We should talk first.

Selene has a genuine opportunity to leave. She meets his eyes.

SELENE
Yes.

SCOR 22 FRIENDS NOT SOON FORGOTTEN

84 INT. AURELION - FIFTH CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-22-CS01

A Reformation medical transport gathers pods beneath a broken Dominion cruiser. A Dominion tug drags a Reformation destroyer clear of shear. No admiral authorized either act. Then exclusion markers reform; a Dominion lance turns back toward an old opponent without firing.

Tarrik closes the feed as the quarantine wall lowers. Tharne appears supporting Lyric. Selene reaches them.

LYRIC
I can walk.

THARNE
You are walking.

LYRIC
Under occupation.

SELENE
Status.

THARNE
The acute response ended when the boundary pressure fell. Her temperature is thirty-two degrees and still decreasing. The corruption is advancing, but slowly.

LYRIC
Everyone is doing excellent work making survival sound disappointing.

SELENE
Do you still feel the Wound?

LYRIC
No.

Tharne exhales. Lyric adds the distinction that destroys the comfort.

LYRIC
I feel remembered.

Selene's grip tightens.

LYRIC
Do not do that.

SELENE
What?

LYRIC
Decide what I need before asking me. You are already considering whether I should remain here.

Selene does not defend the assumption.

LYRIC
Go talk to him.

SELENE
You nearly died.

LYRIC
Yes. I would prefer my survival accomplish something beyond turning me into a case file. You two watched the King enter the prison and became the only people currently able to agree to open it. I assume there are follow-up questions.

THARNE
I'll stay with her.

LYRIC
Under protest.

Lyessa enters with a changed Egdredil magazine and uncleansed blood on her armor. Soldiers block Crownwatch personnel behind her.

LYESSA
Cross wants the terminal.

TARRIK
I know.

LYESSA
He has three Continuity teams coming down.

TARRIK
Keep them out.

LYESSA
For how long?

TARRIK
As long as you can.

LYESSA
That is not a time.

TARRIK
No. I need to understand what we saw before Crownwatch tells me what it means.

Lyessa looks from Tarrik to Selene.

LYESSA
Only what you saw?

TARRIK
No.

A small hurt alters her face. She turns toward Cross's approaching people.

LYESSA
Fine.

TARRIK
If Crownwatch gives you a direct order?

LYESSA
You told me to decide what I do.

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
I'm deciding.

TARRIK
Thank you.

Selene starts toward a side passage. Tarrik follows.

LYESSA
Do not let Cross get the answer before you do.

TARRIK
I won't.

85 INT. AURELION - OBSERVATION GALLERY - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-22-CS02

The gallery contains a broad transparent wall, a dark table and six worn chairs. Tarrik sits; Selene stands looking at the remnants.

TARRIK
You do that often.

SELENE
What?

TARRIK
Stand while everyone else sits.

SELENE
It is easier to leave.

TARRIK
Encouraging.

She gives him a dry look and sits. She touches the cut at her temple. Tarrik puts a field seal on the table.

SELENE
I have one.

TARRIK
Of course you do.

SELENE
Preparation is generally useful.

TARRIK
You should tell Aurelion.

SELENE
That would require Aurelion to listen.

TARRIK
Fair.

She uses his seal anyway. He watches her a moment too long.

SELENE
What?

TARRIK
Nothing.

SELENE
You were staring.

TARRIK
I was thinking.

SELENE
That is not a denial.

TARRIK
You are extremely difficult to talk to.

SELENE
So far you have mostly tried with a sword.

TARRIK
That was easier.

SELENE
I noticed.

Something warm passes, then Selene looks toward the Wound.

SELENE
Tell me about Darek.

TARRIK
You read the record.

SELENE
I read how he died. That is not the same thing.

Tarrik looks at his hands before meeting her eyes.

TARRIK
He was three years older, Better at almost everything until I was fourteen. He hated ceremonies. Every time Crownwatch put us through one, he would count the exits and whisper which he thought he could reach before our father noticed.

SELENE
Your father.

TARRIK
Not Caelus. When our mother died, people spent three days explaining what grief should look like. Darek spent the funeral describing everyone who came to offer condolences until I laughed during the final prayer.

SELENE
Did you get caught?

TARRIK
Obviously.

SELENE
What happened?

TARRIK
Darek took the blame.

SELENE
Why?

TARRIK
He was older.

SELENE
That seems insufficient.

TARRIK
It was enough for him. He was like that.

The memory of Gate Nine weighs on the room.

TARRIK
The scans were clean. They proved nothing. He was begging her to open the barrier. She shot him through the chest, then the throat. She didn't know.

SELENE
Whether he was infected.

TARRIK
No. Tell me she was wrong.

Selene takes the time to answer honestly rather than comfort through a lie.

SELENE
I don't know whether the shot was wrong, Waiting might have opened Gate Nine. Acting made one consequence certain for Darek. The evidence leaves no clean answer. But everything after was wrong, The memorial. The falsified report. Letting you believe the Reformation killed him. Gate Nine was a decision made inside terror. The next morning was not.

TARRIK
I told her that.

SELENE
What did she say?

TARRIK
That she wanted one more day.

SELENE
Of what?

TARRIK
Me loving her the way I did before I knew.

Let the answer sit. Selene turns toward the Wound.

SELENE
Voss would understand her.

TARRIK
You say that like it is not an insult.

SELENE
It isn't. The scale is different. The logic isn't.

86 INT. AURELION - OBSERVATION GALLERY - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-22-CS03

ON SCREEN:
PEOPLE FLOURISH THROUGH ORDER.
ORDER EXISTS THAT PEOPLE MAY FLOURISH. PEOPLE DO NOT EXIST THAT ORDER MAY ENDURE.

TARRIK
They reversed it.

SELENE
Yes.

TARRIK
They made him justify the institution.

SELENE
Yes.

TARRIK
We did the opposite.

The contrast settles: Dominion kept majesty while discarding suspicion of power; Reformation kept suspicion of rulers while discarding suspicion of systems.

TARRIK
We're impressive.

SELENE
Our civilizations?

TARRIK
At missing the point.

SELENE
Impressive is not the word I use.

TARRIK
What word?

SELENE
Embarrassing.

He laughs; after a second, she does too. Neither guards the sound.

TARRIK
Voss knew?

SELENE
For eleven years. She challenged the record for six months, then chose to preserve it.

TARRIK
Why?

SELENE
Because the Reformation works. Courts function. Elections transfer authority without fleets. Provinces cooperate through law, and public systems survive leaders. She believes the original will be used to argue that everything built after the Sundering is illegitimate.

TARRIK
It will.

SELENE
Yes.

TARRIK
The Dominion will use it.

SELENE
Yes.

TARRIK
Do you think she is wrong?

SELENE
Not about the danger. She is wrong about what the danger permits her to do.

TARRIK
You still believe in the Reformation.

SELENE
Yes. Those things happened because the Reformation failed one of its principles. The failure does not make the principle false. You still believe in the Dominion.

Tarrik stops his first impulse to reject the question.

TARRIK
Yes. I do not know what that means anymore.

SELENE
Neither do I.

She closes the projection.

SELENE
I lied too. At the Forum. A historian asked whether the public Admonition had been deliberately altered. I told him the question remained under provenance review.

TARRIK
You knew the answer.

SELENE
Yes.

TARRIK
That was a lie.

The procedural defense crosses Selene's face. She discards it.

SELENE
Yes.

TARRIK
Why?

SELENE
By then I knew there was a fifth Crownmark and that the terminal was linked to containment. I thought confirming the full conspiracy would make someone connect the suppressed record to the active Meridian and decide whatever remained had to be reached first.

She gestures toward the rival fleets.

TARRIK
You were right.

SELENE
About the danger. Not about the lie.

TARRIK
A bad outcome does not make concealment good afterward.

SELENE
No.

TARRIK
Who told you that?

SELENE
Lyric.

TARRIK
Of course.

SELENE
She asked how not telling them felt.

TARRIK
What did you say?

SELENE
Necessary.

TARRIK
That sounds terrible.

SELENE
She thought so. I said it felt awful. She said, 'Good. Keep it awful.'

TARRIK
I like her.

SELENE
You have spoken to her for approximately four minutes.

TARRIK
She threatened me during half of them.

SELENE
That improves your assessment?

TARRIK
Usually.

Her quiet laugh meets his smile. The subject turns serious without erasing the warmth.

TARRIK
Caelus thinks responsibility belongs to whoever is strong enough to carry it.

SELENE
Voss thinks responsibility belongs to systems strong enough to survive individuals.

TARRIK
Which is right?

SELENE
Both. And neither.

TARRIK
Deeply irritating.

SELENE
Yes.

TARRIK
What about the King?

SELENE
He built systems and held enormous personal authority. Then he spent every Witness reminding people that neither fact made responsibility disappear.

TARRIK
He put his name beside the consequence.

SELENE
And he made the final door require someone who disagreed with whoever wanted it opened.

TARRIK
He did not trust agreement.

SELENE
I think he distrusted certainty.

Tarrik puts an anchor-signed black recorder on the table.

SELENE
Cauldron.

TARRIK
One of the anchor-signed duplicates. Glass Citadel holds the original.

SELENE
The record is already public. You have others.

TARRIK
Not enough. Mirrors can be blocked, edited, or called fraudulent once they become inconvenient. This cannot. Keep it.

SELENE
Why me?

Tarrik looks toward the Dominion fleet.

TARRIK
Because mine already buried it once.

Selene takes it, then places a certified archival wafer before him.

TARRIK
Record 7283.

SELENE
A primary mirror. The complete Witness, alteration history, founding review chain, and current provenance certification.

TARRIK
Everything.

SELENE
Yes.

TARRIK
Why?

She looks toward the Reformation formation.

SELENE
Because mine already buried it once.

As each secures the other's evidence, their hands touch. Warmth and cold meet through an open wrist seam. Neither pulls away immediately.

TARRIK
You're freezing.

SELENE
Your baseline temperature appears medically unreasonable.

TARRIK
I'm fine.

SELENE
That is not a measurement.

TARRIK
It has worked so far.

SELENE
Your standards are alarming.

She withdraws a fraction later than necessary. He closes his hand around 7283.

SELENE
Before I knew who you were, I saw you.

TARRIK
Where?

SELENE
I don't know. The sky was red. You were kneeling with blood across your hands.

TARRIK
Was anyone else there?

SELENE
A woman with dark hair. A weapon raised behind you.

TARRIK
Lyessa.

SELENE
Perhaps.

TARRIK
What happened?

SELENE
I don't know.

TARRIK
What did you hear?

SELENE
Do not let him kneel.

TARRIK
Vesryn.

Tarrik recalls the fragments he has heard.

TARRIK
Since Ilyran. Carnage without context. A beggar without a crown. White-gold light in my hands. The warnings felt remembered.

SELENE
Vesryn saw a bear beneath a crown.

TARRIK
Obviously.

Her involuntary glance at his shoulders earns a brief smile.

SELENE
Your confidence is extraordinary.

TARRIK
Selene.

SELENE
I concede the possibility. And the eagle leaves its nest.

TARRIK
You don't have to.

SELENE
Neither do you.

TARRIK
Maybe.

SELENE
That is the danger.

TARRIK
What?

SELENE
If we use Vesryn's visions as permission, we have learned nothing.

TARRIK
We still choose.

SELENE
Yes.

87 INT. AURELION - OBSERVATION GALLERY - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-22-CS04

ON SCREEN:
BOUNDARY STATE: CLOSED
TERMINAL RELEASE: AVAILABLE
RELEASE AUTHORITY: CONTRARY BEARER CONCURRENCE

SELENE
We need terms.

TARRIK
Of course you think that.

SELENE
You object?

TARRIK
No. Go.

SELENE
No assent through a government relay. We authorize release only while physically present or directly verified through Meridian recognition.

TARRIK
No recording.

SELENE
No proxy.

TARRIK
No extracted signature.

SELENE
Agreed. If either bearer appears coerced, cognitively compromised, under Eclipse influence, or incapable of independent judgment, concurrence is refused.

TARRIK
So if I ask you to open it, assume something is wrong with me.

SELENE
Yes.

TARRIK
Comforting.

SELENE
You do the same.

TARRIK
I intended to. No controlled openings, No test aperture, specimen retrieval, or research window. No one cracks the prison because they promise they only want to look.

SELENE
Agreed.

TARRIK
And neither government studies us to bypass concurrence.

SELENE
They will ask.

TARRIK
Cross will order.

SELENE
The Defense Council may do the same.

TARRIK
We refuse.

SELENE
Yes.

No superior validates their agreement. Tarrik asks the question neither wants.

TARRIK
What if one of us dies?

SELENE
The survivor does not improvise, The terminal must recognize another contrary witness.

TARRIK
And if it doesn't?

SELENE
Then it stays closed.

TARRIK
Agreed.

SELENE
Then we should separate.

Let Tarrik react before her explanation.

TARRIK
So quickly.

SELENE
If the Dominion controls Aurelion while both bearers remain here, it controls both halves of concurrence.

TARRIK
Assuming they can make you cooperate.

SELENE
Do you want to test how persuasive Crownwatch can become?

TARRIK
No.

SELENE
If the Reformation gains jurisdiction, the danger reverses.

TARRIK
Voss would call it protective custody.

SELENE
Cross would call it strategic necessity. You disagree.

TARRIK
No.

SELENE
Then what?

TARRIK
I was beginning to appreciate having someone else in the room who knows how bad the ideas are.

Selene stills; the honesty is personal before it is strategic.

SELENE
You will survive the deprivation.

TARRIK
Probably.

SELENE
The safest location for two people required to open the prison is not the same location.

TARRIK
Where do you go?

SELENE
Mestria.

TARRIK
Seriously.

SELENE
Yes.

TARRIK
Why go back?

SELENE
Because the Reformation will decide what Aurelion means whether I participate or not. If I decide the system cannot answer evidence before I let it try, I become Voss in reverse.

TARRIK
You think they will listen?

SELENE
I think they must be given the chance.

TARRIK
Same reason, If I do not return, Cross explains Aurelion to Caelus first.

SELENE
Then you should go.

TARRIK
You say that easily.

SELENE
No. I don't.

He hears the concern and leaves it unexamined.

SELENE
Do you hate her?

TARRIK
No. Voss?

SELENE
No.

TARRIK
It would be easier.

SELENE
Yes. Betrayal only works when something worth trusting existed first.

TARRIK
Inconvenient.

SELENE
Yes.

ON SCREEN:
CEASEFIRE VIOLATION RISK: RISING

Capital ships reposition toward the terminal and opposing escorts answer.

TARRIK
We're out of time.

SELENE
We should tell them.

They rise and leave together.

88 INT. AURELION - UPPER TERMINAL REGROUP CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-22-CS05

Lyessa sees the black recorder in Selene's hand before anyone speaks.

LYESSA
You gave it to her.

TARRIK
Yes.

SELENE
I read your statement, I don't know whether you were wrong at Gate Nine.

LYESSA
Neither do I.

SELENE
I know you were wrong every day after.

Lyessa lowers her eyes. She does not invoke orders or dismiss Selene's standing.

LYESSA
So do I.

It repairs nothing. Tarrik registers that it matters.

LYRIC
You gave him 7283?

SELENE
Yes.

LYRIC
If you lose that, I will kill you.

TARRIK
You seem occupied.

LYRIC
I will recover out of spite.

TARRIK
I believe you.

Lyric smiles. Selene catches an irritation she leaves unnamed.

THARNE
High Centurion.

TARRIK
Ensign.

THARNE
Technically suspended.

TARRIK
Seems contagious.

THARNE
Rathis, What you chose not to do mattered.

TARRIK
So did Glass Citadel.

THARNE
I violated several statutes.

LYRIC
He is extremely proud.

THARNE
I am not.

LYRIC
You glow.

THARNE
I do not.

The companions recount the pact.

SELENE
No release without direct Meridian-recognized concurrence. No proxy, recording or extracted signature. If either bearer is coerced or compromised, the other refuses.

TARRIK
No test aperture. No specimen window. No studying either of us to bypass concurrence. If one of us dies, the survivor does not improvise.

SELENE
The terminal must recognize another contrary witness. Until then, it stays closed. We're leaving separately.

LYRIC
You are both voluntarily returning to the governments already deciding how to own your authority.

SELENE
We cannot leave them alone with the command architecture.

LYRIC
You could vanish.

SELENE
And let the Reformation define my absence as proof that oversight failed?

LYRIC
They may imprison you.

SELENE
Maybe. But I will not decide the system cannot correct itself before forcing it to answer the evidence. You don't have to come.

LYRIC
I know.

SELENE
Your legal exposure--

LYRIC
Catastrophic.

SELENE
Your health--

LYRIC
Unclear.

Lyric ignores Tharne's offered hand, sways, then takes his arm without a comment.

LYRIC
Still coming.

THARNE
So am I.

SELENE
Glass Citadel can extend neutral protection.

THARNE
I filed the review because I believe the system should answer it.

SELENE
All right.

TARRIK
You could stay.

LYESSA
No.

TARRIK
Caelus may arrest me.

LYESSA
He may.

TARRIK
Cross will try.

LYESSA
Almost certainly.

TARRIK
You don't have to come.

LYESSA
I know.

Lyessa adjusts Egdredil and glances toward Lyric.

LYESSA
Still coming.

THARNE
There is one problem.

LYRIC
Only one?

THARNE
The bearer signatures appear bound to the terminal state. I see no mechanism for remote substitution.

SELENE
You don't see one.

THARNE
Correct. The command grammar distributed to the active nodes should not execute release without contrary concurrence, but both governments can interrogate terminal state and interact with portions of the architecture.

TARRIK
How much?

THARNE
I don't know.

LYRIC
So civilization cannot open the door, but it can touch the interesting controls around it.

THARNE
That is imprecise.

LYRIC
Wrong?

THARNE
No.

ON SCREEN:
CEASEFIRE VIOLATION RISK: ELEVATED

SELENE
We need to leave.

Tarrik nods. Selene leads toward the hangar.

89 INT./EXT. AURELION - OUTER-RING HANGAR AND TRANSPORTS - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-22-CS06

A Dominion shuttle waits at the western dock; a Reformation transport at the eastern berth. The arrangement keeps approaches outside weapons range. Lyessa waits west; Tharne supports Lyric east. Tarrik and Selene stand between fire and hard white light.

Each produces a narrow personal comm cipher.

SELENE
No terminal authorization over this channel.

TARRIK
No.

SELENE
One transmission before auto-burn.

TARRIK
Yes.

They exchange the devices separately from the evidence.

TARRIK
Try not to get arrested.

SELENE
Try not to commit regicide.

TARRIK
That seems specific.

SELENE
It was general advice.

The humor leaves her face.

SELENE
Do not kneel.

Tarrik nearly jokes, then chooses not to.

TARRIK
I wasn't planning to.

SELENE
Plans change.

TARRIK
If they do, come remind me.

She goes still with its several possible meanings.

SELENE
Try not to require it.

TARRIK
And you?

SELENE
The eagle.

TARRIK
Yes.

SELENE
I intend to come back.

TARRIK
That is not what Vesryn saw.

She looks at her transport, then chooses her answer.

SELENE
Vesryn does not get a vote.

TARRIK
Good.

SELENE
Neither does prophecy.

TARRIK
No.

A wordless beat permits the relationship to remain unnamed. Tarrik offers his forearm.

SELENE
You are aware I am not one of your soldiers.

TARRIK
I noticed.

She grips his forearm. He grips hers. Warm and cool meet without changing either. Neon Veil pulses; Caerion II answers faintly. They release, turn toward their teams, both glance back and turn away first.

Both board. The transports detach along opposite vectors, the Wound between them until their fleets intervene.

ON SCREEN:
CROWNWATCH
SOVEREIGN PRIORITY
IMMEDIATE RETURN
MESTRIA
CONTINUITY REVIEW
MANDATORY APPEARANCE

Tarrik secures 7283 inside his armor. Selene places the Cauldron recorder beside Caerion II. Cut to Crownwatch: received command architecture finishes reconstructing on a secure display.

ON SCREEN:
CONTRARY BEARER CONCURRENCE REQUIRED

A technician checks the authentication chain twice and forwards the finding to Sovereign Research. The next request is framed as contingency planning; no one orders release.

ON SCREEN:
ALTERNATIVE SOVEREIGN AUTHORITY PATH
FEASIBILITY ASSESSMENT

Priority clearance appears. Match cut to Mestria: a Continuity team reads the same concurrence limitation under a defensive mandate. Its secure project file opens.

ON SCREEN:
TERMINAL DENIAL PROTOCOL
CONCURRENCE OVERRIDE ANALYSIS

Neither team knows the other has begun. Neither believes it is opening the prison. Return to distant Aurelion, contained between the broken remnants. The Wound stays closed. Fade on that unresolved state.

SCOR 23 THE HEIR

90 INT./EXT. CROWNWATCH - RECEIVING TERRACE AND MURAL HALL - ETERNAL EVENING
SCOR-23-CS01

The shuttle descends through amber cloud. The civic feed frames Tarrik and burning Velkorran so a damaged Reformation ship appears to be his target.

ON SCREEN:
AURELION DEFENDED
THE HEIR STANDS AT THE KING'S FINAL BATTLEFIELD

LYESSA
They moved quickly.

TARRIK
They always do.

LYESSA
The Eclipse part is true.

TARRIK
So is Aurelion.

Lyessa studies him. He closes the feed.

TARRIK
That is what makes it useful.

Ramp opens. Tarrik passes across the stone officers kneel on. He does not kneel. A boy raises a wooden sword from his father's shoulders; a maintenance worker weeps with relief; two veterans salute. Tarrik raises a hand to them, unsure how to deserve their faith. Lyessa leaves his crooked insignia untouched.

Inside, the mural makes the Sundering symmetric and triumphant. Match one painted civilian-free lane to the evacuation ships Tarrik saw die in the Witness, then return to his face.

LYESSA
You're staring.

TARRIK
I've never seen it before.

LYESSA
You've seen it hundreds of times.

TARRIK
No.

He points at the painting.

TARRIK
I've seen this.

An officer approaches, careful to interrupt.

CROWNWATCH OFFICER
High Centurion. Emperor Virel is waiting.

TARRIK
Where?

CROWNWATCH OFFICER
The war annex.

Tarrik exchanges a look with Lyessa. The officer opens the west-tower route. Tarrik continues beneath the mural.

91 INT. CROWNWATCH - UNDERGROUND WAR ANNEX - ETERNAL EVENING
SCOR-23-CS02

Analysts leave. Cross had told Lyessa to wait outside; she looks to Tarrik instead.

TARRIK
She stays.

The doors seal. Aurelion and the five nodes occupy the table.

CROSS
Tell me exactly what happened after you entered the terminal.

TARRIK
You have telemetry.

CROSS
I have pieces. Selene Veyne, Can she authorize release?

TARRIK
Yes.

CROSS
Would she?

TARRIK
No.

CROSS
You speak for her now?

TARRIK
No.

CROSS
Then how do you know?

TARRIK
I listened.

ON SCREEN:
ALTERNATIVE SOVEREIGN AUTHORITY PATH
FEASIBILITY ASSESSMENT

TARRIK
You're trying to bypass us.

CROSS
We are determining whether two unsupervised individuals should retain private veto power over a system capable of releasing an extinction-level enemy.

TARRIK
We agreed no one studies a bypass.

CROSS
You agreed. The Dominion was not consulted.

TARRIK
You are not studying Neon Veil.

CROSS
That will be decided by Sovereign authority.

TARRIK
No.

CROSS
You remain an officer of the Dominion.

TARRIK
I remain the bearer.

CROSS
That can change.

Lyessa shifts her weight. She does not draw. Cross closes the authority-path file.

CROSS
For now.

Tarrik places an authenticated Cauldron duplicate on the table. Lyessa stills.

TARRIK
Did Caelus know?

CROSS
Within hours.

TARRIK
Before Darek's memorial.

CROSS
Yes.

TARRIK
Before he named me heir.

CROSS
Yes.

TARRIK
Did Caelus order Gate Nine?

CROSS
No.

TARRIK
Final Containment?

CROSS
I received an authenticated Imperial Executive order. I did not personally witness the Emperor sign it.

TARRIK
We did not know whether the extermination was necessary, so you lied until you could prove that it was.

CROSS
No. We lied because we knew we never could.

Cross lets the sentence remain. Neither certainty nor apology comes to rescue him.

CROSS
The dead cannot tell us whether their deaths were necessary.

TARRIK
So you decided the living should never be allowed to ask.

CROSS
We decided civilization could not survive every future containment order becoming a referendum on whether Cauldron had been justified.

TARRIK
You were afraid soldiers would refuse.

CROSS
Yes.

TARRIK
Maybe they should.

CROSS
Maybe. Maybe the next refusal kills three worlds.

Tarrik retrieves the recorder and turns for the chapel.

CROSS
You think Veyne understands you. She may.

He refuses to call understanding safety.

CROSS
Do not mistake being understood for being safe.

TARRIK
I don't.

92 INT./EXT. CROWNWATCH - OLD WAR CHAPEL AND BALCONY - ETERNAL EVENING
SCOR-23-CS03

The crown lies unworn on stone. Caelus turns, crosses the chapel and embraces Tarrik. Tarrik freezes before allowing the contact.

CAELUS
You came back.

TARRIK
Yes.

Caelus checks the blood and damaged armor without letting his hands leave Tarrik's shoulders.

CAELUS
You're injured.

TARRIK
Mostly other people's blood.

CAELUS
That is often worse. And Lyessa?

TARRIK
Alive.

CAELUS
Good. The Reformation Keeper saved your life.

TARRIK
She did.

CAELUS
Then I owe her a debt I dislike.

TARRIK
I suspect she would enjoy that.

Their nearly shared amusement fades as Caelus looks at Neon Veil.

CAELUS
Tell me.

TARRIK
We completed the Meridian because four anchors were tearing the boundary apart. The Fifth Witness showed Aurelion whole, and the King drawing the Eclipse into it. He warned the civilian ships. Many could not leave. He broke the star anyway. He crossed the boundary. The terminal required a Sovereign reference from inside the prison.

Caelus understands the implication before Tarrik says it.

TARRIK
He went through.

Caelus sits as if his body has made the decision for him.

CAELUS
The King.

TARRIK
Yes.

CAELUS
He did not vanish.

TARRIK
No.

CAELUS
He did not abandon the Reach.

TARRIK
No.

CAELUS
All this time. What did he say?

TARRIK
A lock is not a victory. He said, 'Tell them I did not destroy the Eclipse. Tell them I closed a door.'

Caelus lowers his head. Tarrik briefly hopes this settles the argument.

CAELUS
He bought us time.

TARRIK
What?

CAELUS
Four hundred years.

TARRIK
No.

A tactical aperture appears amid lances and overlapping kill fields.

CAELUS
A controlled aperture.

He gestures to the prepared kill volume.

CAELUS
No general release. No collapse. Anything crossing enters a prepared kill volume and is destroyed before clearing the containment envelope. Then we close the boundary, evaluate, and repeat when ready.

TARRIK
Repeat.

CAELUS
Yes.

TARRIK
For how long?

CAELUS
Until the prison is empty. He may still be there.

TARRIK
You don't know.

CAELUS
No. But if he is alive, he has held that line alone for four centuries. We inherited his war.

TARRIK
We inherited his lock.

CAELUS
Locks are built to open.

TARRIK
Not always. But if you're going to use his design as permission, use all of it. He required someone who disagreed. Selene says no.

Caelus hears how quickly her name comes.

CAELUS
You trust her.

TARRIK
With this? Yes. Our weapons improved. Our ships improved. Our science improved. What did it build?

Caelus studies the simulated Wound. Then his attention returns to the crown.

CAELUS
If you are frightened of what happens when power sits in the wrong hands, stop leaving it there. Take the authority to stop me.

Tarrik looks at the crown, imagining cancellations, disclosure and restraint, not a cheering court. He places the recorder beside it instead.

TARRIK
How long have you known?

CAELUS
Nineteen months.

TARRIK
Did you order Gate Nine?

CAELUS
No.

TARRIK
Final Containment?

CAELUS
No.

TARRIK
I believe you. Did you approve what happened afterward?

CAELUS
Yes.

TARRIK
The Reformation attribution.

CAELUS
Approved under my seal.

TARRIK
You let me bury my brother believing Reformation killed him. You let me hate them for it.

CAELUS
I know. Use mine.

He taps the recorder: his name belongs beside the consequence.

CAELUS
I would make the same decision again.

TARRIK
You learned nothing.

CAELUS
No. I learned precisely what it cost.

TARRIK
The King put his name beside the dead.

CAELUS
So am I.

TARRIK
He did not tell their families someone else killed them.

Caelus has no answer. Tarrik retrieves the recorder.

TARRIK
I need air.

CAELUS
The throne is not a reward, It is the place where every decision eventually becomes someone's grief.

TARRIK
I know.

CAELUS
No.

Caelus looks older now.

CAELUS
You are beginning to.

93 INT. CROWNWATCH - MURAL HALL - ETERNAL EVENING
SCOR-23-CS04

LYESSA
He knew.

TARRIK
Yes. He wants to open Aurelion.

LYESSA
What?

TARRIK
A controlled aperture. A kill corridor around the opening, then close it and repeat.

LYESSA
No. What are you going to do?

TARRIK
He offered me the throne.

LYESSA
That is what you wanted.

TARRIK
No.

LYESSA
Not the crown. The ability to stop everyone else from deciding for you.

Tarrik removes Selene's cipher. Lyessa notices, then leaves him privacy without giving permission.

ON SCREEN:
CONTROLLED APERTURE PROPOSED. I REFUSED.
REFORMATION CONTINUITY HAS OPENED TERMINAL DENIAL ANALYSIS.
VOSS OBJECTED. DEFENSE COUNCIL PROCEEDED.
THEY CLAIM IT CANNOT OPEN THE GATE. ONLY PREVENT YOUR SIDE FROM DOING SO.
CROWNWATCH OPENED ALTERNATIVE SOVEREIGN AUTHORITY PATH. I BLOCKED NEON VEIL ACCESS.
DO NOT LET THEM STUDY YOU.
YOU TOO.
OBVIOUSLY.

The key burns; the conversation vanishes. Tarrik looks at the empty projection longer than necessary. Cut to the council sphere beneath the crown.

CAELUS
Project Final Dawn.

ON SCREEN:
SOVEREIGN CONTAINMENT TERMINATION FEASIBILITY

The model shows three lances, eight fields and an aperture under two-tenths of one percent for 8.4 seconds. No one treats the plan as reckless entertainment.

CONTINUITY DIRECTOR
Under current architecture, terminal release cannot execute without Contrary Bearer concurrence.

VAREN
Does Keeper Veyne support controlled-access study?

TARRIK
No.

CAELUS
She has not reviewed this proposal.

TARRIK
She will still say no.

CAELUS
Your objection.

TARRIK
We do not know enough. At Aurelion, every attempt to study living Eclipse material gave it something to study in return. It adapted to the field holding it and used the architecture as a transmission path. Final Dawn assumes observation is neutral. It is not.

CONTINUITY DIRECTOR
We are redesigning the containment system.

TARRIK
You are designing against the last thing it did. Prepare to defend the boundary, Do not teach yourselves how to open it.

CROSS
Capability is not authorization.

TARRIK
Not at first.

Recommendation tiles appear: Varen, Continuity and Fleet Science support review; legal finds no present release violation; two officers recommend delay. Caelus listens, but does not require a vote.

CAELUS
Your recommendation.

TARRIK
No.

CAELUS
On feasibility.

TARRIK
No.

CAELUS
On construction.

TARRIK
No.

CAELUS
On release?

TARRIK
Absolutely not.

CAELUS
Feasibility review authorized. No terminal release, no aperture construction, and no biological bearer testing without additional Sovereign authorization.

The room disperses. Caelus removes the crown and places it before Tarrik.

TARRIK
You offered me the authority to stop you.

CAELUS
Yes.

TARRIK
Then you authorized the project anyway.

CAELUS
You do not have the authority yet. Sit beside me.

TARRIK
For how long?

CAELUS
Until you no longer need to.

TARRIK
And then?

CAELUS
Rule.

Tarrik sees the same good uses for power and does not touch the crown.

TARRIK
How long do I have?

CAELUS
Technical review begins at first cycle tomorrow. Until then, You do not need to kneel.

Tarrik's eyes snap toward him. Caelus holds the crown without putting it on Tarrik.

CAELUS
Think.

Cut back to the mural after Tarrik leaves. Final Dawn, Alternative Sovereign Authority and intercepted Terminal Denial statuses are all active.

SCOR 24 REGICIDE

94 INT. CROWNWATCH - HALL OF NAMES - ETERNAL EVENING
SCOR-24-CS01

Tarrik rests his hand against cold bronze.

ON SCREEN:
DAREK WALCUR
FELL IN DEFENSE OF THE DOMINION

He remembers Caelus owning the lie and choosing it again. At the throne doors, Lyessa approaches with coffee.

LYESSA
You look terrible. I found coffee.

TARRIK
You found me.

LYESSA
You are standing outside the throne room at three in the morning.

TARRIK
Ianis does not have morning.

LYESSA
Crownwatch accounting does.

They drink. Familiar quiet now carries too much architecture.

TARRIK
I'm not taking it.

LYESSA
Are you sure?

TARRIK
No. But I'm still not taking it.

LYESSA
Why?

TARRIK
Because every reason I can think of to accept is also a reason Caelus believes he should hold it.

LYESSA
You could stop Final Dawn.

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
Release Cauldron.

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
Remove Cross.

TARRIK
You sound enthusiastic about that one.

LYESSA
I have had a difficult week.

Their small smiles end together.

LYESSA
What happens instead?

TARRIK
I don't know. A civilization of nearly a quadrillion people should not depend on one person being good enough.

LYESSA
Is this her?

TARRIK
No. She helped me see some things.

LYESSA
Things I couldn't?

TARRIK
Some.

Lyessa turns to keep hurt from becoming an accusation.

LYESSA
I spent years learning how you think. What frightens you. What makes you angry. What makes you stay after everyone else leaves. Then I used everything I knew about you to decide what you were allowed to know. Selene hasn't had enough time to do that yet.

TARRIK
That isn't fair.

LYESSA
No. I know.

TARRIK
Then what are you doing?

LYESSA
Missing something before it is completely gone.

Tarrik moves within reach. Lyessa lifts her hand and waits. He does not retreat. Her fingers settle on his jaw; his eyes close. She kisses his cheek, not his mouth, and rests her forehead against his temple.

LYESSA
Come back to me.

TARRIK
I'm standing right here.

LYESSA
You know what I mean.

TARRIK
I'll try.

LYESSA
That is a terrible answer.

TARRIK
It's the honest one.

Strategic alarm interrupts. Both displays light.

ON SCREEN:
NEON VEIL BEARER INTERFACE REQUIRED

LYESSA
He ordered it.

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
After you refused.

TARRIK
Yes.

LYESSA
What are you going to do?

TARRIK
Say no again.

LYESSA
And if he doesn't listen?

TARRIK
I don't know.

Footsteps approach. Neither cup has finished steaming.

95 INT. CROWNWATCH - THRONE CORRIDOR AND HALL - ETERNAL EVENING
SCOR-24-CS02

CROSS
High Centurion.

TARRIK
No.

CROSS
This is not release authorization.

TARRIK
I know.

CROSS
Then come willingly.

TARRIK
No.

CROSS
Agent Caedryn. Move.

LYESSA
No.

CROSS
This is not Cauldron.

LYESSA
That sentence is why you should leave.

CROSS
The order requires synchronization modeling.

Cross presents the limitations as reassurance.

CROSS
No release command. No concurrence simulation. No extraction.

TARRIK
Until the model shows extraction would be useful.

CROSS
Perhaps.

TARRIK
But I get to define what happens to me.

CROSS
Dominion law is less certain about that.

LYESSA
No one touches him.

CROSS
You are choosing insubordination.

LYESSA
Yes.

Cross does not order the soldiers forward under the security cameras. Tarrik moves toward the doors; Lyessa catches his arm.

LYESSA
I'm coming.

TARRIK
You don't have to.

LYESSA
I know.

Throne doors open. Caelus in full imperial armor watches Tarrik reach the old kneeling place and remain standing.

CAELUS
Your answer.

TARRIK
No.

CAELUS
To the throne?

TARRIK
The throne. Final Dawn. Bearer synchronization.

CAELUS
You understand this is not release.

TARRIK
I understand you asked yesterday.

CAELUS
I offered.

TARRIK
And I refused.

CAELUS
The strategic environment has changed.

TARRIK
No. Your justification changed.

CAELUS
I offered you authority to stop this.

TARRIK
I don't want it.

CAELUS
That is not humility.

TARRIK
I didn't say it was. I think a civilization that requires the right person on the throne is already broken.

Caelus turns away from the argument toward his technician.

CAELUS
Proceed with synchronization.

TARRIK
No.

LEAD TECHNICIAN
Sovereign authorization confirmed.

Amber paths extend toward Tarrik; Neon Veil responds without assent. He draws Velkorran. Guards raise weapons; Lyessa raises her sidearm. Cross reaches for his.

CAELUS
Stand down.

No one lowers a weapon. Tarrik advances. The technician retreats as Velkorran ignites.

CAELUS
Do not.

TARRIK
You don't get to decide this part.

First blow fractures the interface. Second drives Cinder into circuitry. Third destroys its core; synchronization dies. Sparks settle between heir and throne.

CAELUS
Move.

Tarrik shakes his head.

TARRIK
No.

Caelus unclasps his mantle. Gold-white light extends along the ancient imperial blade.

LYESSA
Caelus.

CAELUS
Do not make me do this.

Tarrik lowers Velkorran into guard.

TARRIK
I'm not.

Caelus attacks first. Their collision cracks basalt. His known forms pressure Tarrik's trained responses.

CAELUS
You telegraph the reversal.

Caelus knocks Tarrik down, then steps back, offering him a chance to yield.

CAELUS
Yield.

TARRIK
No.

CAELUS
Stop confusing stubbornness with courage.

TARRIK
Stop confusing victory with being right.

Tarrik fights with irregular rhythm and spatial movement. A broken crown-point crosses the basalt. Lyessa stays crying at the edge; she does not shoot.

CAELUS
That isn't Crownwatch.

TARRIK
No.

After Tarrik lands an abdominal cut, Caelus sees the influence of the Aurelion duel.

CAELUS
Veyne. She taught you to move.

TARRIK
She taught me to pay attention.

96 INT. CROWNWATCH - THRONE DAIS - ETERNAL EVENING
SCOR-24-CS03

The imperial blade spins across basalt. Tarrik rises on a barely supporting leg and holds Velkorran at Caelus's chest.

TARRIK
Stop.

CAELUS
Take the throne.

TARRIK
No. Stop Final Dawn.

CAELUS
Take the throne.

TARRIK
No.

CAELUS
Someone has to carry this.

TARRIK
Not like this.

CAELUS
Then how?

TARRIK
I don't know.

CAELUS
You keep saying that as though ignorance is a creed.

TARRIK
No. I keep saying it because I don't know.

Caelus's eyes move past Tarrik to the surviving node.

TARRIK
No.

Caelus lunges to the activation plate. Neon Veil burns against Tarrik's chest.

ON SCREEN:
SOVEREIGN OVERRIDE REQUESTED

TARRIK
No!

A fraction of a second: reachable arm, control node, Cinder in Tarrik's open hand. No image certifies that an alternative would succeed. Caelus turns, free hand reaching toward the fallen blade. Tarrik chooses the stab under his ribs.

A small wet breath leaves Caelus. Tarrik kills the ignition, pulls Velkorran free, lets it drop and catches the Emperor as both collapse to the steps.

TARRIK
Caelus.

Tarrik clamps both hands over the wound.

TARRIK
Medical.

No one moves.

TARRIK
MEDICAL!

Lyessa runs. Cross shouts for medics and exits. Caelus catches Tarrik's wrist.

CAELUS
Tarrik.

TARRIK
Don't talk.

CAELUS
You chose.

TARRIK
Yes.

CAELUS
Good.

TARRIK
Don't.

CAELUS
I wanted you to be better than me.

TARRIK
I know.

CAELUS
Be careful...

Blood breaks the sentence. Silence.

CAELUS
...what that costs.

TARRIK
You're not dying.

CAELUS
You were always terrible at lying.

Tarrik half laughs, half sobs. Caelus looks toward the throne.

CAELUS
Someone...

TARRIK
No.

CAELUS
Someone has to.

TARRIK
Then we find something better.

Caelus's face softens without confirming agreement. His hand slips free. His eyes remain open and never move again.

LYESSA
Tarrik.

She kneels across from him, hands hovering over the dead body.

LYESSA
Oh, Loehs. What did you do?

TARRIK
He wouldn't stop.

Amber channels turn white-gold. The system, not a cheering court, recognizes succession.

97 INT. CROWNWATCH - THRONE STEPS - ETERNAL EVENING
SCOR-24-CS04

ON SCREEN:
SOVEREIGN AUTHORITY LOST
DESIGNATED HEIR VERIFIED
TARRIK WALCUR
ASSUME SOVEREIGN AUTHORITY

LYESSA
Take it. Tarrik.

TARRIK
No.

Tarrik retrieves Velkorran and braces against the dais. Blood falls from his leg.

TARRIK
Decline.

ON SCREEN:
SOVEREIGN VACANCY WILL INITIATE EMERGENCY CONTINUITY
CONFIRM DECLINATION

LYESSA
No.

TARRIK
Lyessa.

LYESSA
You can stop all of this.

TARRIK
I know.

LYESSA
Then take it.

TARRIK
No.

LYESSA
You killed him.

TARRIK
I know.

LYESSA
Then take responsibility.

TARRIK
I am.

LYESSA
This is not responsibility. This is leaving.

TARRIK
I am not leaving.

Fleet and provincial requests appear above the still-warm body. Lyessa points toward them, not the crown.

LYESSA
But tonight there are fleets waiting for orders. There is a prison at Aurelion. Reformation is changing its architecture. Caelus is dead. And you are the heir.

TARRIK
I don't want it.

LYESSA
I don't care what you want.

She recoils from her own words. Tarrik reaches her cheek with a bloody hand. She leans into it.

TARRIK
We can build something else.

LYESSA
When? Before the fleet fractures? Before Cross invokes emergency military continuity? Before Reformation decides Caelus's death makes the terminal theirs?

TARRIK
I don't know.

LYESSA
You would let all of this fall apart because you are afraid of becoming him.

TARRIK
No. I am afraid of believing only I can stop it.

LYESSA
Maybe right now you are the only person who can.

He lowers his hand.

TARRIK
That is exactly the sentence I can't trust.

LYESSA
You don't get to kill him and then tell us nobody should inherit what he was carrying.

TARRIK
I didn't kill him for the throne.

LYESSA
That does not make the throne disappear.

TARRIK
Confirm declination.

ON SCREEN:
DECLINATION CONFIRMED

Lyessa turns away, takes three steps and stops. Her hand lowers to the sidearm. Tarrik forces himself upright, recognizing the shape of the warning.

TARRIK
Lyessa.

She turns with the weapon in both hands, crying openly.

LYESSA
Tarrik, please.

TARRIK
Put it down.

LYESSA
Take the throne.

TARRIK
No.

LYESSA
Please.

TARRIK
No.

LYESSA
I can't let this happen.

TARRIK
Then don't make this choice for me.

She almost lowers the gun. Then looks past him to throne, body and Dominion.

LYESSA
I'm not. I'm making it for them.

TARRIK
Lyessa--

The shot strikes beneath his ribs. He falls against the steps and Velkorran slips from his hand. Lyessa screams his name, drops the sidearm, and immediately presses the wound.

LYESSA
No. No, no, no. I'm sorry. Loehs, Tarrik, I'm sorry.

TARRIK
You...

LYESSA
What?

TARRIK
You chose.

LYESSA
Yes.

She closes her eyes.

LYESSA
Yes.

Cross returns with Crownwatch officers and sees both bodies, Lyessa between them.

CROSS
Loehs.

98 INT. CROWNWATCH - THRONE HALL - ETERNAL EVENING
SCOR-24-CS05

ON SCREEN:
DESIGNATED HEIR DECLINED
DESIGNATED HEIR INCAPACITATED
EMERGENCY CROWN CONTINUITY AVAILABLE

Lyessa looks toward the interface.

CROSS
Do not.

LYESSA
Someone has to.

CROSS
The Imperial Executive Council can assume provisional authority.

LYESSA
By the time they assemble, every fleet commander in the Dominion will know the throne is empty.

She bends and rests her forehead against Tarrik's.

LYESSA
I love you.

She rises, walks to the plate and places a trembling bloody hand on it.

ON SCREEN:
PROVISIONAL CROWN REGENCY
ACCEPT RESPONSIBILITY PENDING IMPERIAL CONTINUITY REVIEW

LYESSA
Accept.

ON SCREEN:
CROWN REGENT RECOGNIZED

Cross lowers his head only enough.

CROSS
Regent. What happened?

Lyessa looks at Tarrik. The truth is still available.

TARRIK
Don't.

LYESSA
Tarrik killed the Emperor.

CROSS
And?

LYESSA
He moved against Sovereign authority. He attempted to seize control of Crownwatch.

Tarrik closes his eyes.

CROSS
System record shows he declined authority.

A breath of hope crosses Tarrik's face, then Cross turns back to the Regent.

CROSS
Public account?

TARRIK
Don't.

LYESSA
Seal the throne-room record under Sovereign Continuity. Public account: Tarrik Walcur murdered Emperor Caelus during an unlawful attempt to overthrow Sovereign authority. Crownwatch intervened. The coup failed. Do it.

CROSS
Seal the record.

Officers act. Lyessa cannot bear Tarrik's eyes. Cross kneels and presses the wound.

CROSS
He's alive.

LYESSA
Stabilize him.

CROSS
A living Tarrik complicates the public account.

LYESSA
Stabilize him.

CROSS
Regent.

LYESSA
I said stabilize him.

CROSS
Medical team.

Medics replace her hands with pressure seals and injectors. Reformation terminal warning sounds.

LYESSA
Final Dawn?

CROSS
Feasibility assets remain staged. No aperture authorization has been issued.

LYESSA
Recall them.

CROSS
If we withdraw now and Reformation denial architecture establishes terminal superiority, Dominion access could be lost permanently.

LYESSA
Can they open the prison?

CROSS
Not under current models.

LYESSA
Can they prevent us from opening it?

CROSS
Potentially.

LYESSA
Can their denial architecture interfere with ours?

CROSS
Unknown.

She looks down at Tarrik, then at Caelus. She puts grief somewhere it will not prevent action.

LYESSA
Continue Final Dawn preparation.

Tarrik struggles; a medic holds his shoulder.

MEDIC
Hold still.

LYESSA
No aperture. Nothing opens without my direct authorization.

CROSS
Understood.

LYESSA
Find out exactly what happens if their denial architecture collides with ours.

CROSS
We are already modeling it.

LYESSA
Model faster.

Lyessa kneels beside him and touches the cheek she kissed before the duel.

LYESSA
I'm sorry.

His vision loses detail. The red window, crimson armor and empty throne remain. Before black takes him, her broken but commanding voice returns.

LYESSA
Continue Final Dawn.

SCOR 25 PAYMENT

99 EXT. MESTRIA - RECEIVING PLATFORM - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-25-CS01

Rain fractures the civic skyline. Trains run; a clinic unloads elderly patients; schoolchildren splash one another. Inside the arriving transport, Lyric sits in a stabilization harness, corruption darker along her neck.

LYRIC
If you stare any harder, it becomes romantic.

SELENE
I was evaluating your condition.

LYRIC
See? Romantic.

THARNE
Your core temperature is thirty-one point eight.

LYRIC
And yet my personality remains warm.

THARNE
No measurable evidence supports that.

Ramp opens to undrawn weapons and a courteous intake officer.

INTAKE OFFICER
Keeper Veyne. Pursuant to Emergency Continuity Review Order Seven-Nine, your operational equipment must remain in state custody during evidentiary proceedings.

Selene surrenders Axiom, then Staccato, their custody numbers appearing. Her fingers stay around collapsed Verity longer. The officer waits without reaching. She releases it and receives a receipt. The command strip follows; exposed skin feels wrong.

LYRIC
They're undressing you administratively.

SELENE
Helpful.

LYRIC
I try.

INTAKE OFFICER
Lyric Vale.

LYRIC
Unfortunately.

INTAKE OFFICER
You are being transferred to Biological Continuity Observation.

LYRIC
See? Much nicer than prison.

Medical personnel approach with holstered pulse-weapon security.

SELENE
She remains under my responsibility.

INTAKE OFFICER
Your Keeper authority is suspended for purposes of medical-containment assignment.

SELENE
Chancellor Voss?

INTAKE OFFICER
No.

SELENE
Who?

INTAKE OFFICER
Joint medical-security authorization.

THARNE
I should accompany her.

INTAKE OFFICER
Ensign Tharne Vadem, you are assigned independent witness status pending Continuity testimony. Continued contact before separate statement would compromise evidentiary separation.

Lyric releases the harness before anyone can. Her legs nearly fold; Tharne catches her.

LYRIC
Go.

SELENE
No.

LYRIC
You came back because you wanted the system to answer. So make it answer. If they dissect me, I intend to complain formally.

THARNE
They are not going to dissect you.

LYRIC
You sound almost certain.

Selene lets the medical team escort Lyric. She leaves empty-handed for the hearing.

100 INT. MESTRIA - EMERGENCY CONTINUITY REVIEW CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-25-CS02

A blue Keeper light glows at Selene's collar. Five officers sit opposite at her height. Voss sits several seats away, neither beside nor against her.

SENIOR JUDGE
Emergency Continuity Review Veyne-Seven-Two. Time stamped. Full evidentiary capture authorized.

MAL
Keeper Veyne, do you contest that you entered Glass Citadel under falsified transit credentials?

SELENE
No.

MAL
Coordinating with Dominion High Centurion Tarrik Walcur?

SELENE
No.

MAL
Transferring independently authenticated Reformation archival evidence into his possession?

SELENE
No.

MAL
So we are not primarily here to determine what you did.

SELENE
No.

MAL
We are here to determine whether what you did remains compatible with Keeper authority.

SELENE
Yes.

Selene submits the complete evidentiary package. 7283, provenance, alteration chains, Voss restriction, Meridian/Witness telemetry and specimen orders populate the table. Cauldron appears last.

MAL
What is that?

SELENE
Authenticated Dominion command evidence from Operation Cauldron.

MAL
Source?

SELENE
Tarrik Walcur.

MAL
And you gave him Record 7283.

SELENE
Yes.

MAL
Why?

SELENE
Because his government buried Cauldron. And mine buried this.

ON SCREEN:
SOURCE MATCH: 100.000%
PRE-SECESSION CUSTODY VERIFIED

EXAMINER
Glass Citadel primary-mirror authentication has been independently reproduced. No material challenge remains regarding source integrity. Record 7283 is authentic.

Selene closes her eyes in relief.

EXAMINER
Authenticity is not the question before this review.

SELENE
It should be.

MAL
Does authentication of Record 7283 legalize falsifying transit credentials?

Selene is silent: truth does not answer every jurisdictional question.

MAL
Does it grant an individual Keeper authority to decide which laws remain binding whenever that Keeper concludes the institution enforcing them has failed?

SELENE
No.

Voss rises for executive testimony.

MAL
Did you know Sovereign Record 7283 existed in authentic, unabridged form before Keeper Veyne's investigation?

VOSS
Yes.

MAL
How long?

VOSS
Eleven years.

MAL
Did you authorize continued restriction of that record?

VOSS
Yes.

MAL
Did you believe the alteration accidental?

VOSS
No. Immediate disclosure would predictably be used by Dominion political actors to characterize the Reformation as a civilization founded upon deliberate fraud.

MAL
Would that characterization be entirely false?

VOSS
No.

SELENE
You told me you challenged the restriction for six months.

VOSS
Yes.

SELENE
And then?

VOSS
I chose preservation.

SELENE
You chose the lie.

VOSS
Yes.

Mal turns to Selene, refusing to make this Voss's trial instead.

MAL
Then what is the meaningful difference between your conduct and Chancellor Voss's?

SELENE
The endpoint. Lyric, Tharne, and I established a written endpoint because I did not trust my own future judgment to keep concealment temporary. I did not replace the institution with myself. I prevented the institution from replacing the evidence with itself. The danger is not that judgment exists. The danger is pretending procedure made it disappear.

Tharne enters in formal gray without insignia. His evidence independently establishes stabilization.

MAL
So activation was necessary.

THARNE
I did not say that. I believe completing the Meridian was the correct decision given the evidence available. I cannot prove there was no unknown alternative.

MAL
Can you scientifically exclude the possibility that Lyric Vale's condition influenced Keeper Veyne's private perceptions?

THARNE
No.

SELENE
Can you establish that any of those mechanisms occurred?

THARNE
No.

SELENE
Any evidence of them? Any measurable cognitive alteration?

THARNE
No.

MAL
Absence of evidence is not exclusion.

THARNE
Neither is absence of exclusion evidence.

During recess every room display changes.

ON SCREEN:
EMPEROR CAELUS VIREL CONFIRMED DEAD
ASSAILANT IDENTIFIED: TARRIK WALCUR
FAILED SOVEREIGN SEIZURE
WALCUR STATUS: UNCONFIRMED

Selene stands before remembering to.

SELENE
No. That's wrong.

SENIOR JUDGE
What is?

SELENE
The seizure. He did not want the throne.

MAL
People may want different things under pressure.

SELENE
Request Crownwatch succession logs.

CLERK
Unavailable.

SELENE
Throne-room system record.

CLERK
Restricted under Sovereign Continuity.

SELENE
Confirmation of Walcur's death.

CLERK
None.

SELENE
Medical status.

CLERK
Unknown.

Only official narrative exists. The private cipher has burned. The table changes to Terminal Denial readiness, 67 percent.

HALEN OR
The Denial Protocol establishes a Reformation-authenticated rejection layer against unilateral foreign Sovereign commands.

SELENE
Do you know that it cannot affect them?

HALEN OR
No.

SELENE
Then stop.

VOSS
I proposed Glass Citadel verification and reciprocal suspension of all terminal modification.

SENIOR JUDGE
Defense Council rejected the proposal.

VOSS
Four to three.

SELENE
You voted against deployment.

VOSS
Yes. Our denial research accelerated after Dominion authority-path work became visible. Their research accelerated after ours. That is the escalation.

SENIOR JUDGE
This tribunal has no authority to adjudicate Defense Council strategy.

The panel reconvenes after recess. The ruling shows 7283 authentic, alteration deliberate, executive restriction maintained, completion stabilized containment, no established cognitive control but exclusion impossible.

SENIOR JUDGE
Selene Veyne, this tribunal does not find you guilty of treason. It does find that your continued exercise of active Keeper authority presents unacceptable Continuity risk pending final disposition. Effective immediately, Keeper commission privileges are placed in abeyance.

The blue light at her collar simply dies.

SENIOR JUDGE
Neural command privileges are suspended. Classified network access revoked. Interregional travel requires authorization. Operational command withdrawn.

SELENE
What happens to Record 7283?

SENIOR JUDGE
Full evidentiary release remains restricted pending Civil Continuity impact review.

SELENE
Then you are still suppressing it.

SENIOR JUDGE
We are controlling timing and context of full release.

Selene hears the shape of her own Forum evasion. She touches the dark collar, then leaves for medical visitation.

101 INT. MESTRIA - BIOLOGICAL CONTINUITY VISITOR ROOM - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-25-CS03

Tharne notices the dark Keeper collar. Lyric sits upright behind glass.

LYRIC
They turned you off.

SELENE
Apparently.

LYRIC
Rude. How bad?

SELENE
Your trial begins tomorrow. They added material compromise of a Keeper.

LYRIC
They want me to be the reason.

SELENE
Yes.

LYRIC
What happened with Tarrik?

SELENE
Dominion says he killed Caelus.

LYRIC
Did he?

SELENE
That part may be true.

LYRIC
And the rest?

SELENE
They say he attempted to seize the throne.

LYRIC
No.

SELENE
I trust him.

LYRIC
Then whoever wrote the statement needs everyone to believe that he did.

SELENE
I don't know if he is alive.

LYRIC
I know.

Tharne asks Lyric with a look before opening the medical waveform.

THARNE
Her neural-Echo activity since we entered Mestria.

SELENE
When?

THARNE
Every time Terminal Denial executes a live architecture query.

LYRIC
I can feel them.

SELENE
Who?

LYRIC
The commands. It is like someone tapping on a pipe.

SELENE
From Lyric?

THARNE
Yes.

LYRIC
Not from me. Through me. Something notices.

SELENE
Can you hear it?

LYRIC
No. It knows when you touch the lock.

THARNE
We cannot establish that.

LYRIC
Fine. I don't know what it is doing. But every time one of your people pokes Aurelion, something inside me turns its head.

SELENE
I need to report this.

THARNE
You no longer have Keeper access.

SELENE
I noticed.

THARNE
I retain technical-witness filing rights.

SELENE
Do it.

Selene uses the visitor terminal. Her attempted extinction-risk priority is rejected; HIGH is the highest civilian option.

ON SCREEN:
ACCESS LEVEL: CIVILIAN RESTRICTED
INSUFFICIENT AUTHORITY
ESTIMATED TECHNICAL REVIEW: 31-38 HOURS

THARNE
Mine entered the Continuity technical queue.

SELENE
How long?

THARNE
Fourteen-hour target.

SELENE
Not fast enough.

THARNE
No.

ON SCREEN:
DEPLOYMENT AUTHORIZATION: APPROVED
DEFENSE COUNCIL AUTHORIZATION: 4-3

Voss's dissent is recorded beneath the approval. The public screen changes to Lyessa in blood-marked crimson armor before the throne.

ON SCREEN:
CROWN REGENT LYESSA CAEDRYN
ASSUMES EMERGENCY SOVEREIGN AUTHORITY

LYRIC
That her?

Selene does not need to answer.

THARNE
Crownwatch says Regent Caedryn prevented Tarrik's seizure attempt.

SELENE
No.

Selene compares a false chronology without succession recording, body or medical confirmation. Her trust supplies an inference, not a recovered archive.

SELENE
He didn't take it.

THARNE
What?

SELENE
He refused.

THARNE
Selene, we don't have evidence--

SELENE
I know.

She looks from the accepted-truth ruling to Denial approval and the medical trace. The system knows and continues. The clean partition remains locked.

SCOR 26 SILENCING

102 INT. MESTRIA - MEDICAL OBSERVATION AND CONTINUITY COURT - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-26-CS01

Selene's clean detention room wakes her. Trial notice appears. She requests a stay; no execution order exists yet. The system permits visitation at 06:15. Cut through her waiting to Lyric with real coffee.

SELENE
Your trial begins in less than three hours.

LYRIC
I noticed.

SELENE
Are you afraid?

Lyric lowers her cup.

LYRIC
Yes. Very. But I would prefer not to spend the remaining portion of my legal existence pretending fear has suddenly made me boring.

SELENE
I can fight this.

LYRIC
I know. That is why I need you awake today.

SELENE
I am awake.

LYRIC
You are furious. Different organ.

THARNE
She had another episode at 03:41, concurrent with a Terminal Denial synchronization test. Four seconds without motor control. Eleven without respiration.

SELENE
You stopped breathing.

LYRIC
It restarted.

SELENE
Response?

THARNE
Receipt confirmed.

SELENE
Action?

THARNE
None yet.

At 08:58 Lyric enters the court in a transparent mobile containment frame. Selene and Tharne sit together. Blue public-feed indicator turns on.

LYRIC
Hello, civilization.

NERAL
Ms. Vale.

LYRIC
I was being transparent.

Charges resolve: theft, hostile-state infiltration, attempted assassination participation, evasion, transit falsification, Glass Citadel entry and existential-security concealment. Final charge is continuity endangerment through Eclipse-associated condition.

ORLAN
Did you steal the object now designated the Ianis Crownmark?

LYRIC
Yes.

ORLAN
Why?

LYRIC
Because Dominion had it.

ORLAN
Is that sufficient legal justification?

LYRIC
No.

ORLAN
Did you enter Crownwatch during an operation intended to assassinate Emperor Caelus Virel?

LYRIC
Yes.

Orlan calls the doctor. Kell's proper objections are sustained; nobody needs to manufacture evidence.

ORLAN
Is it reversible?

VALEEN
Not by any treatment currently known.

ORLAN
Can you predict the eventual course?

VALEEN
No.

ORLAN
Has person-to-person transmission been observed?

VALEEN
No.

ORLAN
Can transmission be excluded?

VALEEN
No.

KELL
Observed Ms. Vale intentionally facilitate Eclipse emergence?

VALEEN
No.

KELL
Has she participated in actions that reduced Eclipse emergence?

VALEEN
Yes.

Tharne takes the witness seat, eyes finding Lyric before he answers.

ORLAN
You observed a behavioral anomaly at Aurelion.

THARNE
Yes.

ORLAN
Describe it.

THARNE
For approximately two seconds, I did not believe the person looking back at me was entirely Lyric.

ORLAN
Did she attack you?

THARNE
No.

ORLAN
Raise a weapon?

THARNE
Yes.

ORLAN
Why did she stop?

THARNE
I said her name.

ORLAN
Can you guarantee that would work again?

THARNE
No.

KELL
Has Lyric Vale ever expressed loyalty to the Eclipse?

THARNE
No.

KELL
Did she warn personnel at Aurelion not to place living Eclipse material into containment apparatus?

THARNE
Yes.

KELL
Did acting on them save lives?

THARNE
Yes.

KELL
Can you establish that killing her will reduce the probability of a future Eclipse event?

Tharne stops before answering.

THARNE
No.

ORLAN
Can you establish that keeping her alive will not increase that probability?

He closes his eyes.

THARNE
No.

Both answers remain in the civic record. Lyric does not look away from him.

103 INT. MESTRIA - EMERGENCY CONTINUITY COURT - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-26-CS02

ON SCREEN:
FORMER ACTIVE KEEPER -- COMMISSION IN ABEYANCE

ORLAN
Did Lyric Vale influence your decisions?

SELENE
Yes. She made me less comfortable with my excuses.

ORLAN
Explain.

SELENE
When I withheld information, she asked what the withholding cost. When I followed an order, she asked whether obedience removed my responsibility. When I called secrecy necessary, she reminded me that necessity did not make it clean.

ORLAN
So she encouraged disobedience.

SELENE
She encouraged judgment.

ORLAN
Did she make you more willing to trust Tarrik Walcur?

SELENE
No.

ORLAN
No?

SELENE
Tarrik did that.

LYRIC
Still working on it.

Neral looks at her. She lowers the small lifted hand.

SELENE
Elevated risk is not proof of an outcome.

ORLAN
No.

SELENE
Then the question before this court is not whether Lyric is safe. It is whether uncertainty makes death permissible. If you kill her because you cannot prove she is safe, say that. Do not call possibility evidence. Do not call uncertainty guilt. Do not tell the Reach this was the only available choice because you were afraid to make another.

ORLAN
If Lyric Vale survives and tomorrow becomes the mechanism through which the Eclipse enters Mestria, will you accept responsibility for arguing that she should live?

SELENE
Yes. And if you kill her today and she would never have harmed anyone, will you?

Orlan sits. Lyric is not required to speak. She stands; her frame rises with her.

LYRIC
I assume everyone would prefer that I say I'm safe.

No one answers.

LYRIC
I can't. I don't know what is happening to me. Sometimes it hurts. Sometimes I look at my own hand and need an extra second before it feels like mine. I am afraid of becoming something else. I am afraid you may eventually be right about me.

Let that admission make her more human, not easier to condemn.

LYRIC
But being afraid you may be right is not the same as agreeing that I should die. Keep me in a box. I will complain constantly.

A few observers laugh despite themselves.

LYRIC
I stole your Crownmark. I entered places where I was not invited. I lied, ran, and made threats I intended to keep. But I have never served the Eclipse. I have spent every day since it touched me trying not to.

She looks toward Tharne and Selene.

LYRIC
If one day I lose that fight, stop me. But today I am still here. Today I am me.

She faces the judges again.

LYRIC
If you kill me anyway, put that in the record.

She sits. Court recesses. Selene and Tharne immediately work with Kell on containment alternatives.

104 INT. MESTRIA - COURT AND APPEAL ROUTE - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-26-CS03

Neutral custody is declined for jurisdiction. Cryogenic suspension cannot rule out remote interaction. Remote quarantine and permanent prison receive the same unresolved-risk objection.

ON SCREEN:
RISK CANNOT BE SUFFICIENTLY CONSTRAINED

NERAL
This court does not find sufficient evidence to establish intentional service to the Eclipse, Nor sufficient evidence to establish that Ms. Vale caused cognitive compromise of Selene Veyne. This court does find that Ms. Vale's documented physiological interaction with Eclipse-associated systems constitutes an ongoing and unbounded Continuity hazard for which no validated containment method presently exists. The court therefore authorizes Biological Continuity Termination.

Kell is moving before Selene can rise.

KELL
Immediate appeal. Full panel. Sentence stayed pending review.

NERAL
Emergency Continuity statute permits immediate implementation where delay itself constitutes unresolved propagation risk.

KELL
Then Chancellor review.

NERAL
Executive petition authorized.

SELENE
What method?

ON SCREEN:
MATTER REDUCTION PROTOCOL
ESTIMATED CONSCIOUS INTERVAL AFTER INITIATION: < 2.0 SECONDS
NO RECOVERABLE ORGANIC RESIDUE

Color leaves Lyric's face. She looks toward Tharne.

LYRIC
That's efficient.

THARNE
Lyric.

LYRIC
I don't want to.

NERAL
Sentence implementation is stayed for twenty minutes pending executive petition.

Selene hurries upstairs. At the checkpoint an officer blocks her, weapons undrawn.

SECURITY OFFICER
Ms. Veyne.

SELENE
Move.

SECURITY OFFICER
I cannot.

Frost freezes his boots and seals the next door. Nine minutes after leaving court, Voss intercepts Selene. Alarms gather behind them.

VOSS
Stop.

Selene stops.

VOSS
I filed the emergency stay.

SELENE
Then stop the sentence.

VOSS
I am trying.

SELENE
No. Stop it.

VOSS
There is no ordinary authority to overturn a final emergency-court order.

SELENE
Continuity Hold.

Voss looks away. Selene sees recognition, not lack of a legal lever.

SELENE
Use it.

VOSS
No. A Continuity Hold permits suspension of judicial action when continuation of government itself faces material threat, Lyric's sentence does not meet that standard.

SELENE
Interpret it broadly.

VOSS
No.

SELENE
Break the system for five minutes.

VOSS
To do what?

SELENE
Keep her alive.

VOSS
And after five?

SELENE
We find ten more.

For one heartbeat Voss wants to. The answer does not change.

VOSS
If I suspend a lawful sentence because I believe the court reached the wrong moral conclusion, what prevents the next Chancellor from doing the same when she believes someone deserves death?

SELENE
Lyric being alive.

VOSS
That is not a principle.

SELENE
No. It is a person. Order exists that people may flourish, People do not exist that order may endure.

VOSS
I know what the King said.

SELENE
Then serve her.

VOSS
You think I have not imagined walking into that courtroom and ordering everyone out? I command security. I could delay the sentence by force.

SELENE
Then do it.

VOSS
And establish that judicial decisions survive only until the executive feels strongly enough?

SELENE
Not every exception becomes doctrine.

VOSS
Every sovereign says that.

SELENE
Then stop it.

VOSS
I can't.

SELENE
You won't.

Voss absorbs the correction.

VOSS
Yes.

ON SCREEN:
EXECUTIVE PETITION DENIED
SENTENCE IMPLEMENTATION: 14:00

Selene leaves. Voss does not ask guards to block the final-contact route.

105 INT. MESTRIA - FINAL-CONTACT ROOM - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-26-CS04

Lyric has no shoes. Selene notices before sitting beside Tharne.

SELENE
Why did they take your shoes?

LYRIC
Apparently laces are a revolutionary technology.

SELENE
They were slip-ons.

LYRIC
Then they are cowards.

The attempted smile ends. Silence stretches.

LYRIC
This is dreadful.

THARNE
I'm sorry.

LYRIC
For what?

THARNE
Answering them. Every time they asked whether I could guarantee something, I said no.

LYRIC
You told the truth.

THARNE
I supplied every reason.

LYRIC
You supplied every fact. I needed someone in that room who knew what was happening to me and did not make me easier to save by pretending.

THARNE
I would have preferred easier.

LYRIC
So would I.

She places a hand against glass. He mirrors it.

THARNE
I thought there would be time.

LYRIC
For what?

He cannot speak, then the words arrive at once.

THARNE
I love you.

A tear crosses Lyric's face.

LYRIC
You absolute bastard.

His broken laugh allows hers.

LYRIC
You couldn't have done that yesterday?

THARNE
I didn't know yesterday was the last one.

LYRIC
I love you too.

Selene looks away until Lyric calls her back.

LYRIC
Selene. Don't become stupid because they kill me.

SELENE
That is your final advice?

LYRIC
You are going to want everything afterward to become simple. Everyone in this building wrong. Everything you do next justified because of what they did to me.

SELENE
They are killing you.

LYRIC
Yes. Don't turn me into permission. They will call this humane because it is fast, No blood. No body. Nothing for anyone to photograph. Don't let them call it clean just because the room stays clean.

SELENE
I won't.

Another pulse drives Lyric forward in pain. Tharne's trace spikes violet.

THARNE
Terminal Denial, Another synchronization pulse.

LYRIC
The commands have a shape.

THARNE
A pattern?

LYRIC
Yes. You keep asking the lock questions. It's learning the shape of the questions. You think you're teaching the door what you want. You're teaching whatever is behind it how you ask.

SELENE
Send it.

THARNE
Voss, Defense Council, Glass Citadel.

SELENE
Dominion, if you can reach a neutral channel.

THARNE
Yes.

Security enters early, cutting the apparent seven-minute count.

SECURITY OFFICER
Final contact concludes in two minutes.

SELENE
No.

LYRIC
Selene. Don't make the last two minutes about him.

Selene sits again.

LYRIC
Not the scanner. Me.

Tharne closes it.

LYRIC
You too.

Selene's palm joins the glass opposite Lyric's.

LYRIC
Keep it awful.

SELENE
I will.

The rear door opens. For one second Lyric's terror is unhidden. Medical officers enter; she goes with them. Hold the empty place behind glass for one breath, not a promise of rescue.

106 INT. MESTRIA - BIOSECURITY TERMINATION SUITE FOUR - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-26-CS05

Outside the suite Selene reads the required attendance notice.

SELENE
If we refuse?

MEDICAL COORDINATOR
Post-termination screening becomes mandatory under restraint.

THARNE
We'll attend.

Lyric walks the final six meters alone. White-blue emitters ring the floor marker. No chair or executioner awaits. Public civic feed uses a wide angle.

CIVIC NARRATOR
The sentence of the Emergency Continuity Court will now be implemented following criminal adjudication, medical review, executive petition, and statutory appeal. The Reformation remains committed to due process under law and decisive protection of its citizens from existential biological threats.

SELENE
Turn it off.

Local speaker is muted; civic broadcast elsewhere continues. Lyric finds her friends through glass.

LYRIC
Still terrible lighting.

Identity confirmation completes. Transparent panels rise; the lattice charges. Lyric's face changes to immediate panic. Selene lunges toward the observation interlock.

Selene reaches the observation door.

ON SCREEN:
AUTHORITY DENIED

Her Frost consumes the access panel and cracks its first lock. Tharne opens a diagnostic interruption request.

ON SCREEN:
SAFETY INTERRUPTION REQUESTED
DENIED: SENTENCE AUTHORITY SUPERSEDES TECHNICAL WITNESS

Security enters. Selene freezes one officer's knee and drives another into the wall. Tharne reaches the coolant dump; the sentence system isolates.

ON SCREEN:
UNAUTHORIZED INTERFERENCE DETECTED
BIOSECURITY SENTENCE PROTOCOL ISOLATED

A dampening field kills Selene's Frost. Security pulls her from the door.

Lyric looks through the glass and shakes her head, then looks at Tharne and Selene. White-blue lattice activates. Black-violet lines briefly flare brighter than it. Then she is gone.

The lattice continues through empty air. Filtration draws the last light into a sterile channel. No ash, stain or recoverable fragment remains.

ON SCREEN:
BIOLOGICAL REDUCTION COMPLETE
RESIDUAL ORGANIC MATERIAL: NONE DETECTED
SENTENCE COMPLETE
BIOLOGICAL CONTINUITY SECURED

Selene stops fighting. Tharne slides to the floor, hands still on the dead console.

THARNE
There should be something.

No answer. The floor stays clean and empty.

107 INT. MESTRIA - PROCESSING DESK AND HOLDING ROOM - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-26-CS06

A processing record lists sentence interference, assault, unauthorized Echo use, safeguard compromise and sedition.

PROCESSING OFFICER
Do you contest the conduct?

SELENE
No.

PROCESSING OFFICER
You attempted to stop the sentence.

SELENE
Yes.

PROCESSING OFFICER
You used force against security personnel.

SELENE
Yes.

PROCESSING OFFICER
You would do it again?

SELENE
Yes.

He checks the box: her name beside the consequence. That evening Voss enters holding room alone.

VOSS
They want to imprison you.

SELENE
Reasonable.

VOSS
Indefinitely.

SELENE
For my safety?

VOSS
No.

SELENE
At least we are improving.

Voss's almost smile dies.

VOSS
Several Defense Council members argue that your attempt to compromise the lattice constituted existential-security sabotage.

SELENE
Did it?

VOSS
Yes.

SELENE
Then they are right.

VOSS
I can prevent them from sending you into a Continuity facility.

SELENE
How?

VOSS
Exile.

SELENE
From Mestria?

VOSS
From Reformation core jurisdiction. Indefinite duration. No Keeper authority, neural access, protected systems, or military movement. Transfer to frontier jurisdiction. Reentry prohibited without Continuity authorization.

SELENE
Citizenship?

VOSS
Retained.

SELENE
How generous.

VOSS
I argued against revocation.

SELENE
Why bend for me? You would not break the system for Lyric.

VOSS
Because the law gives me room.

Selene laughs without pleasure. Voss closes her eyes.

SELENE
Lyric died because the law gave you none.

VOSS
Because I chose not to claim authority it did not give me.

SELENE
And I live because a clause happens to leave you some.

VOSS
Yes. I do not know how to make that just.

SELENE
It isn't.

VOSS
No. Your exile hearing is at 08:00.

Voss stands at the door.

SELENE
You watched.

VOSS
Yes.

Selene waits but has no question she wants answered. Voss leaves.

108 INT. MESTRIA - SECURE HOLDING ROOM - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-26-CS07

Tharne looks empty rather than calm. He places the module between them.

THARNE
Lyric's final neural trace.

Reduction field, collapse and violet signal appear. Caerion II timing aligns to the millisecond.

THARNE
When the reduction field activated.

He aligns the time codes.

THARNE
something at Aurelion responded.

SELENE
Boundary pressure?

THARNE
Terminal recognition.

SELENE
She was right.

THARNE
Every live query produced a response. When she died, the response changed.

SELENE
Who has this?

THARNE
Defense Council, Voss, Glass Citadel.

SELENE
Dominion?

THARNE
Neutral Meridian research relay.

SELENE
Authorized?

THARNE
No.

Seven repository icons open beyond Reformation control.

SELENE
Record 7283.

THARNE
The complete version. Alteration history, Voss's admission, Terminal Denial, the terminal warning, and Cauldron.

SELENE
Tarrik gave Cauldron to me.

THARNE
You gave me permission to preserve your evidence.

SELENE
Not publish it.

THARNE
No. Should I release it?

Selene's immediate yes almost comes. She stops before turning Lyric into permission.

SELENE
What do you think?

THARNE
I asked you.

SELENE
I know.

THARNE
Then tell me what to do.

SELENE
No. It is authentic. People may weaponize it. It may destabilize the Reformation, and Dominion propaganda will use it. It may also prevent anyone from burying this again. You decide what that means.

For several seconds he hates her for leaving the decision his. She lets him. He looks at seven repositories.

THARNE
I release it.

SELENE
Then do it.

He presses the command. One government rejects; neutral archive and outer civic mirror accept. Copies propagate.

ON SCREEN:
DISTRIBUTION THRESHOLD REACHED
RECALL IMPOSSIBLE

SELENE
Your name is attached.

THARNE
Yes.

SELENE
You could remove it.

THARNE
No.

The evidence leaves Mestria. Hold on two people who cannot know what it will cost.

109 INT. MESTRIA - DISPOSITION ROOM AND EXILE TRANSPORT - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-26-CS08

The magistrate authenticates disposition. No Voss or Tharne sits beside Selene.

ON SCREEN:
KEEPER COMMISSION: TERMINATED
SECURITY CLEARANCE: REVOKED
NEURAL COMMAND PRIVILEGES: REVOKED
REFORMATION CORE JURISDICTION: EXILE
RETURN PROHIBITED WITHOUT CONTINUITY AUTHORIZATION
CITIZENSHIP: RETAINED

MAGISTRATE
Do you understand the disposition?

SELENE
Yes.

MAGISTRATE
Do you accept transportation to the designated frontier transfer point?

Selene evaluates six guards and her empty hands. She could use Frost. She chooses not to fight.

SELENE
Yes.

MAGISTRATE
Disposition complete.

At the terminal Tharne has five minutes across a painted security line. He studies her civilian coat and absence of insignia.

THARNE
You look strange.

SELENE
So do you.

THARNE
I always look like this.

SELENE
Exactly.

His smile collapses. Selene steps over the line and hugs him. He freezes, then holds her back.

THARNE
I should come.

SELENE
You can. You lose technical access, You lose the ability to challenge Terminal Denial from inside. And you are one of the only people who can prove the relationship between Lyric's neural response and Aurelion.

THARNE
Loehs you.

They both laugh, then wipe their faces.

THARNE
I hate that staying feels like leaving her.

SELENE
It isn't.

THARNE
How do you know?

SELENE
I don't.

He accepts the answer.

THARNE
I stay.

SELENE
Yes.

THARNE
I still believe the system matters.

SELENE
I know.

THARNE
I don't know what that means anymore.

SELENE
Good.

Boarding signal interrupts the small smile.

THARNE
What are you going to do?

SELENE
I don't know.

He embraces her once more. Neither says goodbye. The civilian transport rises through rain; clinics and commuter routes keep working beneath it. Selene cannot turn their real good into an excuse for the empty execution room, or erase the good to make grief easier.

Tharne's last encrypted packet reaches her civilian device before restrictions propagate.

ON SCREEN:
TERMINAL DENIAL PROTOCOL: DEPLOYED
CAERION II AUTHORITY LAYER ACTIVE
DOMINION FINAL DAWN AUTHORITY SIGNAL DETECTED AT AURELION
INTERACTION NOT PRESENT IN MODEL
BOUNDARY PHASE VARIANCE: +0.003%

She tries to answer.

ON SCREEN:
OUTBOUND RESTRICTED CHANNEL UNAVAILABLE
THEY ARE INTERACTING.
VOSS BELIEVES ME. SHE IS TRYING TO FORCE A SHUTDOWN.
DOMINION SIGNAL IS NOT WITHDRAWING.

The response interval narrows again. Selene sits in her assigned civilian seat as the next emergency builds.

SCOR 27 KEEP IT OPEN / STAY GONE

110 INT. MESTRIA - CIVILIAN TRANSPORT - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-27-CS01

Eighteen hours after Lyric's execution.

ON SCREEN:
AURELION BOUNDARY PHASE VARIANCE: +0.009%

A third warning reaches Selene before she finishes the second. The boy across the aisle still plays with projected ships; his sister sleeps against their mother.

ON SCREEN:
AUTONOMOUS CONFLICT RESOLUTION ACTIVE

SELENE
No.

She rises. The transport attendant approaches.

TRANSPORT ATTENDANT
Ms. Veyne, please remain restrained during ascent.

SELENE
I need the pilot.

TRANSPORT ATTENDANT
Passenger cockpit access is prohibited.

SELENE
Aurelion is destabilizing.

Cabin flashes red, lights fail. Every civilian screen receives the system-wide alert. The aircraft turns back over Mestria.

PILOT
All passengers remain secured. Regional navigation has suspended outbound corridors. We are holding emergency vector pending reroute.

ON SCREEN:
THE RESPONSE IS NOT OURS
SOURCE TRACE: AURELION INTERIOR
COMMAND PATTERN SIMILARITY TO DENIAL PROTOCOL: 96.8%

Cut to Tharne matching the new signal to Lyric's final trace. Voss enters in a charcoal interface suit, hair no longer exact.

VOSS
Status.

OPERATIONS CHIEF
Terminal Denial remains active through Caerion II. Executive shutdown was issued seven minutes ago.

VOSS
And?

OPERATIONS CHIEF
Rejected by distributed Continuity safeguards.

VOSS
Defense Council voted to deploy it. They can vote to kill it.

OPERATIONS CHIEF
Three members are unreachable.

Voss sees the final trace still open beside Tharne.

VOSS
What did she tell you?

THARNE
She said the commands had a shape. That we thought we were teaching the door what we wanted. We were teaching whatever was behind it how we ask.

VOSS
Disconnect Caerion.

OPERATIONS CHIEF
Distributed nodes will assume authority.

VOSS
Disconnect those.

OPERATIONS CHIEF
That would constitute deliberate destruction of emergency defense infrastructure.

VOSS
Meaning?

OPERATIONS CHIEF
It would be illegal.

VOSS
Break it.

Yesterday's refusal remains in Tharne's face.

VOSS
Break the damned thing.

Tharne cuts relays. The independent maintenance lattice reassigns authority faster than he can destroy it.

THARNE
It isn't learning anymore.

VOSS
What?

THARNE
The response came first.

VOSS
If it answered before we transmitted.

She looks from the reply to the not-yet-sent query.

VOSS
what is it doing?

THARNE
Predicting us.

Cut Crownwatch: Lyessa wears a temporary mantle over armor still marked with Tarrik's blood. The crown is in protected storage, not on her head.

LYESSA
Is the prison opening?

CROSS
No.

LYESSA
Stop answering the terminal. Answer me.

CROSS
Containment is destabilizing.

LYESSA
Because of Final Dawn.

CROSS
And Terminal Denial.

She remembers Tarrik's refusal and closes her eyes.

LYESSA
Abort Final Dawn.

CROSS
Regent.

LYESSA
Abort it.

CROSS
If we disengage while Denial remains active, Reformation may establish dominant terminal authority.

LYESSA
I don't care. Tarrik was right. Shut Final Dawn down.

ON SCREEN:
SAFE DISENGAGEMENT BLOCKED
FOREIGN TERMINAL CONTEST ACTIVE

She presses her regency band to command surface.

LYESSA
I am the Sovereign authority recognized by this system. Shut down.

ON SCREEN:
DENIED PENDING SAFE ACCESS HANDOFF

CROSS
We can sever Neon Veil physically.

LYESSA
Do it.

CROSS
We will lose the recovered interface architecture.

LYESSA
Hayden.

He stops.

LYESSA
Cut it.

CROSS
Yes.

Her secondary field confirms Tarrik's medical evacuation cleared orbit two hours ago, destination sealed. In a brief memory, a physical note and Velkorran lie beside his cot.

ON SCREEN:
CONTRARY BEARER ARBITRATION REQUIRED
ABORT ALL EXTERNAL AUTHORITY MODIFICATION

Cut back to Selene's civilian cabin: screens become deep black, a violet line fractures them, and a branching pulse spreads through cloud. A scream sounds forward. Selene turns toward the flight emergency.

111 INT./EXT. AURELION FLEETS / MESTRIA / CROWNWATCH - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-27-CS02

Resolute Crown receives warning; Accord receives it eighty milliseconds later. Both order withdrawal. Neither completes the turn. Five white-gold containment lines appear across the stars, invaded by amber authority and blue denial.

ON SCREEN:
REMOTE ANCHOR IV: PHASE LOST
REMOTE ANCHORS I-III: COHERENCE CRITICAL
TERMINAL ANCHOR LOAD: UNBOUNDED
RELEASE AUTHORIZATION: WITHHELD

Neither Tarrik nor Selene has consented. An interior strike tears the structure around the still-refusing lock. The five lines snap.

ON SCREEN:
STRUCTURAL CONTAINMENT FAILURE

Black-violet rupture ejects old plating, bone and living ships. A Dominion lance destroys part of the first vessel; surviving fragments reverse direction and enter the flagship's armor. Its forward lance turns without bridge command.

RESOLUTE CROWN BRIDGE OFFICER
Hard disconnect the weapon.

Too late: the flagship destroys a Dominion cruiser. Accord launches perfectly coordinated drones; eleven seconds later part of the swarm turns against its own fleet with valid credentials. Contact count outruns tracking. Tharne's interoperable threat channels reactivate; amber/blue fleet arcs fight together and lose.

Mestria Tower Seven feed: Ianis Crownmark confiscated at Lyric's intake glows white-gold then violet. A hand comes through a line in an intact floor. The organism folds its ribs through the aperture, corrupts a technician by touch; the technician rises at a wrong angle and attacks researchers.

VOSS
Evacuate Tower Seven.

Security opens fire. The feed dies as geometry gains new depths.

VOSS
All classified Eclipse material is now emergency-public.

OPERATIONS CHIEF
Chancellor?

VOSS
Everything. Dominion gets our combat telemetry. Neutral systems get medical data. Civil networks get breach protocols. Every authentication map relevant to propagation goes open.

TECHNICIAN
That includes Record 7283 annex materials.

VOSS
Release them.

Tharne looks at her: too late, still right.

VOSS
Move.

Crownwatch research floor stretches before engineering can reach severance relay. White-gold then violet swallows two engineers. Lyessa sees personnel trapped in the level.

LYESSA
Seal the level.

CROSS
We still have personnel inside.

LYESSA
I know. Seal it.

Doors close. Black spike penetrates them, fluid climbing toward the ceiling.

CROSS
Fall back.

Lyessa draws the sidearm that shot Tarrik and holsters it. She takes Egdredil from the rack.

CROWNWATCH OFFICER
Regent, evacuation is prepared.

LYESSA
For civilians.

CROWNWATCH OFFICER
You are Crown authority.

She tears off the regency mantle.

LYESSA
Today I'm a rifle. Move.

Black growth enters a temple corridor. Guards sever limbs with fire; Cinder soldiers burn the moving pieces. Civilians freeze at a blocked lift, recognizing the Regent.

LYESSA
Move. Stay low. Do not touch anything black, even if it looks dead.

CROSS
Cauldron has gone dark. Neon Veil city is reporting systemic corruption.

LYESSA
All of it.

CROSS
Yes.

LYESSA
I did this.

CROSS
We did.

LYESSA
Open targeting.

CROSS
To Reformation?

LYESSA
To everyone fighting the Eclipse.

CROSS
Civil networks? Glass Citadel?

LYESSA
Everything.

The cracked Aurelion mural speaks stolen voices, then Tarrik's perfect voice.

ECLIPSE IMITATING TARRIK (V.O.)
Lyessa.

CROSS
It isn't him.

Lyessa fires Egdredil through the painted King's face.

LYESSA
I know.

Cauldron Crownmark wakes beneath ash. Buried bones are drawn into moving tissue, not resurrected. Gate Nine opens; a Darek-like silhouette looks at camera.

ON SCREEN:
WALCUR, DAREK
CONFIDENCE: 94.2%

Feed dies. Neon Veil advertisements all become black.

ON SCREEN:
WE REMEMBER

Violet conduits spread beneath failing transit. Return to the living child outside Selene's torn transport.

112 INT./EXT. MESTRIA - DAMAGED EXILE TRANSPORT - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-27-CS03

Impact rolls the cabin. Cases become projectiles as overhead storage breaks. Rear seal opens; restraints shear. The mother cries toward the boy hanging outside, wrist caught in framework.

MOTHER
My son!

Selene releases her restraint, crawls against decompression and takes the boy's slipping wrist.

Selene drives her free palm into torn alloy. Frost detonates through the hull; water vapor crystallizes across the breach. Her hand freezes to metal. The opening narrows and pressure weakens. She pulls the boy through; his shoulder bends wrong and he screams. Selene drags him to his mother.

The view widens to reveal Mestria below: black tissue bends a tower; an infected defense carrier turns its point defense into the city.

PILOT
Outbound corridor lost. Diverting to North Civic Shelter Four.

The ship lands hard amid civilians. The boy remains with his mother and sister, alive and needing care. Selene's palm is bleeding. Security reaches the aircraft, recognizes her and sees the ice.

LOCAL OFFICER
You can still do that?

SELENE
Yes.

He points toward shelter arches. Something black-violet moves behind buildings.

LOCAL OFFICER
Good. We need you.

Selene steps onto the crowded municipal platform with empty hands.

113 INT./EXT. NORTH CIVIC SHELTER FOUR - PLAZA AND CORRIDOR - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-27-CS04

Medical stations overflow. Calm emergency instructions assign shelter zones that no longer exist. Black material spreads through the exterior corridor.

SELENE
Seal that passage.

LOCAL OFFICER
There are still people outside.

She reaches the window: infant in a woman's arms, three teenagers, elderly man, medical worker dragging a stretcher; shapes behind them. The memory of Gate Nine is carried in an immediate reaction.

SELENE
Keep it open.

LOCAL OFFICER
They'll breach.

SELENE
I know.

Frost gathers around her fingers.

SELENE
Keep it open.

Selene casts Stillfield across the approach. Temperature collapses: the first organism freezes at the legs and falls; the second slides into it. Security plasma tears bodies. The pieces keep crawling.

SELENE
Burn them.

Thermal cutters answer. Civilian groups cross under covering fire: the woman and infant arrive, then teenagers. The medical worker reaches the threshold while a tendril catches the stretcher and pulls it into the street. The officer waits for a close order. Selene gives none.

As the attack continues, a damaged civil-defense terminal opens Tharne's channel. Selene's cheek is bloodied; his face is exhausted.

THARNE
Voss opened everything.

SELENE
Good.

THARNE
Dominion did too.

Shelter shakes; dust falls.

SELENE
Tarrik?

THARNE
No confirmation.

She absorbs it and turns back to the evacuation.

SELENE
I need to go.

THARNE
So do I.

The channel fails. Something strikes from outside. Selene turns toward the doors with Frost gathering.

114 INT. CIVILIAN EVACUATION SHIP - CARGO BAY - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-27-CS05

A child quietly cries. Tarrik wakes expecting Crownwatch, then feels the ship move. Medical cots line cargo walls; civilians stare at forward broadcast. He tries to breathe and touches regenerative mesh over the shot.

Caelus, the refusal, Lyessa's gun and her face return as brief memory fragments. A medic reaches him.

MEDIC
Stay down.

TARRIK
Where are we?

MEDIC
Leaving Ianis.

TARRIK
Crownwatch?

MEDIC
Still transmitting.

TARRIK
Lyessa?

The medic hesitates.

MEDIC
Crown Regent.

Broadcast changes to Eclipse armadas through the Wound. Tarrik recognizes failure without needing an announcer's explanation.

TARRIK
Reformation?

MEDIC
Same situation.

TARRIK
Selene Veyne.

MEDIC
I don't know.

Beside the cot, dark cloth encloses Velkorran. Tarrik unwraps it. A physical strip tied beneath the grip carries Lyessa's handwriting.

ON SCREEN:
FOR ONCE, DO AS I ASK.
STAY GONE.
--L

No apology, explanation or usable channel. He folds and keeps it. A boy of perhaps eight sits on deck, dried blood on a sleeve that may not be his.

BOY
Are you a soldier?

Tarrik has no rank, no Emperor, no state protection. His state calls him traitor. He faces the child's question.

TARRIK
I don't know.

The boy accepts it. The ship shudders; lights flicker. Stay with Tarrik, low in the cot and limited by his injuries.

115 INT./EXT. EVACUATION CARGO BAY / REACH AND AURELION - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-27-CS06

SHIP CREW
Primary evacuation vector is gone.

PILOT
Alternate?

SHIP CREW
Trying.

Another city turns violet on the broadcast. Tarrik grips Velkorran and tries to sit. Medic presses him back.

MEDIC
You tear that seal and you die.

TARRIK
Maybe.

MEDIC
That is not medically useful.

He almost smiles at a precision Selene would appreciate. Sensors sound.

ON SCREEN:
UNKNOWN VESSEL GROUP DETECTED

PILOT
Transponders?

SHIP CREW
None.

PILOT
Dominion profile?

SHIP CREW
No.

PILOT
Reformation?

SHIP CREW
No.

White-gold drive signatures resolve in disciplined ancient-looking formation.

ON SCREEN:
CIVILIAN VESSEL, HOLD VECTOR.
SAFE CORRIDOR AVAILABLE.

PILOT
Identify.

Silence, then the answer without a name.

ON SCREEN:
HOLD VECTOR.
WE WILL BRING YOU THROUGH.

BOY
Are they good?

Tarrik remembers Caelus's love, Lyessa's love, Selene's independence and the King's costly choice. No single uniform answers the child.

TARRIK
I don't know.

The boy nods. Against medical protest, Tarrik closes his hand around Velkorran and stands painfully. Cut to black.

At Aurelion the largest vessel-like organism emerges, carrying structures like ruined cities. Joint lances and warheads break frigate-sized pieces but cannot stop it. An unauthenticated signal enters every open channel. The voice is assembled from Lyric's captured recordings, too clean to be the living woman.

ECLIPSE IMITATING LYRIC (V.O.)
Hello, civilization.

Dead soldiers, civilians, children, Caelus and Darek layer into the voice until language disappears. Then silence. This is stolen identity, not evidence of resurrection.

Maps still draw crimson, blue and white borders. Cauldron turns violet, Neon Veil follows, Mestria and outer settlements disappear beneath multiplying distress. Old enemies exchange firing coordinates. Show Selene still defending her passage; no reunion with Tarrik.

ON SCREEN:
SOVEREIGN CONTAINMENT: LOST

Violet learns the shapes of the final letters before display goes black. Eclipse armadas enter the Reach. Fade into Molahs.

EPILOGUE

116 INT. MOLAHS - PEARL HALLS AND CRADLE CHAMBER - CONTINUOUS
SCOR-EPI-CS01

Soft light moves soundlessly through pearl halls. A breeze stirs an empty corridor toward concentric rings veined gold. Frost coats the central glass.

UNSEEN VOICE (V.O.)
Alethia...

Golden channels brighten one by one. A distant signal, not another voice, answers through the ancient structure.

ON SCREEN:
SOVEREIGN CONTAINMENT: LOST

All light stills for a moment.

UNSEEN VOICE (V.O.)
The door is open.

A hiss breaks four centuries of silence. Alternate rings turn in opposite directions, seams widening patiently. Cold vapor reveals a single cradle. White armor traced with dormant gold has neither Dominion nor Reformation insignia. Chocolate-brown skin, close gray hair, short gray beard; a face older than any preserved portrait.

One finger moves, then another. His chest rises. First breath catches; second deepens. Gold wakes along wrist, chest and throat. Eyes open slowly, then focus.

GOOD KING
Alethia...

The answering voice changes, quieter, almost relieved.

ALETHIA
I am here.

He receives information without spoken exposition. Recognition becomes disbelief, then grief. Across Molahs ancient sensors wake toward failing stars. He closes his eyes and looks very old, never weak.

GOOD KING
My children...

His eyes open. Grief stays as purpose rises. He looks toward the chamber door and the Reach beyond it.

GOOD KING
What have you done?

Hold the face, then cut to black.